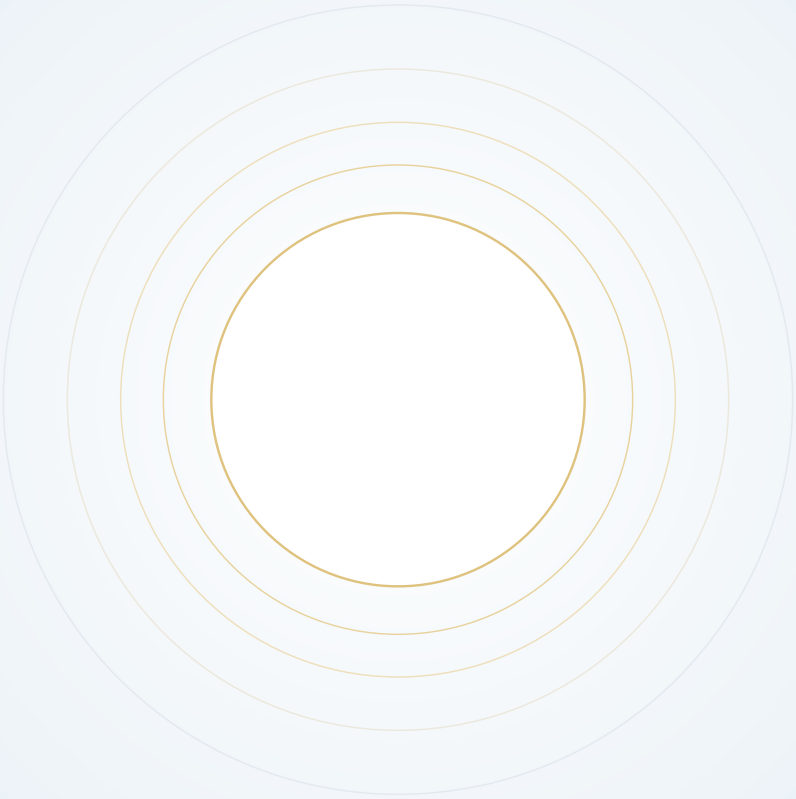


The White Sun of Melancholy

Sympathocracy, Sacrifice, and the Holding Environment in Ari Aster's Midsommar

Nov 10, 2026
@ertertwert

But hold me fast, and fear me not,
I am your bairn's father.

— "Tam Lin" (Child 39A)

Ma seule Étoile est morte, — et mon luth constellé
Porte le Soleil noir de la Mélancolie.

— Gérard de Nerval, "El Desdichado" (1854)

Abstract

This dissertation advances a unified theory of Ari Aster's *Midsommar* (2019) as a philosophical fiction concerning the conditions under which a human being can be held, and the price that total holding exacts. Against the two interpretive paradigms that have dominated the film's reception—an *emancipatory* reading, in which Dani Ardor's closing smile consummates her liberation from a negligent partner, and a *captivity* reading, in which the same smile seals her absorption by a predatory cult—it argues that the smile is neither liberation nor capture but an *equation*: the visible identity of two operations that the film discloses as one when viewed from opposite sides, being held and being burned. The social form that performs this equation is theorized as the *sacrificial holding environment*, a term adapted from D. W. Winnicott's account of the maternal ambience that permits an infant to go on being; its political constitution is theorized as *sympathocracy*: government by compulsory fellow-feeling, whose founding institution is the mirroring chorus, whose temporal architecture is the cycle, whose fiscal base is periodic sacrificial expenditure, and whose ideology is the promise—articulated with diagnostic exactitude in Pelle's question whether Dani feels "held"—that no grief need ever again be borne alone.

The argument unfolds across eight chapters. Chapter One establishes the problem of the held subject: it reads the prologue as a winter's tale in the Shakespearean sense, isolates the formal rhyme between Dani's unanswered wail in her partner's arms and her mirrored wail among the Hårga women (a distinction theorized as *somatic* versus *phonic* holding), and maps the film's two framing deaths—a familicidal suicide in an American winter and a ritual senicide at a Swedish cliff—onto Émile Durkheim's poles of egoistic and altruistic suicide. Chapter Two reconstructs the northern archive from which the Hårga is assembled—the *Hávamál*, Adam of Bremen's account of the nine-yearly sacrifices at Uppsala, Snorri's *Ynglinga saga*, *Gautreks saga* and the antiquarian invention of the ättestupa, the Hälsingland legend of the Hårga dance, Swedish Gothicism from Rudbeck to Geijer, the museology of Skansen, Carl Larsson's

Midvinterblot, and the eugenic underside of the Swedish *folkhem*—and argues that the commune is a Gothicist palimpsest whose invented numerology converges uncannily on the Uppsala record. Chapter Three analyzes the film's formal grammar of *Apollonian dread*—prolepsis, symmetry, inversion, and daylight horror—in dialogue with Bergman, Tarkovsky, Parajanov, Kubrick, and Powell and Pressburger. Chapter Four situates the Hårga within the theory of sacrifice (Frazer, Hubert and Mauss, Girard, Bataille), the gift (Mauss), hospitality (Derrida, Benveniste), and immunity (Esposito, Agamben), and against *The Wicker Man*, Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery," and Ursula K. Le Guin's Omelas. Chapter Five theorizes the mirroring chorus through the anthropology of ritual lament (Alexiou, Seremetakis, Loraux, Rosaldo), the phenomenology of fellow-feeling (Scheler, Stein), Canetti's lamenting pack, Adorno and Horkheimer's organized mimesis, Sontag's fascinating fascism, and Plessner's critique of communal radicalism. Chapter Six reads the film's gender politics as an inversion of sacral kingship through the *Bacchae*, *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, *Miss Julie*, the ballad of Tam Lin, Graves, Neumann, Creed, Clover, and Pastoureau's history of the bear as a dethroned king. Chapter Seven examines the fate of the ethnographers through Fabian's denial of coevalness, MacCannell's staged authenticity, Benjamin's aura, the hermeneutics of the oracle, and Weber's *sacrificium intellectus*, here literalized as a body count. Chapter Eight synthesizes the argument as a theory of the *white sun of melancholy*: mourning deprived of its night, which turns, as Freud and Klein predicted of melancholia, into manic triumph, and which the film stages as *euphoric anagnorisis*—the inversion of tragic recognition into joyful capitulation that links *Midsommar* to Lovecraft's "The Shadow over Innsmouth," *Rosemary's Baby*, *The Witch*, and Aster's own *Hereditary*.

The dissertation's original contribution lies in four claims: that *Midsommar* stages, with sociological precision, the late-modern loss of any middle term between unheld isolation and devouring belonging; that the Hårga's central technology is not violence but organized mimesis, which abolishes the distance on which genuine sympathy depends; that total holding is structurally financed by the destruction of what cannot be mirrored—the outsider, the intellect, the voiceless victim; and that the film conscripts its spectators into the community it depicts, as a mirroring chorus and as decoding elders, performing upon its audience the operation it represents. These claims converge on a single formula: *in the economy of total belonging, to be held is to let fall.*

Contents

CHAPTER ONE 9

The Problem of the Held Subject

Prolegomena to a Theory of the Sacrificial Holding Environment

1.1 The Smile as Crux 9
1.2 Strata of the Corpus: *Commission, Graft, and Paratext* 12
1.3 Method I: *Comparative Mythopoetics and the Strata of the Archive* 14
1.4 Method II: *Reading like an Elder* 16
1.5 A Winter's Tale: *The Prologue and the Unmirrored Wail* 18
1.6 Durkheim's Diptych: *The Two Deaths That Frame the Film* 23
1.7 "Held": *Winnicott, Pelle's Question, and the Phenomenology of Holding* 27
1.8 The Collapse of Holding in Late Modernity 30
1.9 Five Propositions and a Formula 32
1.10 Architecture of the Dissertation 34
1.11 Conventions 36

CHAPTER TWO 39

Nine Days at Uppsala

The Northern Archive of Sacrifice and the Hårga as Gothicist Palimpsest

2.1 The Archive and Its Archons 39
2.2 Myself to Myself: *Odin's Tree and the Economy of Runes* 41
2.3 The Golden Temple: *Adam of Bremen and the Arithmetic of Nine* 43
2.4 The Family Cliff: *Gautreks Saga, Verelius, and the Invention of the Ättestupa* 47
2.5 The Dance on Hårga Hill: *The Devil's Fiddler, the Maypole, and the Chosen One* 49
2.6 Atlantis at Uppsala: *Gothicism from Johannes Magnus to Bayreuth* 51
2.7 The Chooser of the Slain: *Brynhildr, the Drink of Forgetting, and the Burning Hall* 53
2.8 The Museum of the Folk: *Skansen, Larsson, and the Painted Farmhouse* 55
2.9 The People's Home and Its Shadow: *Breeding, Runes, and the Politics of the North* 57
2.10 Conclusion: *Tradition as the Most Modern Artifact* 59

CHAPTER THREE 63

Apollonian Dread

The Formal Grammar of Daylight Horror

3.1 Apollo Ascendant: *Inverting* The Birth of Tragedy 63
3.2 No Night There: *Daylight Horror and the Politics of Visibility* 65
3.3 The Painted Prophecy: *Prolepsis, Mise en Abyme, and the Commune as Metteur en Scène* 67
3.4 The Tyranny of the Center: *Symmetry, Frontality, and Composition as Capture* 69
3.5 The World Upside Down: *Inversion as the Film's Master Figure* 71
3.6 The Breathing World: *Hallucination, Flowers, and the Visible Holding Environment* 72
3.7 The Chorus as Spectator: *Body Genres, Laughter, and the Distribution of Sympathy* 74
3.8 The Burning Woman and the Watching Woman: *Dreyer, Bergman, and the Final Close-up* 75
3.9 Tarkovsky's Fire: *Sacrifice, Beauty, and the Aesthetic Justification of the World* 77
3.10 Conclusion: *Form as Holding Environment* 79

CHAPTER FOUR 81

The Accursed Share in the Sunlit Field

Sacrifice, Gift, Hospitality, Immunity

4.1 Gift, Poison, Pharmakon: *The Welcome Cup* 81
4.2 The Scapegoat's Season: *Frazer, Balder's Fires, and the Beltane Lot* 83
4.3 The Machinery of Consecration: *Hubert and Mauss, Robertson Smith, and the Primal Meal* 85
4.4 Unanimity Minus One: *Girard and the Name of the Victim* 87
4.5 The Accursed Share in the Sunlit Field: *Bataille's Solar Economy* 88
4.6 The Gift That Must Be Returned: *Mauss and the Price of Belonging* 90
4.7 Hostipitality: *The Guest as Hostage* 92
4.8 Communitas and Immunitas: *The Vaccinated Community* 94
4.9 Omelas in Midsummer: *Jackson, Le Guin, and the One Who Walks Toward* 96
4.10 Conclusion: *The Price of Holding* 98

CHAPTER FIVE 101

The Organized Mimesis of Grief

Lament, Fellow-Feeling, and the Mirroring Chorus

5.1 The Chorus at the Center: *Toward a Definition of Sympathocracy* 101
5.2 "Each for Her Own Sorrows": *Ritual Lament from Homer to the Mani* 103
5.3 Unison and Concord: *Hume, Smith, Scheler, and Stein* 105
5.4 The Lamenting Pack: *Canetti, Synchrony, and the Body in Time* 107
5.5 Organized Mimesis: *Adorno, Horkheimer, Freud, and the Mass Ornament* 109
5.6 Fascinating Community: *Sontag, Riefenstahl, and the Thing Theater* 111
5.7 The Ethics of Distance: *Plessner, Arendt, and Sennett* 112
5.8 Grievability: *Balder's Mourners and the Voice That Cannot Be Mirrored* 114
5.9 Sympathocracy: *A Political Theory of the Chorus* 116
5.10 Conclusion: *Against Unison* 117

CHAPTER SIX 119

The Bear, the Queen, and the Fool

Gender, Desire, and the Inversion of Sacral Kingship

6.1 Hold Me Fast: *Tam Lin and the Woman Who Lets Fall* 119
6.2 The Goddess and Her Consort: *Inanna, Freyr, and the Dying God* 121
6.3 The Furies Unappeased: *Bachofen's Oresteia in Reverse* 123
6.4 The Midsummer Bride and the Queen's Two Bodies 124
6.5 The Bear: *Pastoureau's Fallen King* 125
6.6 The Fool in the May Games: *Howie, Christian, and Bottom* 127
6.7 Agave, Electra, Medea: *Tragedy's Women and the Burning House* 128
6.8 Midsummer Night in Strindberg's Kitchen: *Miss Julie and The Father* 130
6.9 The Final Girl Crowned: *Neumann, Creed, Clover, and the Politics of Revenge* 132
6.10 Conclusion: *Sovereignty as Instrument* 134

CHAPTER SEVEN 137

Ethnographers Devoured

Anthropology, Aura, and the Hermeneutics of the Oracle

7.1 The Thesis and the Fire: *Anthropologists in the Field* 137
7.2 Allochronism: *Fabian and the Denial of Coevalness* 138
7.3 Reading over the Shoulder: *Malinowski, Geertz, and the Forbidden Text* 140
7.4 The Aura and the Camera: *Benjamin's Rubi Radr* 142
7.5 The Oracle: *Delphi, Plato, and the Interpreters of Unreason* 143
7.6 The Seer's Wound: *Incest, Disability, and the Sacred* 145
7.7 The Old Gods Rise: *Weber and the Sacrifice of the Intellect* 146
7.8 The Positioned Subject: *Grief and the Only Ethnographer Who Understood* 148
7.9 Ethnographic Horror: *Cannibal Holocaust, The Ritual, and the Forbidden Book* 149
7.10 The Scholar's Capital: *Bourdieu and the Economy of the Thesis* 151
7.11 Conclusion: *The Spectator as Elder* 152

CHAPTER EIGHT 155

The White Sun

Toward a Theory of the Sacrificial Holding Environment

8.1 The Black Sun and the White: *Nerval, Dürer, Kristeva* 155
8.2 Mourning and Melancholia: *The Shadow of the Object* 157
8.3 The Manic Defense: *Klein, Segal, and the Counterfeit of Reparation* 159
8.4 Mouths Without Words: *Abraham, Torok, and the Crypt of the Chorus* 161
8.5 Euphoric Anagnorisis: *Innsmouth, Rosemary, Thomasin, and the Crowned* 162
8.6 The Great Noon: *Nietzsche's Circle and the Counterfeit Yes* 164
8.7 The Smile as Equation: *Reading the Last Shot* 165
8.8 Conscription: *The Spectator's Smile* 167
8.9 The Missing Middle: *Toward an Ethics of Holding* 168
8.10 Conclusion: *The Ninth* 170

Works Cited 174

Keywords 184



CHAPTER ONE

The Problem of the Held Subject

Prolegomena to a Theory of the Sacrificial Holding Environment

A sad tale's best for winter.

— Mamillius, *The Winter's Tale* (2.1.25)

1.1

The Smile as Crux

Every film that ends on a face bequeaths its interpreters an ultimatum. The closing image of *Midsommar*—Dani Ardor, swaddled in a gown of blossoms whose petals appear to respire, watching a yellow A-framed temple burn with nine bodies inside it, among them the man she has loved for four years, her expression passing through horror, grief, and something like vertigo before resolving into a smile—has become the hinge on which the film's reception turns. Two readings have congealed around it. The first, which may be called *emancipatory*, construes the smile as the terminus of a narrative of self-recovery: a woman whose grief has been managed, minimized, and resented by a partner incapable of intimacy is at last seen, heard, and valued by a community that mirrors her pain, and her final act—designating that partner as the ninth offering—is read as decisive severance, the breakup the relationship had been too inert to perform for itself. Aster's paratexts lend this reading a measure of authorial sanction: he has repeatedly described the film as a breakup film wearing the costume of folk horror, and his widely circulated

quip that it is a *Wizard of Oz* for perverts frames the ending as perverse wish-fulfilment rather than catastrophe. The second reading, which may be called *captivity*, construes the same smile as the completion of an indoctrination. Isolated, drugged, deprived of darkness by an unsetting sun, and progressively severed from every tie to her former world, Dani has been groomed by a community that selected her as precisely the subject—bereaved, unheld, starving for belonging—whom a high-control group can most efficiently absorb; the smile is the smile of the convert, and the film is a tragedy disguised as a romance.

Both readings are accurate about what they see, and both are mistaken about what the smile is. The emancipatory reading cannot account for the price. It must either suppress the eight other lives in the temple—among them two commune members whose fear-numbing draught visibly fails, so that they burn screaming—or incorporate them as acceptable collateral to a woman's recovery, a move that reproduces at the level of interpretation the sacrificial arithmetic it purports to celebrate. The captivity reading cannot account for the truth of the cure. It must suppose that the commune's mirroring of Dani's grief is merely instrumental, a manipulative technique masquerading as care, when the film takes considerable pains to show that the care is real, that the holding holds, and that what Dani receives among the wailing women is something no institution of her former life—not her family, not her partner, not the therapist whom Christian's friends invoke as the proper receptacle of her pain—could give. To read the smile as either liberation or capture is to split the film's culminating image along a seam the film itself refuses to recognize.

The thesis of this dissertation is that the smile must be read as an *equation*: the visible identity of two operations that, from inside the community, are one. Dani is held at the precise moment, and by the precise means, that Christian is burned. Her holding is not purchased with his burning as with a separable currency; it *is* his burning, experienced from the side of the held. The heroine's surname registers the identity at the level of the name. *Ardor* is the Latin for flame, heat, the burning of fever and the burning of passion; she is, from her first appearance, the one who burns, and the film's question is only who will be consumed in the fire she carries.

This identity is not a paradox into which the film stumbles. It is the structural principle of the community Aster invents—the Hårga, a commune in the Swedish province of Hälsingland observing a nine-day festival

that recurs once every ninety years—and, this dissertation will argue, the structural principle of a family of social forms that the late-modern imagination has learned to desire. I call that form the *sacrificial holding environment*, adapting the term by which D. W. Winnicott designated the total ambience of physical and psychological support through which a mother enables an infant to go on being (Winnicott 1960). The Hårga is a holding environment raised to the scale of a polity and extended across the whole span of a life, from the cradle to the cliff. Its constitution I call *sympathocracy*: government by compulsory fellow-feeling, a regime in which affect is not privately undergone and publicly expressed but collectively produced, distributed, and administered. Its economy, finally, is sacrificial in the strict sense elaborated by Henri Hubert and Marcel Mauss, by René Girard, and above all by Georges Bataille: the community's capacity to hold everything is financed by the periodic destruction of what cannot be held—the outsider, the unmirrorable, the intellect that insists on standing apart in order to see (Hubert and Mauss [1899] 1964; Girard [1972] 1977; Bataille [1949] 1988).

The chapters that follow test this thesis against an archive deliberately vast: Old Norse poetry and saga; Adam of Bremen's eleventh-century account of the nine-yearly sacrifices at Uppsala; Durkheim's taxonomy of suicide; the Child ballads; Euripides, Shakespeare, Strindberg, and Gogol; Frazer, Graves, and the mythographers of the dying king; Winnicott, Klein, and Kristeva; Weber, Adorno, Horkheimer, and Benjamin; Scheler and Canetti on the phenomenology of fellow-feeling and the anthropology of the lament; Esposito on community and immunity; the folk-horror canon from *The Wicker Man* to *The Witch*; the Swedish national-romantic archive from Olof Rudbeck to Carl Larsson; and the cinema of Ingmar Bergman, Andrei Tarkovsky, and Sergei Parajanov. The breadth is not ornamental. A film whose community claims an antiquity it does not possess, whose scripture is still being written, and whose rites are a bricolage of authentic folklore, antiquarian fantasy, and outright invention demands a method adequate to bricolage: one capable of tracking a motif through its sources, its misreadings, and its reinventions without mistaking any single genealogy for the meaning of the whole.

1.2

Strata of the Corpus

Commission, Graft, and Paratext

Midsommar, released in North America by A24 in July 2019 and produced by Aster's company Square Peg with the Swedish firm B-Reel Films, exists in two authorized states: a theatrical cut of approximately 147 minutes and a director's cut of approximately 171 minutes, which restores material elaborating both the couple's deterioration and the ritual calendar of the festival. Where the versions diverge in ways relevant to the argument, the director's cut is treated as the fuller articulation of the film's system, the theatrical cut as the version through which the film acquired its public life. The film was shot not in Sweden but on a set constructed outside Budapest; its production designer, the Swede Henrik Svensson, built the Hårga's halls, murals, runic garments, and painted interiors from an amalgam of Scandinavian vernacular sources and invention; its composer, Bobby Krlic, records as The Haxan Cloak, a name borrowed from Benjamin Christensen's *Häxan* (1922), the Swedish-Danish pseudo-documentary on witchcraft that stands at the head of the Scandinavian cinema of the occult. These facts matter less as production lore than as evidence of the film's constitutive hybridity. The Hårga is an artifact assembled in Hungary out of Swedish materials by a Swedish designer for an American director, and its authenticity is from the outset a composite—an effect of design rather than a residue of tradition. The film thereby reproduces in its making the condition this dissertation identifies in its fiction: the Hårga is not a survival but a construction, a living palimpsest in which the claim to antiquity is one of the community's most carefully maintained artifacts.

The film's origin is a graft. By Aster's account, B-Reel approached him to direct a folk-horror film set in Sweden, a proposal he accepted only once he found a way to attach it to a personal subject—the end of a relationship—so that the genre premise became the costume of a breakup narrative. The graft remains legible in the finished work as a double register that never fully fuses: on one side, an anthropological horror plot concerned with ritual, sacrifice, and the epistemology of the outsider; on the other, a domestic melodrama concerned with emotional labor, resent-

ment, gaslighting, and the unspeakable inertia that keeps a dying relationship alive. The film's originality lies in its discovery that these registers are not merely juxtaposed but isomorphic—that breakup and sacrifice are the same structure at different scales. The couple is a holding environment that has failed; the commune is a holding environment that cannot fail; and the transfer of Dani from the one to the other requires, as the condition of its completion, the destruction of the residue of the first.

Aster's paratextual pronouncements—interviews, festival discussions, promotional statements—are treated here in the sense Gérard Genette gave to the paratext: as a threshold zone of transaction between a text and its public, authoritative as evidence of how the work was framed but not as a limit on what it can mean (Genette [1987] 1997). The dissertation neither commits the intentional fallacy, in W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley's sense, of treating authorial statements as the measure of meaning (Wimsatt and Beardsley 1946), nor indulges the opposite error of ignoring them; it reads them as one more stratum of the corpus, frequently illuminating and occasionally symptomatic. The *Wizard of Oz* comparison is illuminating precisely in its incompleteness. Dorothy travels from a monochrome Kansas to a Technicolor Oz and spends Victor Fleming's film (1939) trying to return; Dani travels from a blue-black American winter to a saturated Swedish summer and spends Aster's film discovering that there is nothing to return to. The structural rhyme is real—a bereaved, unhoused young woman; male companions each defined by a lack (of heart, of courage, of any sense of the sacred); a destination whose wonder is inseparable from its menace; a curtain behind which the truth of power is concealed—but *Midsommar* reverses Fleming's moral. "There's no place like home" becomes the discovery that home is a place one can be given, at a price.

A further stratum is Aster's oeuvre, which reveals *Midsommar* as the second panel of a sustained inquiry into grief, family, and engineered destiny. *Hereditary* (2018) follows a family destroyed by inherited illness and catastrophic loss, every misfortune of which proves in the final reel to have been orchestrated by a cult, and it closes on a coronation: the possessed son crowned as the demon-king Paimon before a kneeling congregation. *Midsommar* closes on a coronation too—the flower-crowned May Queen enthroned before her burning lover and her new family—and in both films the coronation is the terminus of a grief that a hidden collective has cultivated, channeled, and finally harvested. *Beau Is Afraid* (2023), whose pro-

tagonist's entire life proves to have been staged and surveilled by an engulfing mother, and *Eddington* (2025), set in a New Mexico town fracturing under the paranoias of the pandemic summer of 2020, extend the inquiry into the totalizing mother and the absorptive collective. Across the corpus, Aster's question remains constant: what becomes of a self that has never been adequately held, when a power appears that offers to hold it absolutely?

◉

1.3

Method I

Comparative Mythopoetics and the Strata of the Archive

The method of this dissertation is *comparative mythopoetics*: the analysis of how a contemporary fiction composes its myth from heterogeneous sources, and of what that composition reveals about the desires of the culture that receives it. It shares with the history of religions the conviction that myths and rites are intelligible only within systems of transformation—a conviction articulated in different idioms by Mircea Eliade's morphology of the sacred (Eliade [1949] 1958), Claude Lévi-Strauss's definition of a myth as the totality of its variants (Lévi-Strauss 1955), and Carlo Ginzburg's historical morphology of the witches' sabbath (Ginzburg [1989] 1991). It departs from all three in its object, which is not a myth transmitted by tradition but a myth fabricated for a film, and in its consequent attention to the fabricating apparatus: the antiquarian scholarship, national-romantic iconography, genre conventions, and psychoanalytic and sociological theories through which the materials of northern European religion reach the twenty-first century already interpreted.

The point governs the dissertation's relation to its sources. There is no unmediated access to the religion of pre-Christian Scandinavia. What survives is a body of texts almost all of which were written down by Christians, generations or centuries after conversion, for purposes of their own: the mythological and heroic poems of the Codex Regius, the prose of Snorri Sturluson, the ecclesiastical polemic of Adam of Bremen, the sagas of kings and Icelanders. Upon this textual stratum lies a second, of early modern antiquarianism: Swedish Gothicism, which reached its delirious

apex in Olof Rudbeck's *Atlantica* (1679–1702), a multi-volume demonstration that Sweden was the lost Atlantis and the cradle of civilization. Upon this lies a third, of nineteenth- and early twentieth-century national romanticism, folkloristics, and comparative mythology: Erik Gustaf Geijer and the Gothic Society (*Götiska förbundet*, 1811); Artur Hazelius's open-air museum at Skansen (1891), in which rural Sweden was reassembled, costumed, and staged for urban spectators; and James George Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (1890; third edition 1906–15), whose volumes on the fire festivals of Europe made the Midsummer bonfire an emblem of vestigial human sacrifice. In a darker key, the same stratum includes the völkisch rune-mysticism inaugurated by Guido von List's *Das Geheimnis der Runen* (1908) and absorbed into National Socialist iconography. A fourth stratum is constituted by the twentieth-century theory of religion and society that supplies the very vocabulary through which educated audiences now perceive "pagan" ritual: Durkheim's collective effervescence, van Gennep's rites of passage, Turner's liminality, Girard's scapegoat, Bataille's sacred expenditure. A fifth, finally, is the genre of folk horror itself, whose conventions Adam Scovell has formalized as a "folk horror chain" running from landscape, through isolation and skewed belief and morality, to a culminating happening or summoning (Scovell 2017).

Midsommar draws on all five strata at once and declines to distinguish among them. Its ättestupa—the cliff from which the commune's elders leap at seventy-two—is simultaneously an echo of a comic episode in the Old Norse *Gautreks saga*, in which a miserly family disposes of its members from a "family cliff"; an early modern antiquarian fantasy of systematic Nordic senicide, whose historicity modern scholarship does not accept; an instance of what Durkheim classified as obligatory altruistic suicide; and a folk-horror set-piece. Its sacrificial temple is at once Adam of Bremen's gilded temple at Uppsala; the wicker colossus in which, according to Caesar (*De bello Gallico* 6.16) and Strabo (*Geography* 4.4.5), the Gauls burned men and animals together; Frazer's Midsummer fires; the house in which, according to Snorri's *Ynglinga saga*, the Swedes burned King Óláfr trételgja as an offering to Odin for good harvests; and the effigy of Robin Hardy's *The Wicker Man* (1973). The method such an object requires cannot be source criticism in the philological sense, which would seek to establish what Aster read, nor iconography in the art-historical sense, which would seek a stable code. It must be a method of *convergence*, attentive to how

motifs from incommensurable strata are made to cohere in a single image, and to what that coherence accomplishes.

An example establishes the method's protocol. The Hårga's festival lasts nine days and requires nine lives; its members die at seventy-two, the terminus of four eighteen-year seasons. Adam of Bremen's account of the temple at Uppsala (*Gesta Hammaburgensis ecclesiae pontificum* IV.26–27, with its scholia) describes a festival common to all the Swedish provinces, held every nine years, at which nine males of every living kind were offered and their bodies hung in the sacred grove beside the temple, dogs and horses among the men; a Christian informant, Adam reports, claimed to have seen seventy-two bodies hanging there, and an appended scholion specifies that the rites continued for nine days, a man offered each day alongside other creatures, so that seventy-two victims were made in all. The dissertation does not claim that Aster derived the Hårga's arithmetic from Adam's scholia. It claims something at once weaker and more consequential: that the film's invented numerology falls, whether by design or by the gravitational pull of the archive, into an orbit already traced by the most influential surviving account of Swedish pagan sacrifice—and that this convergence is part of what makes the Hårga feel, to audiences who have never read Adam of Bremen, uncannily old. The *effect* of antiquity is produced not by the citation of sources but by the resonance of structures, and it is that effect, and its uses, that comparative mythopoetics undertakes to describe.

◉

1.4

Method II

Reading like an Elder

A second methodological problem is internal to the film and in some respects more acute. *Midsommar* is an exceptionally dense text, structured by prolepsis, saturated with images that foretell its events, and populated by an interpretive community whose central religious practice is the reading of an obscure text. The film opens on a painted folk panorama, executed in the idiom of Scandinavian vernacular painting, that narrates in advance and in compressed allegorical form the story we are about to watch: the

darkness of the bereaved household, the journey, the sunlit commune, the coronation, the fire. Within the diegesis, the Hårga's walls, tapestries, and garments are inscribed with runes and pictures anticipating what will befall the visitors; a mural in the dining hall depicts the love magic that will be worked upon Christian; and the commune's sacred book, the *Rubi Radr*, is a continuously expanding scripture composed by an oracle deliberately bred through incest so as to be, in the commune's account, unclouded by ordinary cognition, and interpreted by elders who translate his marks into doctrine.

A film so constituted solicits a particular kind of spectator: one who reads every image as a clue, every rune as a code, every painting as a prophecy. It solicits, that is, the hermeneutic posture of the Hårga elders themselves. The spectator of *Midsommar* is invited to treat the film as a *Rubi Radr*—an oracular text whose surface obscurity conceals a total and already-written plan—and much of the film's reception, including an extensive culture of frame-by-frame decoding, has accepted the invitation. The result is a methodological hazard. The evidential paradigm that Carlo Ginzburg traced from Giovanni Morelli's attributions through Sherlock Holmes to Freud—the practice of reading involuntary details as symptoms of a hidden truth (Ginzburg 1989)—becomes, when applied to a text that has deliberately planted its details, a form of complicity. The hermetic drift that Umberto Eco diagnosed in overinterpretation, the slide from resemblance to resemblance until everything signifies everything (Eco 1992), is not merely a risk the interpreter of *Midsommar* runs but a pleasure the film actively cultivates. Its world is one in which patterns are real, in which the visitors' dismissal of omens is fatal, and in which apophenia—the perception of meaningful connection among unrelated data—is not a cognitive error but the correct epistemic stance. The film punishes the skeptic and rewards the decoder.

This dissertation responds to the hazard not by refusing to decode but by making the act of decoding part of its object. Paul Ricoeur distinguished a hermeneutics of suspicion, exemplified by the "masters of suspicion" Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud, which reads manifest meaning as the disguise of latent forces, from a hermeneutics of faith, which reads in order to receive a meaning offered; and he imagined, beyond critique, a "second naïveté" in which the interpreter, having passed through suspicion, might again hear the symbol speak (Ricoeur [1960] 1967; [1965]

1970). Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, drawing on Melanie Klein, recast the distinction as one between *paranoid* reading—anticipatory, totalizing, bent on exposure, structurally akin to Klein's paranoid-schizoid position—and *reparative* reading, which, like Klein's depressive position, assembles the fragments of an ambivalent object into a whole capable of sustaining the reader (Sedgwick 2003). *Midsommar* dramatizes both. The visitors' failure is a failure of paranoid reading: they do not suspect enough, or they suspect too late. Dani's salvation is a triumph of reparative reading: she is assembled, and assembles herself, into a whole by a community that offers her a sustaining object.

The film's final image, however, reveals that reparation as inseparable from sacrifice, and thereby exposes what the Sedgwickian schema leaves unexamined: that the reparative may itself possess a sacrificial structure, that the object which sustains me may be assembled from what has been destroyed for my sake. Klein and her successors distinguished genuine reparation from its manic counterfeit, which repairs the object in a spirit of triumph, control, and contempt that denies the damage done (Klein 1940; Segal 1964). Whether Dani's smile is reparative or manic is the burden of the concluding chapter; here it suffices to observe that the question cannot be decided by a method that is either simply paranoid or simply reparative. The dissertation therefore adopts what may be called a *sacrificial hermeneutics*: one that reads the film's patterns as real while asking, at every turn, what each pattern costs and who is made to bear the cost. The interpreter of *Midsommar* cannot help reading like an elder; the obligation is to remember, while doing so, what the elders' readings are for.

◉

1.5

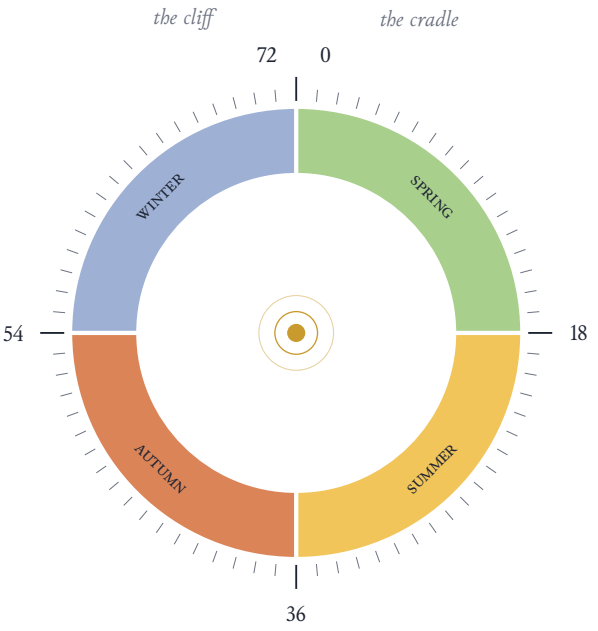
A Winter's Tale

The Prologue and the Unmirrored Wail

"A sad tale's best for winter," says the doomed child Mamillius, and Shakespeare's late romance offers a more exact structural template for *Midsommar* than any horror film. *The Winter's Tale* divides into a wintry Sicilian

tragedy of jealousy and death—Leontes's paranoia destroys his son, apparently destroys his wife, and casts out his infant daughter—and a pastoral Bohemian comedy set sixteen years later at a sheep-shearing festival, presided over by the lost daughter Perdita, dressed as Flora and installed as the feast's queen, who distributes flowers according to the ages of her guests: rosemary and rue, which keep their savor through winter, for the old; for the middle-aged, the flowers "of middle summer," which, she observes, "are given / To men of middle age" (4.4.107–108); for the young, a lament that the flowers of spring are absent. The play closes in a chapel where Paulina, the ritual mistress of Leontes's long mourning, brings a statue to life and returns the dead queen to her husband. *Midsommar* reproduces the play's diptych—a winter of grief, then a summer festival with a flower-crowned queen—and its floral calendar of ages, which the Hårga have systematized into Pelle's doctrine of the four eighteen-year seasons of life: spring to eighteen, summer to thirty-six, autumn to fifty-four, winter to seventy-two. But it inverts the denouement. Shakespeare's romance restores the dead; Aster's replaces them. The office of Paulina passes to Siv, the Hårga's matriarch and ritual director, but the miracle she administers is not resurrection but substitution. Dani does not recover her family; she is given another.

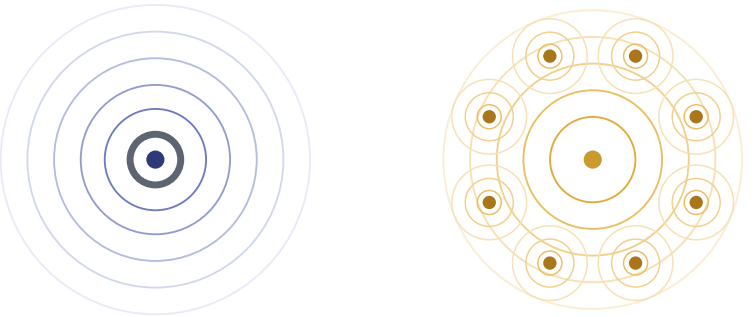
The prologue in which Dani loses the first family establishes the film's governing opposition with a formal economy that criticism has largely overlooked. Its opening minutes are organized around remote, mediated, and failed contact. Dani, in a dark apartment in an unnamed American city in the depth of winter, receives a cryptic and alarming email from her sister Terri, whose bipolar illness the film establishes; she cannot reach her sister or her parents by telephone; she calls Christian, who is out with his friends, and her fear of burdening him is audible in every hesitation. The friends, meanwhile, in a restaurant scene that functions as an informal tribunal, press Christian to end the relationship and propose, in effect, that Dani's needs belong to the professional market of therapy rather than to him. The sequence culminates in the revelation, conveyed through slow, gliding camera movements in a silent suburban house, that Terri has killed herself and both parents with car exhaust piped into the home. It then cuts to the scene that will rhyme, across the whole duration of the film, with its emotional climax: Dani, having received the news, collapses into Christian's arms and emits a wail so raw and so sustained that Florence Pugh's



THE SEASONS OF A LIFE Pelle's doctrine of four eighteen-year seasons: spring to eighteen, summer to thirty-six, autumn to fifty-four, winter to seventy-two. The circle runs from the cradle to the cliff.

rendering of it has become one of the most discussed vocal performances in recent cinema.

What the scene shows, and what it withholds, is precise. Christian holds Dani's body. He does not hold her voice. He is silent; his face, turned partly from her and toward the lens, registers helplessness, discomfort, duty. And the camera, rather than closing on the grieving woman, withdraws, tracking slowly backward and leaving the couple small in the frame, as though the apparatus itself recoiled from what it recorded. The wail is unanswered. It goes out into the room and returns to no one. This is the film's first holding, and it is a failed holding of a specific kind: a holding of the body that leaves the voice unheld. I propose to name the distinction one between *somatic holding* and *phonic holding*, and to argue that it organizes the entire film. Somatic holding is the ordinary currency of modern intimacy: the embrace that comforts without participating, that contains a sufferer without entering her suffering. Phonic holding is the answering of a cry by a cry: the reception of pain into a resonant body that returns it amplified and shared. The prologue establishes that Dani's world—family,



SOMATIC HOLDING
the body held, the voice unheld

PHONIC HOLDING
a cry answered by a cry

THE TWO WAILS In Christian's arms the cry goes out into the room and returns to no one; among the Hårga women it is matched, pitch for pitch, and rises as she rises.

partner, society—can offer at best the former. The Hårga will offer the latter.

The rhyme arrives after the May Queen's procession through the fields, when Dani glimpses through a gap in a door the ritual coupling of Christian with Maja, the young Hårga woman who has chosen him as her mate, and stumbles into a nearby building, where she collapses into the same wail she uttered in Christian's arms months before. This time the wail is answered. The women who have followed her gather around her, kneel with her, and wail with her—matching her pitch, her rhythm, her breath, rising as she rises, so that her solitary cry becomes the leading voice of a chorus. The scene is shot not in withdrawal but in immersion: the camera stays close, and the sound saturates the frame. Where Christian's silent embrace left Dani alone inside her grief, the Hårga's mirroring places her at its center, as its source and its conductor. The film's emotional logic is concentrated in the interval between these two wails. Everything the Hårga offer Dani—and everything they take from others in order to make the offer—is contained in the difference between a cry that is merely tolerated and a cry that is returned.

The point is not merely psychological; it is formal, and, as Chapter Five argues at length, political. The mirroring of the second wail is not a spontaneous efflorescence of sympathy but an institution, and the film has prepared us for it. At the ättestupa, when one of the two elders survives the fall with shattered legs, the commune answers his moans with its own be-

fore the mallet ends him; during the ritual coupling, the naked women surrounding Maja and Christian breathe and cry out in synchrony with Maja's pleasure. Mirroring is a Hårga practice—a technology for the collective production and distribution of affect—and it has a strict corollary whose significance emerges only in the finale. When the temple burns, the commune mirrors the screams of the two volunteers whose fear-suppressing draught has failed. It does not mirror Christian, who has been paralyzed by a powder blown into his face and sewn inside the eviscerated carcass of a bear: he is mute, and his muteness places him outside the economy of the answered cry. The sacrificial holding environment holds every voice that can be heard, and only those. What cannot be voiced cannot be mirrored, and what cannot be mirrored cannot be grieved. Chapter Five develops this observation through Judith Butler's analysis of the differential distribution of grievability (Butler 2004); here it suffices to mark that the film's two wails and its final silence compose a single argument about the conditions of being held.

The comparison with the film's most obvious ancestor sharpens the point. At the climax of *The Wicker Man*, Sergeant Howie, locked inside the burning effigy, sings the Twenty-Third Psalm in the Scottish metrical version while the islanders outside answer with the medieval round "Sumer is icumen in": two songs, two faiths, two communities of voice contending across the wicker. Howie dies a Christian in more than name; he has a psalm to sing, and the psalm is his last act of resistance. *Midsommar*'s Christian has nothing to sing. His name is the residue of a faith of which nothing else remains in him—no psalm, no prayer, no doctrine, no community of voice—and the Hårga, by paralyzing him, ensure that even the residue is silent. Where Hardy staged a contest of hymns, Aster stages a chorus and a mute. The modern secular subject, the film suggests, enters the fire without any song of its own, and therefore without anyone to answer it.

1.6

Durkheim's Diptych

The Two Deaths That Frame the Film

Midsommar is framed by two deaths, and the frame is a sociological argument. In the American winter of the prologue, a young woman whose bipolar illness the film has carefully established fills her parents' house with exhaust from a car, killing them, and dies with the tube taped into her own mouth; the deaths are discovered by strangers, reported by telephone, and witnessed by no one who loved the dead. In the Swedish summer of the second act, two Hårga elders who have reached seventy-two are led in procession to the top of a cliff, mark an ancestral stone with blood from their palms, and leap, before the assembled community and its guests, onto the rocks below. One death is secret, nocturnal, domestic, and unwitnessed; the other public, diurnal, ceremonial, and celebrated. One destroys a family in an act of despair; the other renews a community in an act of piety. The film sets the two side by side without commentary, but the juxtaposition is exact enough to be read through the most influential sociological account of self-inflicted death ever written, Émile Durkheim's *Suicide* (1897).

Durkheim held that suicide rates are explained not by individual psychology but by two dimensions of the social bond: *integration*, the degree to which individuals are attached to the life of a group, and *regulation*, the degree to which a group's moral discipline sets limits to individual desire (Durkheim [1897] 1951). Each dimension admits pathologies of deficit and of excess. Too little integration produces *egoistic* suicide, the death of an individual thrown back upon himself; too much produces *altruistic* suicide, the death of an individual who has no existence apart from the group. Too little regulation produces *anomic* suicide, the death of desire without limit; too much produces what Durkheim called *fatalistic* suicide, a type he confined to a single footnote and described as the death of those whose futures are walled off without mercy and whose passions are crushed by oppressive discipline. Durkheim insisted that individual pathology could not account for the social rate, and the film, though scrupulous about Terri's illness, composes her death as a social image as well as a clinical event: the snow-

muffled suburb, the sealed rooms, the hose running from the exhaust, a family integrated at last only by the gas that fills its house.

Read through this typology, the prologue occupies the corner of double deficit. Dani's family exists only as a network of failed transmissions—an alarming email, unanswered calls, messages left on machines—and her intimate bond is a relationship that her partner's friends, with a candor the film neither endorses nor refutes, diagnose as sustained chiefly by inertia. Terri's act parodies, in the register of despair, the collective death the Hårga ritualize: she does not die alone but takes her parents with her, folding the family into a single death as though annihilation were the last form of integration still available to it. The image is of the society Durkheim feared modernity would produce: an aggregate of individuals connected by communication but not by communion, regulated by nothing but appetite, and consoled by nothing but the market.

The second death occupies the opposite corner with an exactness that verges on citation, because Durkheim's own catalogue of what he termed *obligatory altruistic suicide* drew upon the very northern antiquity that the Hårga simulate. Drawing in part on the seventeenth-century Danish antiquary Thomas Bartholin, Durkheim reports that Danish warriors held it a disgrace to die of age or sickness in bed; that the Goths believed those who died natural deaths would languish forever in caverns of venomous creatures; and that on the frontier of the Visigoths' territory stood a high pinnacle, the Rock of the Forefathers, from which old men weary of life threw themselves down. Shortly afterward he records the custom of Ceos, where men who had outlived a certain age gathered at a solemn festival and, their heads crowned with flowers, joyfully drank hemlock (Durkheim [1897] 1951, bk. 2, chap. 4). The two signature images of *Midsommar*—the cliff of the elders and the flower-crowned festival of a death embraced with joy—stand within a few pages of each other in the founding text of academic sociology, as its paradigm of excessive integration: the case in which, for Durkheim, the individual counts for so little that the obligation to die is a social duty and its refusal a dishonor. Two consequences follow. The first is that the Hårga's cliff is Durkheim's cliff, and the film's inquiry into belonging begins at the point where the discipline that first theorized belonging began. The second is that Durkheim's paradigm was itself assembled from the Gothicist antiquarianism examined in Chapter Two, so that sociology's founding image of the over-integrated society was,

from the outset, a northern fantasy. The strata of the archive described in §1.3 are not only the film's sources; they are the sources of the theories through which the film is read.

To Durkheim's altruism the Hårga add the fatalism he relegated to a footnote. Their lives are regulated from birth to death by the calendar Pelle recites to his guests, four seasons of eighteen years, the last ending in a death appointed in advance: the future is not merely blocked but abolished on schedule. The male elder is played by Björn Andrésen, whose face, as Tadzio in Luchino Visconti's *Death in Venice* (1971), became modern cinema's emblem of the youthful beauty for which an aging man dies. In *Midsommar* the emblem returns as an old man who dies so that the young may flourish, and a single casting decision compresses the film's inversion of the relation between generations. That this elder bears the name Dan—the heroine's own, shorn of its final vowel—belongs to the order of signs whose over-reading §1.4 cautioned against. Yet the film's world is one in which such signs are not idle, and it is difficult not to discern in the old man whose body refuses to die cleanly, and whose moans the commune answers before the mallet ends them, a premonition of the heroine whose grief the commune will answer and whose former life it will end.

Taken together, the two deaths trace a diagonal across Durkheim's plane, from the corner of double deficit to the corner of double excess (Figure 1.1). Durkheim located social health in neither corner but in the moderate center, and his institutional remedy, set out in the conclusion of *Suicide* and in the preface to the second edition of *The Division of Labor in Society* (1902), was the restoration of intermediary bodies: occupational groups standing between the isolated individual and the distant state, near enough to hold the individual and plural enough not to absorb him (Durkheim [1893] 1984). The film's world contains no such middle term. The cohort of anthropology graduate students is a pseudo-intermediary whose members treat Dani as an intrusion; the therapist they invoke is a commodity, a holding purchased by the hour; the family is dead. The Hårga, conversely, absorbs every intermediary—kin, guild, school, church, state—into a single body that is all of them at once. Dani's passage from America to Hälsingland is thus neither ascent nor descent but a traversal of the entire plane without a place to stand: from the corner where no one holds her to the corner where everyone holds her absolutely.

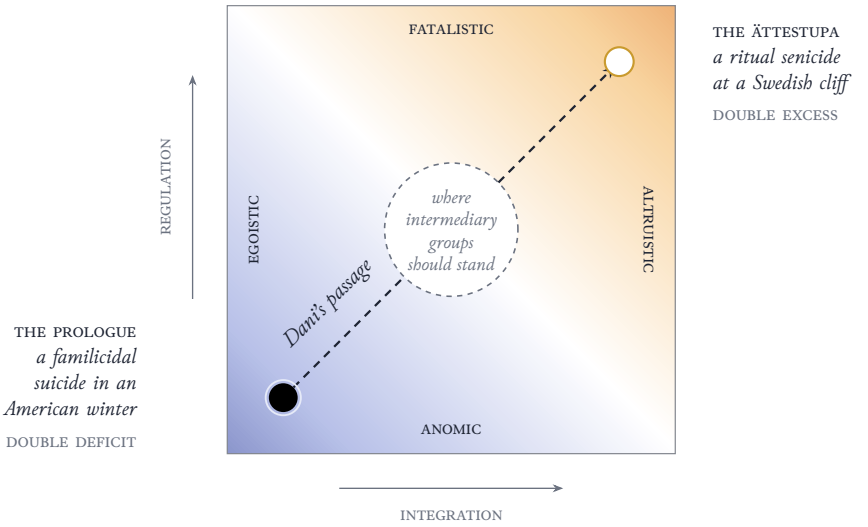


FIGURE 1.1. The prologue and the ättestupa occupy opposite corners of Durkheim's plane; the passage between them crosses the place where his intermediary groups should stand and finds nothing there.

A second Durkheim completes the diptych. In *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912), analyzing Australian mourning rites, Durkheim argued that mourning is not the spontaneous movement of private feeling wounded by loss but a duty imposed by the group: one weeps not merely because one is sad but because one is obliged to weep, and the collective performance of grief, far from depleting the group, restores to it the sense of its own vitality (Durkheim [1912] 1995, bk. 3, chap. 5). Marcel Mauss generalized the insight in his study of the obligatory expression of sentiments (Mauss 1921). The Hårga's mirroring chorus is the piacular rite brought to perfection: grief that is, in the strict sense, socially compulsory, and whose collective performance converts loss into renewal. The sequence of the finale—the shared wail, the election of the victim, the fire, the smile—follows the arc Durkheim described, from the group's lamentation to the group's re-intensified life. What Durkheim could survey with a comparativist's detachment, the film compels its spectator to inhabit from within: the moment at which a community's grief becomes its joy, and the dead become its fuel.

1.7

"Held"

Winnicott, Pelle's Question, and the Phenomenology of Holding

After the ättestupa, when Christian has advised Dani to take some time alone, it is Pelle who seeks her out in the visitors' sleeping quarters. Pelle is the Hårga-born student who brought the visitors to the commune, and the one who remembered the birthday Christian forgot, marking it with a portrait of Dani drawn in his own hand. He tells her that his parents, too, are dead—they burned in a fire—but that he was never alone afterward, because he has always felt held by a family, by the community that raised him. He then asks whether she feels held by Christian, and whether Christian feels like home. The question is at once tender and diagnostic, a gesture of care and an act of assessment. It is the recruiter's question, and it is phrased in the vocabulary of the clinic. *Held* is a term of art: it is the master concept of D. W. Winnicott's psychoanalysis, and the film places in the mouth of its recruiter the central idea of postwar British object-relations theory.

Winnicott's provocation that there is no such thing as an infant—only an infant together with maternal care—grounds a theory in which the self is not a given but an achievement made possible by an environment (Winnicott 1960). The infant's earliest phase is one of *holding*: a total provision, physical and psychological, that shields the infant from what Winnicott called *impingement* and permits the continuity he called *going-on-being*. Where holding fails, the infant is exposed to anxieties Winnicott termed unthinkable, among them going to pieces, having no relation to the body, having no orientation, and falling forever (Winnicott [1962] 1965). The last of these receives in *Midsommar* its most literal image. The ättestupa is a staging of the fall. But it is a held fall: announced, witnessed, attended by the whole community, answered by the community's voice, and closed by its hand. The Hårga do not abolish falling; they hold it. Here is the first sense of the formula toward which this dissertation tends: among the Hårga, to be held is to consent, at the appointed time, to fall.

Winnicott's later account of the mirror-role of the mother, which he introduced in explicit dialogue with Jacques Lacan's mirror stage (Lacan

[1949] 2006), specifies what holding does to a face. When the infant looks at the mother's face, Winnicott argued, what it ordinarily sees is itself: the maternal countenance returns the infant's state to it, and through that return the infant begins to exist. Many infants, however, have a long experience of not getting back what they give. They look and do not see themselves, because the mother's face reflects her own mood or the rigidity of her defenses (Winnicott [1967] 1971). Developmental research has since given the observation experimental form: in the still-face paradigm, infants confronted with a caregiver's sudden unresponsiveness move rapidly from attempts at re-engagement to protest and withdrawal (Tronick et al. 1978). Christian's face in the prologue is a still face. Dani looks into it and finds his discomfort, his sense of duty, his wish to be elsewhere; she does not find her grief. The faces and voices of the Hårga women return her grief to her, magnified. What Heinz Kohut would call a mirroring selfobject—the responsive other whose reflection sustains the cohesion of the self (Kohut 1971)—is supplied to Dani not by a person but by a chorus. Phonic holding, in the terms of §1.5, is the mirror-role transposed from the face to the voice and from the dyad to the group.

The transposition is not without loss, and two refinements of the clinical literature locate it. Daniel Stern distinguished *affect attunement* from imitation: the attuned caregiver matches the intensity, rhythm, and contour of the infant's expression in a different modality, and the translation is the proof that an inner state, rather than an outward behavior, has been grasped (Stern 1985). The Hårga's mirroring is closer to imitation than to attunement. It reproduces the contour of Dani's cry in the same modality, at the same pitch, and amplifies it; it is resonance without translation, a contagion of affect rather than an understanding of it. Wilfred Bion, for his part, described the mother's *reverie* as a container that receives the infant's unbearable projected states, metabolizes them, and returns them in a form the infant can bear (Bion 1962). The Hårga do not metabolize; they multiply. Dani's anguish returns to her undiminished and enlarged, and what Bion called beta-elements—raw, unthought experience fit only for evacuation—are discharged in the only operation the commune offers for them, which is action. When, at the festival's culmination, Dani must choose the ninth offering, the commune's equivalent of the alpha-function is revealed to be the rite itself. The Hårga do not help Dani to think the unthinkable. They help her to do it.

The deepest Winnicottian implication concerns failure. The good-enough mother, Winnicott argued, begins with an almost complete adaptation to her infant's needs and then adapts less and less completely, in step with the infant's growing capacity to tolerate her failure; this graduated failure is the condition of disillusionment, of reality-testing, and of the transitional space in which a self comes into its own (Winnicott 1953). A holding that never failed would not facilitate development but arrest it. The Hårga's holding of Dani never fails: its mirroring is perpetual, its adaptation total. But no environment can hold without failing somewhere, and the Hårga's solution to this law constitutes the dissertation's central theoretical claim. In the good-enough environment, the necessary failure of holding is *temporalized*: it is distributed across the held subject's own development as gradual disillusionment. In the sacrificial environment, failure is *spatialized and personified*: it is exported from the held subject onto others, who are not held at all but let fall. Total holding for some is purchased by absolute failure for others. This is the second, darker sense of the formula: among the Hårga, to be held is to let fall.

A final Winnicottian text explains why the cure nevertheless works. In "Fear of Breakdown," Winnicott proposed that the breakdown a patient dreads has already occurred, but could not be experienced when it occurred, because there was not yet a self able to gather it into experience; it must therefore be undergone for the first time in the present, in the transference, in the presence of a holder (Winnicott 1974). The second wail of *Midsommar* is the first wail experienced for the first time. What Dani could not undergo in Christian's arms, because no one received it, she undergoes among the Hårga women, because they do. The scene's therapeutic force is genuine, and the captivity reading, which treats it as mere manipulation, cannot account for it. But the frame in which the cure takes place is the inverse of the analytic frame. Analysis is bounded in time, abstinent in gratification, and devoted to interpretation, so that the transference may be understood and eventually dissolved. The Hårga's frame is unbounded, gratifying, and devoted to action, so that the transference may be consummated and never dissolved. Dani's breakdown is held at last; but the holder will not let her go.

1.8

The Collapse of Holding in Late Modernity

Pelle's question has purchase only on a subject who is not held, and the film locates the source of its heroine's unheldness not in her biography alone but in the social order of which her biography is a symptom. Hannah Arendt concluded *The Origins of Totalitarianism* by arguing that total domination bases itself on loneliness: not isolation, which pertains to the political realm of action, nor solitude, in which one keeps company with oneself, but the experience of not belonging to the world at all, which she counted among the most radical and desperate experiences a human being can undergo (Arendt [1951] 1973). The lonely, in Arendt's analysis, are not merely susceptible to total movements; they are the material from which total movements are made. The Hårga's recruitment proceeds by the same criterion. Of the outsiders brought to the festival, all but one end in the temple. Only Dani—the one who is truly lonely—is kept. The commune distinguishes between those it will consume and the one it will absorb, and the line between them is the line of loneliness.

A century of social theory has charted the erosion of the institutions that once held the bereaved. Ferdinand Tönnies set the affective, kin-and-place bonds of *Gemeinschaft* against the contractual, instrumental relations of *Gesellschaft* (Tönnies [1887] 2001). Max Weber diagnosed a disenchanted world from which the ultimate values had withdrawn, and he closed "Science as a Vocation" by advising those unable to bear the fate of the age to return quietly to the old churches, whose arms stood open "widely and compassionately" to receive them, at the unavoidable price of an intellectual sacrifice (Weber [1919] 1946). The image of open arms is Winnicott's holding transposed to the scale of a creed, and the Hårga answer it exactly: not an old church but an invented one, whose arms are open, whose compassion is literal fellow-suffering, and whose price, as Chapter Seven argues, is the sacrifice of the intellect performed upon actual intellectuals. Philip Rieff gave the same diagnosis a clinical inflection. Modernity, he argued, had replaced the *commitment therapies* of positive communities, which cured by reintegrating the sufferer into communal purposes, with an analytic therapy that released the individual from communal claims al-

together: "Religious man was born to be saved; psychological man is born to be pleased" (Rieff 1966). The restaurant scene of the prologue stages Rieff's opposition with precision. Christian's friends propose that Dani's grief belongs to a therapist—the analytic remedy of a society without positive communities. The Hårga offer the alternative Rieff believed extinct: a commitment therapy in which the cure is membership.

The couple at the film's center is itself an institution of late modernity. Anthony Giddens described the *pure relationship* as a bond entered into for its own sake and sustained only so long as each party derives sufficient satisfaction from it, a relation without external anchors and therefore perpetually revocable (Giddens 1991; 1992); Zygmunt Bauman named its affective condition liquid love, the frailty of ties conducted as connections that may be broken at will (Bauman 2003). Dani and Christian's relationship, unmoored from marriage, children, property, and kin, survives on inertia and guilt and is maintained by an asymmetrical distribution of what Arlie Russell Hochschild called emotional labor (Hochschild 1983): Dani manages her grief according to the feeling rules of the relationship, apologizing for her needs, seeking a friend's reassurance that she may lean on her partner at all, rationing her tears. Eva Illouz has shown how emotional capitalism converts intimacy into a field of communicative competence, requiring the self to narrate its suffering in therapeutic idioms and to negotiate its needs like terms of a contract (Illouz 2007; 2008). The Hårga invert these feeling rules wholesale. They demand not restraint but intensity, not management but expression, not negotiation but surrender; and to a subject exhausted by the labor of managing grief within a liquid bond, the inversion presents itself as release.

The privatization of mourning completes the diagnosis. Geoffrey Gorer, surveying bereavement in mid-century Britain, found that the decline of public mourning ritual had left the bereaved without social support and grief without form (Gorer 1965); Philippe Ariès traced the emergence of a forbidden death, removed from the household to the hospital and from public ceremony to private discretion (Ariès 1974; [1977] 1981). The film's ellipsis is eloquent: *Midsommar* contains no funeral. Between the winter of the prologue and the summer of the journey the dead are buried offscreen, and when Dani reappears her grief has become a private condition, medicated and discharged in bathrooms, out of sight. The Hårga, for whom

every death is a festival, offer what Gorer's Britain and Dani's America have withdrawn: a public form for loss.

The sociology of high-control groups supplies the other half of the configuration. Rosabeth Moss Kanter, studying nineteenth-century American communes, identified six mechanisms by which durable utopian communities secured commitment—sacrifice, investment, renunciation, communion, mortification, and transcendence (Kanter 1972)—and the Hårga deploy all six with textbook completeness. Lewis Coser named "greedy institutions" those that claim the exclusive and undivided loyalty of the whole person and reduce the claims of every competing role (Coser 1974); Erving Goffman described the total institution, in which sleep, work, and play are conducted in one place under a single authority (Goffman 1961). Late modernity, the film suggests, produces the unheld individual and the greedy institution as two halves of one configuration: the first supplies the hunger, the second the meal. The configuration has outlived the film's moment, as the efflorescence of documentary series about high-control groups in the years around its release, among them *Wild Wild Country* (2018) and *The Vow* (2020), and the 2023 advisory in which the Surgeon General of the United States declared an epidemic of loneliness and isolation, alike attest (US Department of Health and Human Services 2023). *Midsommar*'s achievement is to show that the nightmare of the cult and the dream of the commune are the same fantasy seen from opposite sides—which is to say that they repeat, at the scale of a culture, the equation of the final smile.

◉

1.9

Five Propositions and a Formula

The argument of the dissertation may be condensed into five propositions, each developed in the chapters that follow, and a formula that binds them.

I Proposition I: **The Missing Middle.** *Midsommar* stages the disappearance of any middle term between unheld isolation and devouring belonging. Its heroine traverses the whole of Durkheim's

plane, from the corner of egoism and anomie to the corner of altruism and fatalism, without encountering the intermediary institutions in which Durkheim located social health. The film's horror is not that the Hårga exist but that nothing exists between them and the world Dani left.

II Proposition II: **Sympathocracy.** The Hårga's fundamental technology is not violence but organized mimesis. The mirroring chorus produces, distributes, and administers affect collectively, abolishing the distance between self and other on which sympathy in the strict sense depends, and replacing fellow-feeling with contagion. The commune's violence is secondary and periodic; its mimesis is primary and continuous.

III Proposition III: **Exported Failure.** Every holding environment must fail somewhere. The good-enough environment temporalizes its failure as the gradual disillusionment of the held subject; the sacrificial environment spatializes and personifies its failure as sacrifice. Total holding for some is financed by absolute failure for others: the outsider who cannot be assimilated, the intellect that insists on distance, the voiceless victim who cannot be mirrored.

IV Proposition IV: **The Fabricated Archive.** The Hårga's antiquity is a construction, a Gothicist palimpsest of authentic sources, antiquarian fantasy, and invention, and the commune's power depends on the effect of antiquity that the construction produces. In the sense established by Eric Hobsbawm and Terence Ranger's account of invented tradition (Hobsbawm and Ranger 1983), tradition is the most modern of the commune's artifacts: its scripture is still being written, and its claim to the past is a strategy for possessing the future.

V Proposition V: **Conscription.** The film performs upon its spectators the operation it represents. It invites them to mirror Dani's affect in the finale, to experience her smile as release, and to decode its images as the elders decode the *Rubi Radr*. The audience is thereby enrolled in the community it watches, as a mirroring chorus and as a college of interpreters, and the film's last question

> is addressed less to its heroine than to us: what, in the pleasure of the ending, have we been willing to let burn?

The five propositions converge on the smile, which the dissertation reads as an instance of what it calls *euphoric anagnorisis*. Aristotle defined recognition as a change from ignorance to knowledge, issuing in love or hatred between persons marked for good or ill fortune, and held that the finest recognition coincides with reversal (*Poetics* 1452a). In tragedy, recognition arrives with catastrophe and discharges itself in pity and fear. In *Midsommar*, the heroine recognizes what the community is—that its holding is its burning—at the moment of the burning, and the recognition issues in joy. The reversal is not of fortune but of affect: the knowledge that should produce horror produces belonging.

The formula that condenses the argument may now be stated in full: *in the economy of total belonging, to be held is to let fall.* The verb carries three senses, and the film activates all of them. The Hårga let fall their elders from the cliff, holding the fall so that no one falls unheld. They let fall those whom they cannot hold, the outsiders and the voiceless, in order to hold those whom they keep. And the held subject lets fall what she was: her former attachments, her separate judgment, the residue of a self formed in the world she has left. Each sense names a sacrifice, and the smile is the expression of a subject who has accepted all three.

◉

1.10

Architecture of the Dissertation

The chapters follow the order of the film's own construction, moving from the materials out of which the Hårga are made, through the medium in which they are rendered, to the systems their society embodies, and finally to the subject and the spectator whom those systems claim.

Chapter Two descends into the archive. It reconstructs the northern sources—Eddic poetry and saga, Adam of Bremen's Uppsala, the antiquarian invention of the ättestupa, the Hälsingland legend of the Hårga dance—together with the modern apparatus through which they

reach the film, from Rudbeck's *Atlantica* to Skansen and from Carl Larsson's *Midvinterblot* to the racial-biological underside of the Swedish welfare state; it establishes Proposition IV. Chapter Three turns to form and inverts Friedrich Nietzsche's opposition of Apollo and Dionysus: the film's Dionysian contents—drugs, dance, sex, frenzy—are administered through an Apollonian form of symmetry, daylight, and prolepsis, so that its dread is the dread of order rather than of chaos. Chapter Four reads the Hårga as an economy through the theories of sacrifice, gift, hospitality, and immunity; it argues that the commune is the limit case of what Roberto Esposito calls the immunitary paradigm, a community that protects its life by incorporating the foreign as victim, measures it against Le Guin's Omelas and Jackson's village, and develops Proposition III. Chapter Five isolates the affective core of the argument, the mirroring chorus, and defends Proposition II through the anthropology of lament, the phenomenology of fellow-feeling, and the critique of organized mimesis. Chapter Six addresses sovereignty and desire: the May Queen as an inverted sacral king, the bear as a dethroned sovereign, Christian as the consort of an archaic cycle, and the gendered politics of a revenge the film both indulges and indicts. Chapter Seven addresses knowledge: the ethnographers devoured by their object, the oracle bred to be unclouded, and the sacrifice of the intellect literalized as a body count. Chapter Eight draws the strands together in a theory of the white sun of melancholy—mourning deprived of its night—and returns to the smile as euphoric anagnorisis and to the spectator's share in it, completing Propositions I and V.

The dissertation comprises eight chapters. The Hårga's rite requires nine offerings, and the ninth is not prescribed but chosen: by a single person, at the last moment, under the gaze of the community. The ninth station of this argument is likewise left to the reader, who must decide, as the spectator of the film must decide, what the smile has cost and whether the price was worth paying.

I.II

Conventions

Citations follow the author-date system of *The Chicago Manual of Style*; where a translation or later edition is cited, the year of original publication appears in brackets. References to *Midsommar* are to the director's cut unless the theatrical version is specified, and scenes are located by narrative day and event rather than by timecode, since running times differ across versions and releases. Character names follow the credits. Swedish and Old Norse terms are retained in their customary forms (*ättestupa*, *Hårga*, *midsommar*, *blót*); the *Rubi Radr* and the commune's runic and rune-like inscriptions are treated as diegetic artifacts, without prejudice to their relation to the historical futharks. Old Norse texts are cited from standard English translations, Adam of Bremen from Francis J. Tschan's translation (Adam of Bremen 1959), and classical texts by conventional book and section numbers. Dialogue is paraphrased except where a single word carries the argument, as with Pelle's *held*. Figures are schematic and the author's own.





CHAPTER TWO

Nine Days at Uppsala

The Northern Archive of Sacrifice and the Hårga as Gothicist Palimpsest

Veit ek, at ek hekk
vindga meiði á
nætr allar níu,
geiri undaðr
ok gefinn Óðni,
sjalfr sjalfum mér.

— *Hávamál* 138

Ceterum neniae, quae in eiusmodi ritu libationis fieri solent,
multiplices et inhonestae, ideoque melius reticendae.

— Adam of Bremen, *Gesta Hammaburgensis ecclesiae pontificum* IV.27

2.1

The Archive and Its Archons

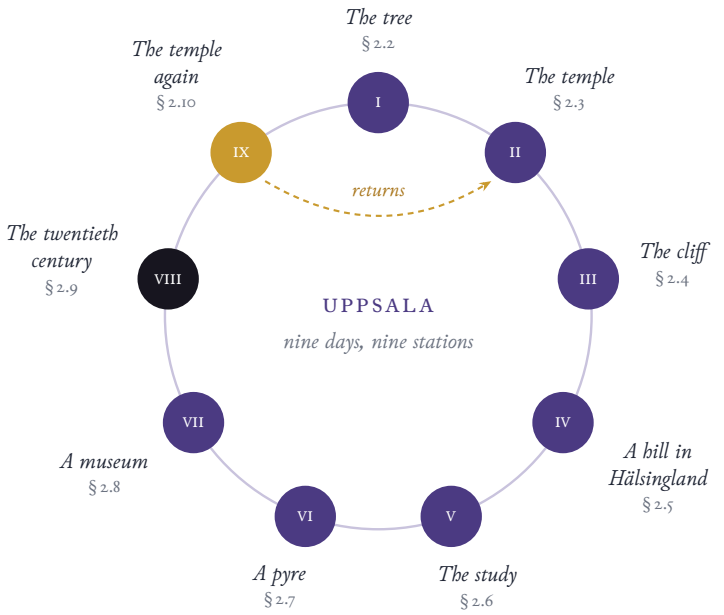
The Hårga present themselves as survivors. Their festival is said to return once in ninety years, their elders to observe a law of life older than memory, their scripture, the *Rubi Radr*, to contain the whole of their tradition. Yet the film never dates the commune's origin, never names a god to whom its rites are addressed, and never shows a document older than the scripture whose newest pages are still being drawn by the oracle Ruben. The Hårga's antiquity is asserted rather than demonstrated: it is a claim the community makes about itself and a sensation the film produces in its spectators. This chapter takes that claim as its object. Its question is not whether the Hårga are authentic—they

are a fiction, built on a set outside Budapest—but how the effect of their authenticity is manufactured, from what materials, and to what ends.

Three models of the written past orient the inquiry. Thomas De Quincey proposed that the human mind is a palimpsest, a parchment on which successive writings have been laid down without any being truly erased, so that under the right conditions the oldest script may surface through the newest (De Quincey 1845). Freud, describing the child's toy called the mystic writing-pad, imagined a surface that receives ever-new inscriptions while retaining permanent traces of the old ones in the wax beneath (Freud [1925] 1961). Jacques Derrida, reading Freud, recalled that the word *archive* descends from the Greek *arkheion*, the house of the *archons*, magistrates who held a city's official documents and possessed the right to interpret them. The archive is therefore at once a principle of commencement and a principle of commandment, the place where things are said to begin and the place from which order is given; and archivization, Derrida argued, produces the event as much as it records it (Derrida [1995] 1996). No formulation fits the Hårga more exactly. The elders are archons; the temple that houses the *Rubi Radr* is an *arkheion*; and the scripture does not preserve a tradition so much as generate, page by page, the tradition it claims to preserve.

The result may be called a *Gothicist palimpsest*: a composite surface on which several historical strata of northern self-imagination show through one another, none effacing the rest, and on which the newest inscriptions are disguised as the oldest. Five strata, distinguished in §1.3, are legible in the Hårga: the medieval textual record of Scandinavian religion, nearly all of it written by Christians; the early modern antiquarianism that Swedish scholars called *götism*; the national romanticism and folkloristics of the nineteenth century; the biopolitics of the twentieth-century welfare state; and the modernist, popular, and generic afterlives of the north, from Stravinsky to black metal to folk horror. The chapter argues that every Hårga practice condenses several strata at once; that what the film discloses beneath the surface of the commune's antiquity is not a pagan origin but the history of its rewritings; and that this history includes its violence.

The title names the place where the strata converge. Uppsala never appears in *Midsommar*, yet for nine centuries the town has been the capital of the archive on which the film draws. It is the site of the golden temple that



THE NINE STATIONS Chapter Two's itinerary through the archive, from the tree to the ninth station, which returns to the temple.

Adam of Bremen described in the 1070s and of the great mounds where the Yngling kings were said to lie; the seat of the university where, in 1664, the word *ättestupa* entered the Swedish language and where Olof Rudbeck located Atlantis; the city of Linnaeus, who sorted humankind into varieties; and the city in which, in 1922, the Swedish state founded the first government institute of racial biology in the world. The nine sections that follow are nine days at Uppsala: nine stations of an itinerary through the archive, each of which excavates one practice or image of the Hårga and the strata that compose it.

2.2

Myself to Myself

Odin's Tree and the Economy of Runes

The first station is a tree. In the run of stanzas known as the *Rúnatal*, embedded in the Eddic poem *Hávamál*, Odin recounts that he hung on

a wind-shaken tree for nine whole nights, wounded by a spear and given to Odin, himself to himself, on a tree whose roots no one knows; that no one gave him bread or drink; and that he peered down, took up the runes, took them screaming, and fell back from there (*Hávamál* 138–39). The passage is the founding myth of northern writing, and its economy is plain. Knowledge is not received; it is purchased, and the price is the body of the one who would know. The same economy governs Odin's other great acquisition. According to the *Völuspá* and to Snorri Sturluson's *Gylfaginning*, the god pledged an eye at the well of Mímir for a draught of its wisdom, so that the all-seeing god is half-blind by the cost of his sight (Larrington 2014; Snorri Sturluson 1987). Odin is the god of the hanged, of the dead, of poetry and of ecstasy, and Adam of Bremen glossed his name with a phrase that has haunted every subsequent interpretation: *Wodan, id est furor*—Wodan, that is to say, fury (Adam of Bremen 1959, IV.26).

The Hårga name no god, but their scripture obeys Odin's economy. The *Rubi Radr* is written by Ruben, a child the commune has bred through incest so that his mind will be, in its own account, unclouded by ordinary cognition, and whose marks the elders read as Odin read the runes beneath the tree. The oracle is a body sacrificed before its birth, and the scripture is the yield of that sacrifice; among the Hårga there is no revelation without a price paid in flesh. The commune's arithmetic belongs to the same mythological register. Norse cosmology is saturated with nines: nine worlds in the *Völuspá*, nine nights on the tree, nine mothers of the god Heimdallr, nine daughters of the sea-giant Ægir, nine steps taken by Thor before he falls dead at the world's end, nine nights that Freyr must wait for the giantess Gerðr, eight rings dropped every ninth night by the ring Draupnir. The Hårga's numbers are all multiples of nine: a nine-day festival, nine offerings, life seasons of eighteen years, a death fixed at seventy-two, a cycle that returns every ninety years. Whether or not the film's makers consulted the Eddas, the commune's numerology sits inside the most distinctive numerical signature of the northern mythological corpus.

The most consequential phrase in the *Rúnatal* is the reflexive *sjalfr sjalfum mér*, "myself to myself." Odin is both offering and recipient, and the sacrifice is a transaction within a single self that emerges from it transformed and empowered. The finale of *Midsommar* is reflexive in the same sense. Dani gives what she was to what she is becoming; she is at once the one who offers and the one who receives; and she acquires, in what Chap-

ter One called euphoric anagnorisis, a new knowledge, the knowledge of what the community is. But Odin's self-sacrifice costs no one else, whereas Dani's is paid with another body. The film thereby discloses something about the reflexive formula itself, and about the therapeutic culture whose narratives of self-transformation reproduce it: the self that offers itself to itself in a rite of rebirth is often financed by those whom the rebirth discards. *Myself to myself* names the sacrificial holding environment from the inside; *Christian to the fire* names it from the outside.

A second Odinic episode completes the station. In *Gautreks saga*, King Víkarr's fleet lies becalmed; lots are cast to learn what the god demands, and the lot falls on the king. His companions resolve to perform a mock sacrifice. A soft calf's gut serves as the noose and a slender branch as the gallows, and the hero Starkaðr strikes the king with a reed stalk that Odin, in disguise, had given him the night before, pronouncing the words *Now I give you to Odin*. At once the reed becomes a spear, the gut a strong rope, and the branch springs upward; Víkarr dies hanged and pierced, as Odin hung pierced on his tree (Hermann Pálsson and Edwards 1968). The episode is the mythic prototype of a structure that *Midsommar* exploits with precision: a rite its participants believe to be theater becomes real in the moment of its performance. The visitors read the Hårga's opening ceremonies as folklore staged for guests and discover at the cliff that the staging was the reality. Odin is the god of that conversion, the god of the jest that kills. Chapter Eight will argue that the film's spectators undergo the same conversion in reverse: what they experience within the fiction as a real death, they leave the cinema having enjoyed as a show.

◉

2.3

The Golden Temple

Adam of Bremen and the Arithmetic of Nine

The second station is the temple. Around 1075, in the fourth book of his history of the archbishops of Hamburg-Bremen, the cleric Adam of Bremen described the sanctuary of the Swedes at Uppsala in terms that have shaped every later image of northern paganism (Adam of Bremen 1959, IV.26–27 and scholia). The temple, he wrote, is made entirely of gold; the

scholia appended to the early manuscripts add that a golden chain encircles it, hanging from the gables, and that it stands on a plain ringed by hills in the manner of a theater. Inside, the people venerate three gods. Thor, the mightiest, sits enthroned at the center and governs thunder and lightning, wind and rain, fair weather and crops; Wodan, "that is, fury," wages war and gives men strength against their enemies; Fricco, figured with an immense phallus, bestows peace and pleasure. Priests sacrifice to Thor when plague or famine threatens, to Wodan in war, and to Fricco at weddings.

Every nine years, Adam continues, a festival common to all the Swedish provinces is held at Uppsala, and from it no one is exempt; kings and peoples send gifts, and—what Adam calls crueler than any punishment—even those who have accepted Christianity must buy their way out of its ceremonies. Nine heads of every male creature are offered, their blood to placate the gods, their bodies hung in the grove beside the temple. That grove is so sacred that each of its trees is believed divine by reason of the deaths and decay of the victims; dogs and horses hang there beside men, and a Christian informant told Adam that he had seen seventy-two bodies hanging together. A scholion adds that the feasting and sacrifices last nine days, that on each day a man is offered with other animals, so that seventy-two creatures die over the nine days, and that the rite falls near the spring equinox. Further scholia describe an evergreen tree of unknown kind beside the temple and a spring in which a living man is drowned, the people's wish to be granted if his body is never found.

Adam never went to Uppsala. He wrote from Bremen, relying on informants who probably included the Danish king Sven Estridsen and the missionary bishop Adalvard the Younger of Sigtuna, and he wrote as the propagandist of a see that claimed authority over the whole north. Scholars remain divided: some read the temple, the tree, and the well as a cosmological topos rather than a description of a site, while others argue that particular details derive from reliable oral tradition (Hultgård 2022). Excavation at Gamla Uppsala has revealed great mounds and monumental halls but no golden temple, and Olaf Olsen's argument that pre-Christian cult was conducted largely in multifunctional halls rather than in dedicated temples (Olsen 1966) has been qualified, not overturned, by the discovery of a small, repeatedly rebuilt cult building at Uppåkra in Skåne (Larsson 2007). The most influential description of Swedish pagan sacrifice is thus

a hostile foreign text whose central object may never have existed in the form described: an archive, in the sense of §2.1, that produces the event it records.

Other texts complete a constellation of nines and fires. Thietmar of Merseburg reported in the 1010s that at Lejre in Zealand the Danes gathered every nine years in January to offer ninety-nine men and as many horses, with dogs and cocks (Thietmar of Merseburg 2001, I.17). Snorri's *Ynglinga saga* makes Uppsala the seat of Freyr and chronicles a dynasty of royal sacrifice. When harvests failed despite offerings of oxen and men, the Swedes killed their king Dómaldi and reddened the altars with his blood. King Aun the Old gave nine of his sons to Odin, one every tenth year, each death buying him ten more years, until he was reduced to drinking from a horn like an infant and the Swedes forbade the tenth. And when famine struck in the reign of Óláfr trételgja, the Swedes surrounded his house, burned him inside it, and gave him to Odin for a good year (Snorri Sturluson 1964). The formula the sagas attach to the sacrificial feast, *til árs ok friðar*, "for a good year and peace," names the purpose of all these deaths: the fertility and tranquility of the community that makes them.

Measured against Adam's account, the Hårga's festival discloses convergences too dense to be accidental, whether or not they were designed (Table 2.1).

The convergences are numerical and architectural; the divergences are theological. The Hårga move the rite from the threshold of spring to midsummer, the season of maximal light; they replace hanging and drowning with falling and burning, the latter prefigured by the burning of Óláfr in his house for the year's yield; and they address their rites to no god at all. No Thor, Wodan, or Fricco receives the Hårga's offerings, which are directed instead to the circle of the community's own life. In this the Hårga's religion is the most Durkheimian imaginable, for Durkheim held that the god of the clan is nothing other than the clan itself, hypostasized and transfigured (Durkheim [1912] 1995). Chapter Five argues that this absence of gods is the theological foundation of sympathocracy: where no deity receives the offering, the community's feeling becomes the sacred itself.

One sentence of Adam's deserves a station of its own. Having counted the bodies in the grove, he turns to the singing: *Ceterum neniae, quae in eiusmodi ritu libationis fieri solent, multiplices et inhonestae, ideoque melius*

Adam of Bremen's Uppsala *(c. 1075)*	Feature	The Hårga in *Midsommar*
Every nine years	Recurrence	Every ninety years
Nine days	Duration	Nine days
One man on each day, nine in all	Human victims	Nine offerings in all
Bodies seen hanging in the grove; creatures sacrificed over the nine days	Seventy-two	Age at which every member dies
A temple "entirely of gold"	Sanctuary	A temple painted yellow
Evergreen tree beside the temple; a grove made holy by the dead	Sacred tree	Ancestral tree that receives the ashes of the dead
Near the spring equinox	Season	Midsummer
Hanging; drowning in the spring	Manner of death	Falling; burning
Thor, Wodan, Fricco	Addressees	No named god

Table 2.1. Adam of Bremen's Uppsala and the Hårga's festival compared.

reticendae—as for the chants customarily performed at a rite of this kind, they are many and indecent, and therefore better passed over in silence. Adam's word is *nenia*, the Roman name for the funeral dirge, personified as the goddess Nenia who presided over lamentation. The most detailed surviving account of Swedish sacrifice thus contains a deliberate hole precisely where the lament should be: the victims are counted and the gods named, but the voices are withheld. *Midsommar* fills the hole. Its most original fabrication, the mirroring chorus that answers the moans of the dying and the wail of the bereaved, occupies the exact place where the archive fell silent. Where Adam declined to transcribe the dirge, Aster composes one, and the chorus that holds Dani is the *nenia* the *Gesta* suppressed.

◉

2.4

The Family Cliff

Gautreks Saga, Verelius, and the Invention of the Ättestupa

The third station is the cliff, and its archive is the most thoroughly fabricated of all. The only Old Norse text that mentions a "family cliff" is the opening episode of *Gautreks saga*, an Icelandic legendary saga set partly in Västergötland and committed to writing late in the Middle Ages. King Gauti, lost while hunting, comes upon an isolated farmstead whose household is so miserly that any diminution of its property counts as catastrophe; the arrival of a guest is itself a calamity. Members of the family meet such misfortunes, which the saga makes as trivial as it can, by dividing their goods and leaping from a precipice called the *Ætternisstapi*, so that they may go to Odin rather than live diminished (Hermann Pálsson and Edwards 1968). The tone is comic and the target is avarice: the episode satirizes a peasant household that would rather die than share, and its word for the cliff appears nowhere else in the Old Norse corpus.

The satire became a Swedish custom through a sequence of learned acts. In 1664, at Uppsala, Olof Verelius, the first holder of a professorship in the antiquities of the fatherland established during Olof Rudbeck's rectorship, published the saga with the Icelander Jón Rúgman, together with a Swedish translation that rendered *ætternisstapi* as *ättestupa* (Verelius 1664). The same editions brought other saga words into Swedish, among them

bärsärk, the bear-shirted warrior to whom Chapter Six returns. Antiquarians soon attached the new name to cliffs across the Swedish landscape. Erik Dahlbergh's engraved survey of the realm, *Suecia antiqua et hodierna*, included a view of a Västergötland *ättestupa*; Erik Gustaf Geijer repeated the report in his widely read history of the Swedish people (1832–36); and from there it passed into schoolbooks and parish descriptions, until the saga's joke had become folk memory. Modern historians regard the practice as legend, and the historian Birgitta Odén dismissed it as a tall tale. The *ättestupa* is thus the paradigm of what folklorists call a learned tradition: a motif that descends from the study into the village and returns, a few generations later, as the testimony of the folk. Chapter One showed that the same motif had meanwhile ascended into sociology as Durkheim's Rock of the Forefathers. The Hårga's cliff is the terminal stage of the sequence, and it reverses the saga's tone completely: what the saga mocked as miserly folly, the Hårga perform as sacred generosity.

The commune's justification of the custom is not economic but onomastic. After the leap, Siv explains to the horrified guests that the Hårga understand life as a circle, a "recycle," in which one thing falls and another rises, and that the name of the first elder to leap, Ylva, will pass to a child not yet born; she gestures toward a pregnant woman. The Hårga's own formula—one falls, another rises—is the dissertation's formula spoken in the community's voice. Death at seventy-two is a gift of the name to the unborn, a restitution of the individual to the circle from which it came.

Set against the comparative record of senicide, the Hårga's cliff appears as a synthesis of that record's incompatible versions. Procopius reports that among the Heruli the old and the sick were placed on a pyre, stabbed by a man who was not their kinsman, and burned (Procopius 1919, VI.14). Durkheim recorded the flower-crowned festival at which the old of Ceos drank hemlock with joy. Japanese legend tells of *ubasute*, the abandonment of the aged on a mountain in times of scarcity, a legend rather than a documented practice, which Fukazawa Shichirō's novella of 1956 and the films of Kinoshita Keisuke (1958) and Imamura Shōhei (1983) made into one of the great modern narratives of filial sacrifice (Fukazawa [1956] 1961). Anthony Trollope's satire *The Fixed Period* (1882) imagined a republic in which citizens are deposited in a college at sixty-seven and painlessly ended at sixty-eight, and William Osler's jocular invocation of Trollope's scheme in his valedictory address at Johns Hopkins in 1905 provoked a national

scandal (Trollope 1882; Osler 1906). *Logan's Run*, as novel (1967) and as film (1976), staged a society whose citizens surrender themselves at a fixed age to a ceremony of promised renewal (Nolan and Johnson 1967), and *Soylent Green* (1973) gave the state's euthanasia the anesthetic form of a pastoral reverie. The Hårga combine these versions: the fixed age of Trollope, the public festival of Ceos, the promised renewal of *Logan's Run*, the aestheticized death of *Soylent Green*, and a generosity that the Gautreks household parodies by its absence.

Pelle's doctrine of the four seasons, finally, joins the cliff to an ancient comparative schema. Ovid's Pythagoras, in the fifteenth book of the *Metamorphoses*, likens the four seasons of the year to the four ages of human life (Ovid 1984); the Brahmanical law codes divide the life of the twice-born into four stages, the *āśramas* of student, householder, forest-dweller, and renouncer (Doniger and Smith 1991). The Hårga's sequence—childhood, pilgrimage, labor, and mentorship, each of eighteen years—resembles the *āśramas* in its fourfold progression from formation to withdrawal. Its terminus, however, is the opposite. The *āśramas* culminate in a renunciation that frees the individual from the social world; the Hårga's seasons culminate in a death that returns the individual's name to the community. The last stage of Hårga life is not liberation but restitution.

◉

2.5

The Dance on Hårga Hill

The Devil's Fiddler, the Maypole, and the Chosen One

The fourth station is a hill in Hälsingland. Hårga is a real village in the parish of Hanebo, beneath a flat-topped rise called Hårgaberget, and it lends the commune its name. A legend attached to the place, printed in 1785 by Johan Gabriel Lindström, tells of a stranger with a fiddle who came among the young people of Hårga as they danced and played a tune they could not stop dancing to. He led them up the hill; morning came, their elders went to church, and the young of Hårga were still dancing; they danced until they dropped dead, and in some tellings one of them glimpsed the cloven hoof beneath the fiddler's coat. The tune, *Hårgalåten*, is among the best-known pieces of the Swedish folk repertoire, and the

village now hosts a summer hambo competition, the Hälsingehambon, in which a dance once fatal has become a contest.

Midsommar names its commune after the victims of a demonic dance and gives that commune a dance contest of its own. In the May Queen sequence, the young women of the Hårga, Dani among them, dance around the maypole after drinking a prepared draught, until one after another they fall; the last to remain standing is crowned. The film fuses the legend with its modern afterlife and reverses both. In the legend, an outsider's music destroys a community's youth; in the film, a community's music absorbs the outsider, who wins. In the legend, the dance is a sin committed while the elders are at church; among the Hårga, the dance is the church. And in the legend the dancers die, whereas in the film the dancers who fall merely lose, and the death that the dance should bring is deferred and redistributed onto others.

The maypole around which they dance is itself a palimpsest. The Swedish *midsommarstång* is generally held to have arrived from Germany in the late Middle Ages, and its alternative name, *majstång*, has been derived not from the month but from the verb *maja*, to dress with leaves. The festival it crowns was kept on the eve of Saint John the Baptist until 1953, when Sweden moved Midsummer to a fixed weekend in late June. What foreigners perceive as Sweden's most pagan festival is thus a Christian feast, reorganized by modern legislation, around an early modern import. Its divinatory customs persist: on Midsummer night, unmarried girls gathered seven or nine kinds of wildflowers in silence and laid them beneath their pillows to dream of their future husbands. The film converts this sublimated divination into its literal substrate, the love magic worked upon Christian—a pubic hair baked into his pie, menstrual blood in his drink, a rune placed beneath his bed—and thereby exposes the bodily economy that the flowers had decorously veiled. National romanticism gave the festival its canonical images in Anders Zorn's painting *Midsommardans* (1897), its couples turning in the diffuse light of a Dalecarlian summer night, and in Hugo Alfvén's orchestral rhapsody *Midsommarvaka* (1903). The Hårga's dance inherits that luminosity and adds the death the idyll excludes.

The dance unto death is one of Europe's most persistent images, and the film's version gathers its variants. The dancing plague of Strasbourg in 1518; the Pied Piper who led the children of Hamelin away with his music; Hans Christian Andersen's "The Red Shoes" (1845), whose heroine

cannot stop dancing until an executioner cuts off her feet (Andersen 1845), and Michael Powell and Emeric Pressburger's film of 1948, whose dancer dies on a railway line: each stages a compulsion of the body that music initiates and that only death can end. The most important modern version is Igor Stravinsky's *Le Sacre du printemps*, conceived with the painter and archaeologist Nicholas Roerich as a sequence of pictures of pagan Russia, choreographed by Vaslav Nijinsky, and premiered amid tumult in Paris on 29 May 1913. In its final scene a maiden chosen by the community dances herself to death to propitiate the spring. The *Rite* is modernism's archaic sacrifice par excellence, and it is itself a fabricated archive, assembled by Roerich from archaeological speculation and ethnographic fragments into a ritual that no one had ever performed. *Midsommar*'s May Queen dance is the *Rite* inverted: the chosen one does not die but rules, and the death the *Rite* assigned to her is distributed among others. T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land* (1922), whose notes acknowledge debts to Frazer and to Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920), completed modernism's absorption of the fertility-sacrifice paradigm into the cultural common sense through which the Hårga's rites are now perceived (Eliot 1922; Weston 1920). The Hårga dance, in short, to music that the twentieth century composed for them.

◉

2.6

Atlantis at Uppsala

Gothicism from Johannes Magnus to Bayreuth

The fifth station is the study in which the north invented its antiquity. In 1554 the exiled Catholic archbishop Johannes Magnus published at Rome a history of all the kings of the Goths and Swedes that traced the Swedish royal line to Magog, grandson of Noah, and claimed for Sweden the glory of the Goths who had humbled Rome (Johannes Magnus 1554). Swedish monarchs styled themselves kings of the Swedes, the Goths, and the Wends, and in the seventeenth-century age of empire Gothicism became something close to a state ideology. Its charter was a Roman text. Tacitus's *Germania*, rediscovered in the fifteenth century, offered early modern readers an image of northern peoples free, chaste, and unmixed,

and Christopher Krebs, borrowing Arnaldo Momigliano's judgment, has traced how that image made the treatise one of the most dangerous books ever written (Krebs 2011). The *Germania* also describes sacrifice. It reports that the Germans offered human victims to their chief god on fixed days (*Germania* 9), and that the goddess Nerthus, Mother Earth, was drawn among her peoples in a covered wagon, bringing days of rejoicing and peace wherever she came, after which wagon and goddess were washed in a secret lake by slaves whom the lake then swallowed (*Germania* 40; Tacitus 1970). The May Queen's procession through the Hårga's fields, in which Dani is drawn among the crops to bless them, reproduces the progress of Nerthus; the visitors consumed once the procession is over are her drowned servants.

The Gothicist imagination culminated in Olof Rudbeck's *Atlantica* (1679–1702), a four-volume demonstration that Sweden was Plato's Atlantis, that Old Uppsala had been its capital, that Swedish was the first language of humankind, and that the myths of Greece were garbled memories of Swedish history (Rudbeck 1679–1702; King 2005). Rudbeck was no crank in his other work. He had described the lymphatic vessels and built the anatomical theater at Uppsala, and his attempt to date the soils of Old Uppsala by the thickness of their layers anticipated stratigraphic method. Science and myth issued from the same hands, and the same university that produced the *ättestupa* produced Atlantis. A century later Uppsala's most famous professor turned the gaze of classification on humankind itself. Carl Linnaeus journeyed through Lapland in 1732, directing upon the Sámi the ethnographic eye that Europe was directing upon its colonies, and the tenth edition of his *Systema Naturae* (1758) divided *Homo sapiens* into varieties distinguished by color and temperament (Linnaeus 1758). The taxonomic stratum of the archive begins here, and §2.9 follows it to its consequences.

Romantic Gothicism transposed the antiquarian fantasy into poetry and pedagogy. The Gothic Society, founded in Stockholm in 1811, printed in its journal *Iduna* Erik Gustaf Geijer's poems "The Viking" and "The Yeoman Farmer," which established the twin ideals of nineteenth-century Swedish nationalism, the seafaring warrior and the free, land-owning peasant (Geijer 1811). Geijer and Arvid August Afzelius gathered the nation's ballads in *Swedish Folk Songs from Antiquity* (1814–18); Esaias Tegnér's *Frithiofs saga* (1825) became the national epic of the schoolroom; Per Henrik Ling, another member of the society, devised the gymnastics that would

discipline the Swedish body. The Hårga are the yeoman farmer without the Viking: a self-sufficient agrarian community of land, kin, and cycle, governed by elders and closed to the world except when it chooses to admit, and consume, its guests.

The Gothicist trajectory reached its aesthetic apex outside Sweden, in Richard Wagner's *Der Ring des Nibelungen*, built from the Eddas and the *Völsunga saga* and first performed complete at Bayreuth in 1876. Wagner had theorized the *Gesamtkunstwerk*, the total work of art in which poetry, music, architecture, painting, and dance would fuse into a single festival form capable of regenerating a people (Wagner [1849] 1993), and the young Nietzsche dedicated *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872) to Wagner as the herald of a reborn Dionysian community (Nietzsche [1872] 1999). The Hårga's nine-day festival is a *Gesamtkunstwerk* in the strict Wagnerian sense. It integrates architecture, mural painting, costume, music, dance, cuisine, and ritual drama into a single ordered experience whose end is the regeneration of a community. It differs from Bayreuth in one respect only: some members of its audience do not survive the performance. Chapter Three argues that *Midsommar* is itself conceived as such a total design, and that its form is the instrument through which the Hårga's festival becomes the spectator's own.

◉

2.7

The Chooser of the Slain

Brynhildr, the Drink of Forgetting, and the Burning Hall

The sixth station is a pyre, and it discloses the deepest graft in the film's composition: the breakup narrative that Aster has described as the personal core of *Midsommar* is itself among the oldest stories of the north. The heroic poems of the *Poetic Edda* and the thirteenth-century *Völsunga saga* tell how the hero Sigurðr awakened the valkyrie Brynhildr, who taught him the lore of runes, and how the two pledged themselves to each other. At the court of King Gjúki, Queen Grímhildr gave Sigurðr a drink that made him forget Brynhildr. He married Grímhildr's daughter Guðrún and, in the shape of Guðrún's brother Gunnarr, won Brynhildr for Gunnarr by riding through the wall of flame that ringed her hall. When Brynhildr

learned of the deception she demanded Sigurðr's death, and after he was killed she took her own life and was burned beside him on his pyre (Larrington 2014; Byock 1990). Wagner's *Götterdämmerung* preserved the pattern and magnified its ending. Hagen's potion, administered by Gutrune, makes Siegfried forget Brünnhilde; the betrayed Brünnhilde conspires in his murder; and in the drama's last scene she orders a pyre, rides into its flames, and the fire spreads until Valhalla, the hall of the gods, burns.

The romance plot of *Midsommar* follows the Völsung sequence step by step. Christian is plied with drinks and love magic by the women of a matriarchal house; he forgets his obligations to Dani and is joined to a daughter of that house, Maja; Dani witnesses the betrayal; she chooses his death; and he burns in a hall. The film departs from the pattern only at its end. Brynhildr dies with Sigurðr; Brünnhilde immolates herself and redeems the world through love. Dani lives, the fire consumes only the betrayer, and she smiles. Heroic love sought union in death; modern love, as the film renders it, seeks freedom through another's death. Aster's breakup film is Brynhildr's vengeance without Brynhildr's suicide—though Chapter Eight will argue that the suicide returns in displaced form, as the immolation of the self Dani was.

The parallel extends to the office Dani assumes. The word *valkyrja* means "chooser of the slain," from *valr*, the fallen, and *kjósa*, to choose. As May Queen, Dani's decisive prerogative is precisely to choose the slain: Siv instructs her that the ninth offering is hers to select, between Christian and a member of the commune drawn by lot. The film thus restores to the May Queen of Swedish custom, a figure of flowers and fertility, the archaic function of the valkyrie, a figure of death and election. Crowned with blossoms, Dani chooses as the valkyries chose.

Two further Eddic scenes illuminate the film's treatment of grief and of joy with a precision that criticism has not recognized. In the first lay of Guðrún, the widowed Guðrún sits beside Sigurðr's body and cannot weep. The wives of noblemen gather around her, and each in turn recounts her own sorrows—husbands slain, children lost, captivity endured—in order to release Guðrún's grief. None succeeds until Gullrönd draws back the shroud and bids her look upon her husband; then Guðrún weeps, her tears falling like hail (Larrington 2014). The scene is an Eddic rite of collective female lament, in which women's voices serve as a technique for opening a grief that cannot open itself. It is the archival precursor, exact in its struc-

ture, of the scene in which the Hårga women surround Dani and give her wail its chorus. In the short lay of Sigurðr, conversely, when Brynhildr hears from her bed Guðrún's cry over the slain hero, she laughs, once, with her whole heart; and Gunnarr disputes the meaning of her laughter, telling her that it is not good fortune that makes her laugh and asking why her face has lost its color (Larrington 2014).

The tradition thus already contains both of the film's climactic affects, the answered wail and the unaccountable smile, and it distributes them between two women. *Midsommar* unites them in one. Dani is first Guðrún, the woman who cannot grieve until a chorus of women grieves with her, and then Brynhildr, the woman who laughs at the death of the man who betrayed her, while a dissenting voice—Gunnarr's in the poem, the captivity reading's in the film's reception—insists that the laugh does not mean what it appears to mean. The final smile is the moment at which Guðrún becomes Brynhildr. And the interpretive quarrel with which this dissertation began, over whether that smile is liberation or capture, is some eight centuries old.



2.8

The Museum of the Folk

Skansen, Larsson, and the Painted Farmhouse

The seventh station is a museum. In 1891 Artur Hazelius, who had founded the Nordic Museum in Stockholm eighteen years earlier, opened Skansen on the island of Djurgården: the first open-air museum in the world, in which farmhouses, manors, and churches were dismantled across Sweden and reassembled on a single hill, staffed by attendants in regional dress, animated by craft demonstrations and folk dance, and furnished every June with a maypole. Skansen reconstructed rural Sweden for the city at the very moment that industrialization and an emigration of more than a million people to America were emptying the countryside. Its premise was that the folk could be preserved by being staged, and that a nation could visit its own past as tourists visit a foreign land.

Dean MacCannell, extending Erving Goffman's distinction between the front and back regions of social performance, called this arrangement

staged authenticity: tourist settings promise visitors access to the back region where real life is lived, and then stage the back region too, so that the search for authenticity is satisfied by a further performance (MacCannell 1973; 1976). The Hårga present themselves to their guests as Skansen presents Sweden: in costume, at long tables, at their crafts and their dances, with a guide, Pelle, who explains each custom in the idiom of cultural relativism. The visitors' anthropological ambition is to reach the back region, and the film punishes every attempt. Josh photographs the forbidden pages of the *Rubi Radr*; Mark urinates on the ancestral tree; Christian, appropriating Josh's thesis, presses toward what he takes to be ethnographic access. Each transgression of the front region is answered with death, and the film's grim joke is that the Hårga's back region is staged as well. The only region that is not a performance is the inside of the temple when it burns.

Carl Larsson supplies the archive's two faces in a single oeuvre. His watercolors of his family's house at Sundborn, published as *Ett hem* (1899), fixed the image of Swedish domestic happiness—light timber, painted furniture, children, flowers, open windows—that would shape Scandinavian design and its global commercial descendants (Larsson 1899). The same painter devoted the great ambition of his last years to *Midvinterblot* (1915), a vast canvas of the Swedes sacrificing King Dómaldi before the golden temple of Uppsala in the dead of winter, painted for the staircase of the Nationalmuseum, rejected by the museum in his lifetime, and installed in the place for which it was made only in 1997. Larsson contains the Hårga in nuce: the idyll and the sacrifice by the same hand, in the same palette, for the same national public. The pastel interiors of the Hårga and the blood on their rocks come from a single Swedish visual archive.

The Hårga's painted halls draw on a third tradition. In Hälsingland itself, the province in which the commune is set, prosperous farmers of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries commissioned itinerant painters to cover the interiors of their houses with flowers, ornament, and biblical scenes rendered in local dress; seven of these decorated farmhouses were inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List in 2012. Kindred traditions of painted wall hangings, *bonader*, unfolded sacred narratives in sequential panels peopled with figures in rural costume. The film's opening, a painted panorama that unfolds the entire narrative in the manner of such a hanging, presents the story we are about to watch as if it were

already scripture, rendered in the idiom of rural devotion. Selma Lagerlöf's *The Wonderful Adventures of Nils* (1906–7), commissioned as a geography reader for Swedish schools, offered the same pedagogical panorama on the scale of the nation: Sweden seen from the back of a goose, province by province, as a landscape of instruction (Lagerlöf 1906–7).

The cinema inherited this archive in Ingmar Bergman's *The Virgin Spring* (1960), adapted from the medieval ballad of Töre's daughters at Vänge and photographed by Sven Nykvist. Bergman's medieval Sweden is a palimpsest in which paganism persists beneath a Christian surface: the pregnant foster-daughter Ingeri invokes Odin against her pious foster-sister, who is raped and murdered on her way to church, and a spring rises where the girl's body lay. *Midsommar* reverses Bergman's layering. In Aster's Sweden the pagan is the surface and Christianity the faint underlayer: a saint's day absorbed into a solstice, a church to which, in the Hårga legend, the elders walked while the young danced, and a man named Christian who burns.

◉

2.9

The People's Home and Its Shadow

Breeding, Runes, and the Politics of the North

The eighth station is the twentieth century, and it is the darkest. In 1928 the Social Democratic leader Per Albin Hansson described the society he hoped to build as a *folkhem*, a people's home, in which equality, consideration, cooperation, and helpfulness would prevail and no one would be a stepchild. The image of the nation as a household that holds all its members became the governing metaphor of the Swedish welfare state, and Alva and Gunnar Myrdal's *Crisis in the Population Question* (1934) proposed an ambitious social policy to secure the nation's reproduction (Myrdal and Myrdal 1934). The same decades produced the welfare state's shadow. In 1922 the Swedish parliament founded the State Institute for Racial Biology at Uppsala under the physician Herman Lundborg, whose survey *The Racial Characters of the Swedish Nation* (1926) catalogued the population by physical type (Lundborg and Linders 1926). Sterilization laws enacted

in 1934 and broadened in 1941 remained in force until 1975, and some sixty-three thousand people, the great majority of them women, were sterilized under their provisions, on social as well as medical grounds. The history reached a wide public only in 1997, through Maciej Zaremba's articles in *Dagens Nyheter*, after which a state commission and a law of compensation followed (Broberg and Roll-Hansen 1996; Zaremba 1999).

The Hårga are the people's home in miniature, and they reproduce its shadow along with its promise. The commune holds every member from cradle to cliff; it shares possessions and parenting; it leaves no one alone in grief. It also governs reproduction with total authority. Its matings are sanctioned by the elders, who approve Maja's choice of Christian and supervise the coupling; it imports outsiders, in its elders' own phrase, as new blood; and it deliberately breeds through incest the oracle whose disability it treats as sanctity. In the Hårga the folkhem's two faces, the home that cares and the institute that selects, are fused in a single institution. Roberto Esposito's account of the immunitary paradigm, examined in Chapter Four, describes the logic exactly: a community protects its life by controlling which bodies may reproduce and which must be removed.

The film's casting makes the commune's uniformity visible. The Hårga are white, fair, and dressed in white; the guests killed for the rite form a more various company than their hosts, and among them is Josh, the Black American anthropologist who dies for attempting to photograph the scripture. The archive on which the commune draws has never been politically innocent. Guido von List claimed to have received his system of eighteen Armanen runes in a vision during a period of blindness in 1902, and his rune mysticism passed into the iconography of National Socialism (List 1908; Goodrick-Clarke 1985); the SS research institute known as the Ahnenerbe, founded in 1935, counted among its founders Herman Wirth, who sought a primordial Nordic religion in the Bronze Age rock carvings of Bohuslän (Pringle 2006). The Hårga's runic garments and runic scripture carry this contamination whether or not the film intends it, and the film neither conceals it nor exploits it.

The archive's popular afterlives have been as ambivalent as its scholarly ones. The Swedish band Bathory, whose album *Blood Fire Death* (1988) took as its cover Peter Nicolai Arbo's national-romantic painting of Odin's Wild Hunt, *Åsgårdsreien* (1872), carried the iconography of the Gothic Society into extreme metal. In Norway, the black metal milieu of the early

1990s turned its rhetoric of heathen revival into the arson of churches, beginning with the stave church at Fantoft in 1992 (Moynihan and Søderlind 1998). The Hårga, who burn a man named Christian, perform as rite what that milieu performed as crime. Contemporary heathenry, meanwhile, remains divided between inclusive currents and ethnically exclusive ones. *Midsommar* belongs to this history without belonging to any faction within it. Its achievement is to render the beauty of the Nordic idyll and its biopolitical horror in a single image, denying the aesthetic its innocence and the horror its simplicity. The flowers and the sterilizations, the maypole and the institute, issue from one archive.

◉

2.10

Conclusion

Tradition as the Most Modern Artifact

The ninth station returns to the temple. Robin Hardy's *The Wicker Man*, the film to which *Midsommar* is most often compared, contains a speech that *Midsommar* conspicuously withholds. Lord Summerisle explains to Sergeant Howie that his grandfather, a Victorian agronomist, developed new strains of fruit for the barren island and, to make its people cultivate them with conviction, restored to them the joyous worship of the old gods. The islanders' paganism is a third-generation product of enlightened estate management, an invented tradition that confesses its invention. The Hårga's never does. The film gives no genealogy of the commune, no founder, no date, no motive; it offers instead a scripture still being written. This withholding is the source of the Hårga's power. An archive whose origin cannot be located, because it is continuously produced, is an archive that cannot be refuted, and its antiquity is guaranteed by nothing except the community's present conviction.

Eric Hobsbawm defined invented traditions as responses to novel situations that take the form of reference to old situations, and he observed that they proliferate when rapid social transformation weakens the patterns for which older traditions had been designed (Hobsbawm and Ranger 1983). The Hårga answer exactly to the definition. The novel situation to which they respond is the late-modern collapse of holding analyzed in Chapter

One; the old situation to which they refer is the archive excavated in this chapter. Their antiquity is the form their modernity takes. This is the precise sense of Proposition IV: tradition is the most modern of the Hårga's artifacts, and its function is to offer the unheld subjects of the present the fantasy of a community older than history, in which no one need ever again face loss alone.

The nine stations have also shown that the archive is not innocent. Each stratum carries a sacrifice of its own: Odin's eye and the hanged of his tree; the seventy-two bodies of Adam's grove and the dirges he would not transcribe; a satire on avarice converted by Uppsala's antiquarians into a custom that Swedish schoolchildren learned as history; the drowned servants of Nerthus and the dancing maiden of the *Rite*; Brynhildr's pyre; the varieties of Linnaeus and the sterilizations of the people's home; the runes of List and the churches of Fantoft. The Hårga gather these sacrifices into a single community, and in doing so they make visible what every effect of antiquity conceals: that it is purchased. Every *arkheion* has its archons, and every archive, the film suggests, has its fire.

The dissertation now turns from the materials of the Hårga to the medium in which they are rendered. The archive excavated in this chapter reaches the spectator not as information but as form: as composition, color, symmetry, and above all light. The festival is held at midsummer in a province where the June sun dips only briefly below the horizon and the night never fully darkens, and the film renders its horror in the unrelenting brightness of a sky that will not set. Chapter Three examines that brightness.





CHAPTER THREE

Apollonian Dread

The Formal Grammar of Daylight Horror

nur als aesthetisches Phänomen ist das Dasein und die Welt ewig gerechtfertigt.

— Friedrich Nietzsche, *Die Geburt der Tragödie* (1872), §5

And the gates of it shall not be shut at all by day: for there shall be no night there.

— Revelation 21:25

3.1

Apollo Ascendant

Inverting The Birth of Tragedy

Nietzsche's first book divided Greek art between two powers. Apollo, whose name Nietzsche glossed as "the shining one," was the god of light and of dreams, of measure and limit, of the beautiful illusion of form; he was also, Nietzsche added, the soothsaying god, the god of prophecy. Above all he presided over what Nietzsche, borrowing from Schopenhauer, called the *principium individuationis*, the principle by which the world appears as a plurality of separate, bounded individuals. Dionysus, god of intoxication, presided over the collapse of that principle. In the Dionysian festival, Nietzsche wrote, the boundaries between persons dissolve, the estranged individual is reconciled with others and with nature, and the veil that separates the self from the primordial unity of being is torn to shreds (Nietzsche [1872] 1999). Attic tragedy was born of their union. Its origin was the Dionysian chorus, which Nietzsche

described as the mirror in which Dionysian humanity contemplated itself; its Apollonian element was the dream-image on the stage, the hero's individuated form projected out of the chorus's ecstasy; and its effect upon the spectator, seated in the theater's concentric terraces, was to let him look past the whole world of civilization and imagine himself one of the chorus. The Apollonian, in this scheme, is a protective veil. It makes the Dionysian abyss bearable by giving it form, and it is in this sense that Nietzsche could declare, in the sentence that stands at the head of this chapter, that only as an aesthetic phenomenon are existence and the world eternally justified.

Midsommar is a Nietzschean tragedy turned inside out. Its contents are Dionysian through and through: psilocybin in a meadow, hallucinogenic draughts at the feast, a dance prolonged into collapse, a coupling rite performed before a chorus of women, the dissolution of private grief into collective wailing, and at the last a fire into which a man is given for the community's renewal. Each is an image of the *principium individuationis* abolished. Yet the film renders them in a form that is Apollonian in every particular: in daylight that never yields to night, in compositions of insistent symmetry, in long takes that hold their objects at a measured distance, in a palette of white, yellow, and pale blue, and in a narrative so thoroughly prophesied in advance that nothing in it can surprise. In Nietzsche's tragedy the Apollonian veils the Dionysian; in *Midsommar* the Apollonian administers it. The Hårga's ecstasies are scheduled, lit, measured, and foretold. Their intoxication runs on a timetable.

The result is a species of terror for which the horror film has no settled name, and which this chapter calls *Apollonian dread*: the dread not of chaos but of order, not of darkness but of light, not of the unknown but of the foreknown, not of the formless but of form itself. The classical horror film frightens by withholding: shadow, offscreen space, the sudden shock. *Midsommar* frightens by disclosure. It shows everything, in focus and in sunlight, and it shows it in a design so complete that the spectator comes to understand that the design is itself the threat. The Hårga's power is a formal power, and the film's form is not a neutral vehicle for representing that power but the instrument through which it is exercised, first upon the visitors and then upon us.

Apollo himself was never as serene as Nietzsche's polarity suggests. He was the archer whose arrows brought plague upon the Greek camp at Troy, and the god who flayed the satyr Marsyas. In Apollodorus's version of that

myth, the musical contest between Apollo's lyre and Marsyas's pipes was decided when Apollo turned his instrument upside down and played it so, challenging the satyr to do the same; Marsyas could not, and the god hung him from a tall pine and stripped off his skin (Apollodorus 1921, 1.4.2). The myth condenses the formal grammar this chapter traces. The Apollonian triumphs by inversion, hangs its rival from a tree, and flays him. *Midsommar* turns its world upside down on the road to the Hårga, and it flays its own satyr. Mark, the most Dionysian of the visitors, a heedless pleasure-seeker who urinates on the ancestral tree, is skinned by the commune; a man wearing his face kills Josh; and his straw-stuffed body ends in the temple wearing a jester's cap, fulfilling the name of a game, Skin the Fool, that the commune's young people had played before the visitors' eyes. Simon is displayed in a barn in the posture of the "blood eagle," a Viking rite that Roberta Frank showed to have been largely the creation of later misreadings of skaldic verse (Frank 1984), and so one more invention of the archive examined in Chapter Two. Christian, by contrast, dies not flayed but enclosed. The commune adds a skin rather than removing one, sewing him into the hide of a bear.

3.2

No Night There

Daylight Horror and the Politics of Visibility

Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* of 1757 laid down the law that the literature and cinema of terror would obey for two centuries: "To make any thing very terrible, obscurity seems in general to be necessary" (Burke 1757, pt. 2, sec. 3). Terror, for Burke, required darkness, vagueness, and the withheld; the beautiful, by contrast, was smooth, small, delicate, and clear. The Gothic novel and the horror film accepted the division. Their castles are night-bound, their monsters half-glimpsed, their climaxes staged by candle and moon. *Midsommar* violates Burke's law so systematically that the violation constitutes a poetics. Its terror is clear, bright, and composed; it frightens with the very qualities Burke assigned to beauty.

The film had predecessors in this inversion, and together they form a counter-tradition of daylight dread. The opening dream of Bergman's

Wild Strawberries (1957) unfolds on a deserted street in merciless sunlight, before a clock without hands and a hearse whose coffin spills out the dreamer's own corpse, and the same director closed *The Seventh Seal* (1957) with a dance of death silhouetted against a pale sky. Alfred Hitchcock staged the most celebrated attack of *North by Northwest* (1959) in an empty field under a high sun, where there is nowhere to hide because there is nothing to hide behind. Peter Weir's *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (1975) loses its schoolgirls on a hot, bright Valentine's Day afternoon, in a landscape whose beauty is indistinguishable from its menace. Tobe Hooper's *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre* (1974) ends not in darkness but in the morning, its killer swinging his chainsaw in a frustrated dance against the sky, and Robin Hardy's *The Wicker Man* burns its victim on a radiant May Day. *Midsommar* gathers this counter-tradition into a single, sustained program. Once the visitors arrive in Hälsingland, the film never again shows true night. The sun lingers late into the evening and returns almost before it has gone; the visitors, disoriented, discover that the bright evening is already late; sleep, deprived of darkness, loses its boundaries; and the festival's nine days blur into one continuous day.

Hälsingland lies south of the Arctic Circle, and its midsummer produces not the true midnight sun but nights of persistent twilight, in which the sun dips briefly below the horizon and the sky never fully darkens. The film pushes this northern light toward the absolute. Its Sweden borrows the attributes of Thule, the far northern land in which, Procopius reported, the sun at the summer solstice does not set for forty days (Procopius 1919, VI.15), and it fulfills the promise that Revelation makes of the heavenly city in this chapter's epigraph: there shall be no night there.

The light has a function, and its function is political. Darkness is the condition of privacy, of secrecy, of solitude, of dissent: in darkness one may hide, sleep alone, slip away. The Hårga abolish darkness as they abolish the private. The guests sleep in a communal hall, eat at common tables, and find no hour in which they are unobserved. Michel Foucault's analysis of the panoptic institution, in which permanent visibility produces a subject who disciplines himself, condensed the principle into the dictum that visibility is a trap (Foucault [1975] 1977). The Hårga's sun is a panopticon without a tower, a surveillance exercised by light itself and by a community that is everywhere at once. The visitors who seek concealment—Josh in the temple by night, Mark beyond the tree—are precisely those who die.

In this sense the film's light is the visual form of the holding environment. The prologue's unheld grief took place in darkness: in a sealed house at night, in an apartment where Dani wept alone. The commune holds Dani by never letting her be alone, and it secures that holding by never letting it be dark.

The Western philosophical tradition has equated light with truth and liberation. Plato's prisoners are released from the cave into the sunlight of the Good (Plato 1992, 514a–520a), and the Enlightenment named itself after the light. *Midsommar* inverts the allegory. Dani passes from the darkness of an American winter into a world of perpetual sun, and the passage is not an emancipation from illusion but an initiation into a truth so total that it leaves no shadow in which a separate self might hide. Adorno and Horkheimer opened their critique of enlightenment by observing that the fully enlightened earth glows with a calamity that has triumphed (Adorno and Horkheimer [1947] 2002). The Hårga's earth is fully enlightened in the most literal sense, and its radiance anticipates the fire to come.

3.3

The Painted Prophecy

Prolepsis, Mise en Abyme, and the Commune as Metteur en Scène

Midsommar begins at its end. Before its first scene it presents a painted panorama, in the manner of the folk hangings discussed in §2.8, that narrates the whole film in compressed allegorical form: the darkened household and its deaths, the summons and the journey, the sunlit commune, the crowning, the fire. The film then fills its world with paintings, tapestries, carvings, and runes that foretell what is about to happen. Murals in the commune's buildings lay out the stages of the love magic that will be worked upon Christian and the coupling rite that will follow; a bear caged in the commune from the visitors' first day announces the skin in which Christian will die; the young people of the Hårga play a game called Skin the Fool, whose name the film later fulfills upon Mark; and the visitors pass these signs daily without reading them. In Gérard Genette's narratological vocabulary the film is saturated with prolepsis, the anticipation of events not yet narrated (Genette [1972] 1980), and most of its

prolepses are of the kind Genette called repeating: they announce events that the film will later show in full.

The effect is the one Alfred Hitchcock described in his celebrated distinction between surprise and suspense. A bomb that explodes without warning beneath a table yields a few seconds of surprise; a bomb shown to the audience before the characters sit down yields minutes of suspense, because the audience knows what the characters do not (Truffaut 1967). *Midsommar* shows the bomb in its first image. Its horror is almost never surprise; it is the slow suspense of foreknowledge, the dramatic irony of a spectator who has been told the ending and must watch the characters walk toward it. That epistemic position is not neutral. The only people within the film who share it are the elders, who know the plan, who have read the *Rubi Radr*, and who watch the visitors with the serene patience of those who know what will be. By granting its spectators foreknowledge, the film seats them among the elders. Proposition V named the invitation to read like an elder as one face of conscription; prolepsis is its formal mechanism. Nietzsche's Apollo, it will be recalled, was at once the god of light and the god of prophecy, and the film's daylight and its foreknowledge are two expressions of a single Apollonian regime.

The narrative is foreknown in a second sense. Aster's description of *Midsommar* as a *Wizard of Oz* for perverts identifies its genre, and the fairy tale has the most rigidly predetermined plot in narrative art. Vladimir Propp showed that the Russian wondertale is built from a fixed repertoire of thirty-one functions whose sequence never varies, and that its last four complete the tale: the false hero or villain is exposed; the hero is given a new appearance; the villain is punished; and the hero is married and ascends the throne (Propp [1928] 1968). The final act of *Midsommar* executes these functions in order. Christian's betrayal is exposed before Dani's eyes; Dani is transfigured, clothed in a gown of flowers; Christian is punished in the fire; and Dani is enthroned as queen among a new family to which she is, in the commune's sense, wedded. The film's horror is the fairy tale's happy ending performed to the letter. Its form is not only proleptic in its paintings but predestined in its morphology: once the genre is recognized, the end is written.

The paintings within the film are also images of the film. André Gide borrowed from heraldry the phrase *mise en abyme* for the miniature within a work that reproduces the work as a whole, and Lucien Dällenbach sys-

tematized the device as the mirror in the text (Dällenbach [1977] 1989). The opening panorama, the murals, and the *Rubi Radr* are such mirrors, and they belong to a pattern that runs through Aster's work. In *Hereditary* the mother is a miniaturist whose dioramas reproduce her family's catastrophes, and the film's first shot glides into one of her dollhouse rooms until it becomes the room in which the story begins; the miniature contains the film, and the cult that has engineered every event stands, like the miniaturist, outside the house it controls. In *Beau Is Afraid* the hero's life proves to have been staged and watched by his mother, and he sees his own story performed as a play in a forest. Aster's films repeatedly incarnate their own authorship within the fiction, as a collective or a parent who has designed the plot. In *Midsommar* that author is the Hårga. The commune is a metteur en scène: its festival is a production, its murals are storyboards, its scripture is a screenplay still in draft, and its oracle, bred to be unclouded by ordinary cognition, is the unconscious from which the script is drawn. The film's total design and the commune's total plan coincide, and the coincidence is the source of the film's peculiar dread. The visitors are victims neither of chance nor of a monster but of a composition.

The film's reception completed the circuit. Few recent films have generated so extensive a culture of decoding: frame-by-frame inventories of runes and paintings, theories assigning each visitor's death to one of the four elements, catalogues of the number nine. The spectators who perform this labor read the film as the elders read the *Rubi Radr*, as an oracular text whose every mark is significant and whose meaning has been fixed in advance. The film has made of its audience a college of interpreters.

3.4

The Tyranny of the Center

Symmetry, Frontality, and Composition as Capture

The Hårga's world is built on symmetry, and Pawel Pogorzelski's camera photographs it in frontal, centered compositions to which the film returns throughout. The yellow temple rises as a triangle; the feast tables stretch in long parallel ranks; the maypole stands at the center of concentric rings of dancers; the elders sit in a row facing their guests; the May Queen is

enthroned at the axis of the frame. Erwin Panofsky argued that the central perspective of the Renaissance was a symbolic form, a way of organizing the visible world around the fixed eye of a single beholder and thereby constituting that beholder as a subject (Panofsky [1927] 1991). The symmetrical frame of *Midsommar* organizes its world around a different center: not the eye of an individual but the axis of a community. Its vanishing points are the temple, the pole, and the throne. The individual who enters that axis is not empowered by it but absorbed.

The model is Stanley Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980), whose one-point perspectives and symmetrical corridors render the Overlook Hotel as a total environment designed to absorb the man who enters it as caretaker. *The Shining* ends on a photograph of a ballroom party in 1921, in which the protagonist appears at the center of the crowd, smiling: the hotel has always had him, and the image proves it. The final tableau of *Midsommar* is a pendant to Kubrick's photograph. Dani stands at the center of the frame, crowned and robed, her new family arrayed around her and the burning temple behind; she too has been incorporated into an image that seems to have been waiting for her, the image that the opening panorama had already painted. To be centered in such a composition is to be held, and to be held in the frame is to be fixed.

Kubrick supplies a second model in *Eyes Wide Shut* (1999), whose masked ritual at a country mansion stages sexuality as liturgy: participants arranged in a ceremonial circle, a presiding figure at its center, an intruder discovered and threatened, a woman who offers herself in his place. The coupling rite of *Midsommar* shares this liturgical geometry—the circle of witnesses, the officiating elders, the outsider at the center of a ceremony he does not understand—but replaces Kubrick's masks with bare faces and his candlelit night with afternoon light. The Hårga have no need of masks. Their ritual is not secret; it is simply inescapable.

The most radical precedent for the film's frontality lies in the cinema of Sergei Parajanov. In *The Color of Pomegranates* (1969), Parajanov abandoned narrative continuity for a sequence of frontal tableaux in which ritual gestures, symbolic objects, and costumed figures are arranged flat against the frame like icons; in *Shadows of Forgotten Ancestors* (1965) he immersed the spectator in the cyclical rites of a Carpathian community governed by seasons, magic, and the dead. Parajanov's tableaux suspend the time of story in the time of ritual, and *Midsommar*'s ceremonies bor-

row that suspension. At the feast, at the cliff, and at the coronation, the film stills its movement into tableau, and the spectator, held before an image composed with liturgical exactness, experiences the commune's time as the time of the icon, which does not pass but returns.

◉

3.5

The World Upside Down

Inversion as the Film's Master Figure

The visitors' entry into Hälsingland is marked by the film's most celebrated shot. An aerial camera follows the car along a forest road, rises over it, and rotates as it passes, until the car is driving along the top of the frame with the sky beneath; the image holds, upside down, as the car passes under a banner strung across the road, and the world rights itself only as the visitors arrive. The banner, in Swedish, calls for an end to mass immigration to Hälsingland and urges a vote for a "free north." Aster has said that the film had such matters on its mind but that he did not want to be too on the nose, and so arranged for the banner to be seen upside down as the camera turns (Aster 2019). The inversion hides the slogan in plain sight. The commune's politics, whose archival genealogy §2.9 traced, enter the film inverted, legible only to a spectator who turns the image right side up in the mind.

The shot is a hinge, and it is not alone. A few minutes earlier the film made a transition of the same kind, in a single continuous movement that carries Dani from a breakdown in her apartment's bathroom into a breakdown in an airplane lavatory, as if the two rooms were one. Across *Midsommar*, inversion is the master figure, and it operates at every scale. Winter becomes summer and night becomes day. The unanswered wail becomes the answered wail. A family that dies in secret becomes a family that kills in public. The legend of a demonic dance becomes a dance of election; the ballet in which the chosen maiden dies becomes a contest in which she reigns; Oz, the land from which Dorothy longs to return, becomes the home that Dani will never wish to leave; and tragic recognition, which ends in pity and fear, becomes the euphoric recognition with which the film concludes. The rhetorical name for this structure is chiasmus, the

crossing of terms in reverse order, and the film's governing equation is chiastic: the holding is the burning, and the burning is the holding.

Inversion also governs the architecture of the whole. Prologue and finale mirror each other across the body of the festival. In the prologue, a sister kills her family in darkness and Dani's cry goes unanswered. In the finale, Dani—whom the women of the commune now call their sister—watches her new family kill in daylight, and every cry but one is answered. Even the elders' cliff inverts the prologue's death: one is a fall into nothing, the other a fall into the community's arms. The world Dani enters is not other than the world she leaves; it is the same world turned upside down. That is why the final smile, seen from the side of the old world, looks like madness, and seen from the side of the new, looks like health. The film asks its spectators to hold both views at once, as the shot on the road asks them to read a banner hung upside down.

3.6

The Breathing World

Hallucination, Flowers, and the Visible Holding Environment

The film's representation of altered states is among its subtlest formal achievements. Where the psychedelic cinema of the 1960s rendered intoxication through saturation, distortion, and kaleidoscopic montage, *Midsommar* renders it through the gentlest possible animation of surfaces. During the mushroom trip in the meadow, grass appears to grow through the back of Dani's hand. At the feast, tables and faces undulate almost imperceptibly, and a flower in Dani's crown seems to wink. In the finale, the immense gown of blossoms in which she is enthroned appears to breathe, its petals rising and falling with a respiration that is not quite her own. The world does not dissolve into chaos; it comes alive. Matter acquires breath.

The image has a precise meaning within the argument of this dissertation. Winnicott distinguished the *object-mother*, the mother as target of the infant's excited needs, from the *environment-mother*, the mother as the total ambience of care that holds the infant and shields it from the unpredictable (Winnicott [1963] 1965). The breathing world of *Midsommar* is the environment-mother made visible. The grass that grows through

Dani's hand, the tables that breathe at the feast, and the gown that respires around her body each depict an environment that has become a living body, continuous with the subject, enfolding her and breathing with her. Nietzsche's Dionysian ecstasy reconciled the individual with nature by dissolving the boundary between them. The film renders that reconciliation as a regression to the earliest form of holding, in which there is not yet a boundary between infant and environment to dissolve.

The gown is the culmination of this logic, and it has a counterpart. In the final sequence two figures are enclosed in garments that envelop them entirely but for the face. Dani is encased in flowers, living, breathing, crowned. Christian is sewn into the eviscerated carcass of a bear, paralyzed, mute, and soon burning. The two garments form the film's last diptych and its most exact image of the equation that this dissertation reads in the smile: two enclosures, one living and one dead; two skins, one that holds and one that consumes. The flower gown is a holding environment worn as clothing. The bear is its negative, the skin of a creature whose death the community has prepared as a vessel for the man it will let fall.

The theme of an environment that overwhelms its visitors' boundaries has a precedent in Michael Powell and Emeric Pressburger's *Black Narcissus* (1947), in which a community of nuns established in a palace high in the Himalayas is undone by the wind, the altitude, the color, and the sensual memories with which the place assails them. Jack Cardiff's Technicolor makes the environment itself the agent of the nuns' disintegration, and the film ends with a fall from a bell tower over a precipice. *Midsommar* extends the conceit and reverses its moral charge. The nuns are undone by an environment that resists their discipline; Dani is remade by an environment that answers her need. In both, the environment wins.

Edvard Munch supplies the iconography that the breathing world answers. In *The Scream* (1893), a figure on a bridge presses its hands to its head against a cry that, in Munch's own account, passed through nature itself; sky and fjord vibrate with a sound the figure cannot escape. *The Scream* is the image of a cry that isolates: the world screams, and the self is alone with the scream. *Midsommar* inverts the image. Nature still answers the cry, but its answer is no longer terror; it is accompaniment. Munch's *Dance of Life* (1899–1900), set on a midsummer night on a Norwegian shore, arranges a woman in white, a woman in red dancing with a man, and a woman in black, dressed as if in mourning, into an allegory of the stages of love and

life. The Hårga's midsummer dances the same allegory to a different end. The mourner is clothed in flowers and crowned, and the man is given to the fire.

3·7

The Chorus as Spectator

Body Genres, Laughter, and the Distribution of Sympathy

Linda Williams identified three "body genres" in popular cinema—horror, melodrama, and pornography—distinguished by their spectacle of a body seized by an excess of sensation or emotion and by the involuntary mimicry they elicit in the spectator, whose own body shudders, weeps, or is stirred in sympathy with the body on the screen (Williams 1991). *Midsommar* stages all three in sequence, and in each it does something without precedent in the tradition: it places within the frame a chorus that performs the mimicry the genre solicits from its audience. At the cliff, when the second elder survives his fall with shattered legs, the assembled commune answers his moans with its own: horror's scream, mirrored. After Dani witnesses Christian's betrayal, the women of the commune answer her sobbing with theirs: melodrama's tears, mirrored. At the coupling rite, a ring of older women echoes the cries of the ceremony: the third genre's spectacle, mirrored. The Hårga chorus is a diegetic audience. It is the body-genre spectator materialized within the frame, responding to each spectacle exactly as the genre asks its audience to respond.

This doubling transforms the spectator's position. Nietzsche held that the Greek spectator could imagine himself a member of the tragic chorus; *Midsommar* shows its spectators a chorus and invites them to recognize themselves in it. In doing so the film makes its own affective machinery visible. It discloses that the bodily mimicry on which horror, melodrama, and sexual spectacle depend is a social technique, and that the community which practices it most perfectly is the one that kills. The spectator who weeps with Dani among the wailing women is already wailing with the Hårga.

The film's comedy has a function in this economy. The coupling rite, staged with a ceremonial solemnity that tips into absurdity, was met in

many theaters with laughter, and Christian's subsequent flight across the commune is played as farce. Henri Bergson defined the comic as the mechanical encrusted upon the living, and he observed that laughter requires *une anesthésie momentanée du cœur*, a momentary anesthesia of the heart: we laugh at those with whom we have, for an instant, ceased to sympathize (Bergson [1900] 1911). The laughter the film provokes at Christian's expense is Bergsonian in exactly this sense. It suspends the audience's sympathy for a man who is himself drugged and used, and it does so on the eve of his death. The comedy anesthetizes the spectator's heart toward the victim the film is about to burn. Laughter, the opposite of the mirroring chorus, is its accomplice: the chorus extends sympathy to those the community will hold, and laughter withdraws it from those the community will let fall.

The score completes the distribution. Michel Chion distinguished *empathetic* film music, which expresses the emotion of a scene, from *anempathetic* music, which proceeds with conspicuous indifference to the suffering it accompanies (Chion [1990] 1994). Bobby Krlic's music for the finale is both at once. As the temple burns, the score rises to an ecstatic, almost romantic climax that is empathetic toward Dani, whose transformation it celebrates, and anempathetic toward the burning, whose victims it ignores. The music mirrors one affect and lets the others fall; it performs, at the level of sound, the Hårga's economy of holding. The spectator carried on its swell is carried where Dani is carried, into the joy that the fire finances.

◉

3.8

The Burning Woman and the Watching Woman

Dreyer, Bergman, and the Final Close-up

Midsommar ends on a face. Its last movement holds Dani in close-up as the temple burns, and her expression passes through horror, grief, and bewilderment before it settles into a smile; then the screen goes black. Béla Balázs, the first great theorist of the close-up, argued that the cinema had revealed the human face as a landscape of minute movements in which the inner life becomes visible (Balázs 1952), and Gilles Deleuze made the face the paradigm of what he called the affection-image (Deleuze [1983] 1986).

The final close-up of *Midsommar* is the place where the film's equation becomes visible. In a single face, without a cut, the meaning of the fire passes from catastrophe to deliverance.

The close-up has a lineage in Scandinavian cinema, and it is a lineage of burning women. Carl Theodor Dreyer's *The Passion of Joan of Arc* (1928) composed its heroine's trial almost entirely of close-ups and culminated in her burning before a crowd whose grief turns to riot. Dreyer's *Day of Wrath* (1943), set amid the Danish witch persecutions of the seventeenth century, opens its drama with the burning of an old woman, Herlofs Marte, as a boys' choir sings, and follows much of her ordeal through the eyes of a young woman, Anne, who watches. By the film's end Anne, accused in turn, confesses before her judges, and Dreyer leaves undecided whether she has been revealed as what the community says she is or remade into it. *Midsommar* inherits both films and inverts them. Its heroine does not burn; she watches. And like Anne, she accepts at the last the identity the community has prepared for her, though the identity is not witch but queen. The burning woman of Dreyer's cinema becomes, in Aster's, the woman who watches the burning: Falconetti's face of martyrdom becomes Pugh's face of rapture.

Ingmar Bergman supplies the other half of the lineage. *Persona* (1966) fused the faces of two women into a single composite image, the cinema's most famous figure of one identity dissolving into another, and *Cries and Whispers* (1972) surrounded a dying woman with women whose care and whose coldness are alike rendered as cries. Most pertinently, *Smiles of a Summer Night* (1955) gave the Swedish summer night its mythology of the smile. The groom Frid explains that the summer night smiles three times: first, at midnight, for young lovers; second, for fools and jesters; and third, in the hours before dawn, for the sad, the depressed, the sleepless, the confused, the frightened, and the lonely. Bergman is reported to have spoken of the comedy's construction as an equation to be solved, four couples mixed and then resolved. Dani's smile is the third smile of the summer night. It is the smile reserved for the sad, the sleepless, the frightened, and the lonely, and it arrives, as Frid promised, at the end of the night. In the Hårga's Hälsingland, however, the night never comes, and the smile must be purchased with fire.

3.9

Tarkovsky's Fire

Sacrifice, Beauty, and the Aesthetic Justification of the World

The film's most consequential cinematic precursor was made in Sweden by a Russian. Andrei Tarkovsky's *The Sacrifice* (1986), shot on the island of Gotland with Bergman's cinematographer Sven Nykvist and Bergman's actor Erland Josephson, tells of a man, Alexander, who on the eve of a nuclear catastrophe vows to give up everything he loves if the world is spared; who, on the counsel of a strange visitor, spends the night with a woman named Maria, said to be a witch, as the condition of the world's salvation; and who, finding the world restored the next morning, keeps his vow by setting fire to his house. Tarkovsky filmed the burning in a single long take in pale northern light, and when the camera failed during the first attempt the house was rebuilt so that it could be burned again. The film's last images show Alexander's young son watering a dead tree that father and son had planted at the opening, in the hope that daily care might bring it to life.

The correspondences with *Midsommar* are close enough to suggest that the later film answers the earlier. Both stage a sexual union with a "witch" as a condition of renewal; both culminate in the burning of a building in Swedish daylight; both set a tree at the center of their rites; both ask whether a sacrifice can secure the continuation of a world. The difference, however, is absolute. Tarkovsky's sacrifice is a self-sacrifice. Alexander gives his own house, his own family, and finally his own sanity, and the film never decides whether the gift was efficacious or whether he is simply mad. The Hårga's sacrifice is a sacrifice of others, and its efficacy is guaranteed by nothing but the community's conviction. Tarkovsky's *Andrei Rublev* (1966) had already set a Christian monk among the pagan revelers of a Kupala night, the Slavic midsummer, where he is bound to a post, tempted by a woman of the rite, and released, while by morning the pagans are being hunted by the prince's soldiers. *Midsommar* reverses the outcome. The pagans prevail, and the man called Christian burns.

Tarkovsky described cinema as the sculpting of time (Tarkovsky [1986] 1987), and the long takes of *Midsommar* sculpt time in his manner—at the

cliff, at the feast, in the gliding passage through the gassed house of the prologue—holding the spectator inside duration until the event can no longer be escaped. Here the formal analysis of this chapter meets its ethical question. Nietzsche's dictum that only as an aesthetic phenomenon are existence and the world eternally justified might stand as the creed of a film whose beauty is total. Every frame of *Midsommar* is composed, lit, and colored with a care that makes it beautiful as a painting is beautiful, and the beauty is not separable from the horror; it is the horror's medium. Kant defined the beautiful as purposiveness without purpose, the appearance of design in an object that serves no end (Kant [1790] 2000). The beauty of *Midsommar* is the inverse: purposiveness with a purpose, disguised as purposelessness. Every flower foretells, every symmetry captures, every painting prophesies, and the beauty that seems to exist for its own sake proves to have been, from the first frame, the instrument of a plan. Apollonian dread, in its final form, is the dread of a beauty discovered to have a purpose, and of the discovery, in the last close-up, that the purpose includes us.

Walter Benjamin closed his essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility with a warning that the aestheticization of politics culminates in a humanity so estranged from itself that it can experience its own destruction as an aesthetic pleasure of the first order (Benjamin [1936] 1968). Chapter Seven returns to Benjamin. Here it is enough to observe that *Midsommar* stages, and invites its audience to undergo, precisely the experience Benjamin feared: the enjoyment of destruction as spectacle. The film does not simply indulge that pleasure. It exposes its mechanism, through the chorus that models the audience's mimicry, the comedy that numbs its sympathy, and the score that sweeps it into joy. But exposure is not exemption. The spectator who understands the mechanism still feels the swell.

3.10

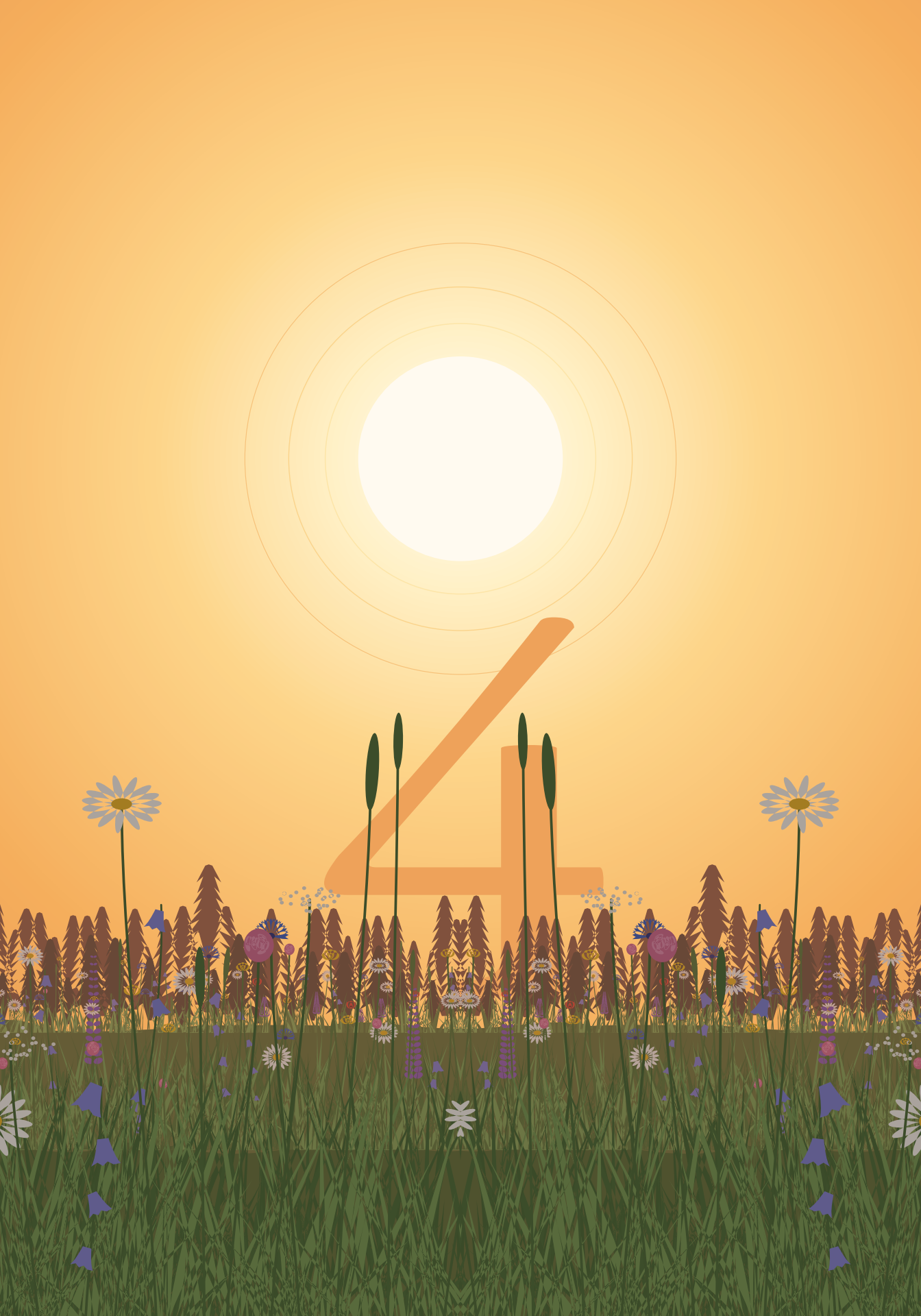
Conclusion

Form as Holding Environment

The formal grammar traced in this chapter can be summarized in a single claim: the form of *Midsommar* is itself a holding environment. It holds its spectators in a light that never fails; in compositions that center and fix; in a foreknowledge that seats them among the elders and a fairy-tale morphology that writes the ending in advance; in a world that breathes with its heroine; in a chorus that models their bodily response; in a comedy that numbs their sympathy where sympathy would be inconvenient; and in a score that carries them into the heroine's joy. Like the Hårga's holding of Dani, the film's holding of its audience is genuine. Its beauty consoles, its music moves, its ending releases. And like the Hårga's holding, it has its price. What the film holds, it holds by mirroring, and what it cannot mirror—the mute man in the bear, the victims whose burning the score ignores—it lets fall.

Freud observed that the German word *heimlich*, "homely," belonging to the house, develops in the direction of ambivalence until it coincides with its opposite, *unheimlich*, the uncanny, because what belongs to the house is also what is concealed within it (Freud [1919] 1955). Pelle asked Dani whether Christian felt like home. The commune offers her a home in the fullest sense, and the film's form makes that home uncanny in Freud's exact sense: familiar, beautiful, protective, and, at its center, a place where something is burning.

In Nietzsche's tragedy, the Apollonian saved the spectator from the Dionysian abyss by veiling it in beautiful form. In *Midsommar* the beautiful form is the abyss, and the veil is the fire. The next chapter turns from form to the economy that the form conceals: the logic of sacrifice, gift, hospitality, and immunity by which the Hårga finance the holding of the few with the destruction of the many.



CHAPTER FOUR

The Accursed Share in the Sunlit Field

Sacrifice, Gift, Hospitality, Immunity

ἀνέμισγε δὲ σίτῳ
φάρμακα λύγρ', ἵνα πάγχυ λαθοίατο πατρίδος αἴης.

— Homer, *Odyssey* 10.235–36

And the goat shall bear upon him all their iniquities unto a land not inhabited.

— Leviticus 16:22

4.1

Gift, Poison, Pharmakon

The Welcome Cup

In Swedish, *gift* is two words. As an adjective it means married; as a noun it means poison. English has kept a third sense, the present, which is the oldest: the Germanic word named a giving, and in early northern usage it named the gift that sealed a marriage. A year before he published his essay on the gift, Marcel Mauss devoted a short note to the paradox that the same Germanic word should have come to mean a present in one language and a poison in another, and he found the explanation in the archaic law of exchange, in which a gift was at once a bond and a danger: a thing that obliges whoever accepts it and may destroy whoever cannot repay (Mauss 1924). The Hårga's dealings with their guests compose a



Gift They give, they marry, and they poison, and the three operations are one.

lexicon of this word. They give, they marry, and they poison, and the three operations are one.

The visitors' induction is punctuated by offerings. Psilocybin is shared in a meadow before they reach the commune, and the meals of the festival's first days follow. Then come the food and drink, worked with love magic, that are served to Christian; the draught that Dani drinks before the dance; the tea pressed on Christian before the coupling rite; the powder blown into his face; and the substance given to the two volunteers to numb their fear before the fire. Each is a gift and a dose. The Greek *dosis* names both a giving and a dose of medicine or poison. Plato's word *pharmakon* names both remedy and poison, and Jacques Derrida, reading the *Phaedrus*, showed that the word cannot be resolved into either sense without violence to the other (Derrida [1972] 1981). The same draughts that release Dani's grief immobilize Christian. The Hårga's pharmacy is the material basis of their holding: what heals the held paralyzes the dropped.

Derrida also observed that *pharmakon* has a near relation in *pharmakos*, the human scapegoat, a word Plato's text never uses but whose shadow falls across its vocabulary. At Athens, during the Thargelia, a festival of Apollo held in the early-summer month of Thargelion, two persons designated *pharmakoi* were led through the city and driven out as bearers of its pollution, while first fruits were offered to the god. Some ancient sources report that the *pharmakoi* were beaten with branches and squills; a few, of disputed reliability, that they were killed and burned and their ashes scattered on the sea. An early-summer festival of the god of light, an offering of first fruits, and the expulsion of human scapegoats: the Thargelia is the Hårga's Greek double, and it binds the *pharmakon* of the welcome cup to the *pharmakos* of the fire.

This chapter reads the Hårga as an economy of gift, obligation, consecration, expenditure, hospitality, and immunity, and it argues that this economy finances the holding analyzed in Chapter One. Its claim is the one stated as Proposition III. The Hårga's holding is a gift that obliges; the obligation is discharged in sacrifice; and the sacrifice is the community's immune response to foreign bodies that it has deliberately admitted.

4.2

The Scapegoat's Season

Frazer, Balder's Fires, and the Beltane Lot

James George Frazer devoted the last part of *The Golden Bough* to the fire festivals of Europe and named it after a Norse god: *Balder the Beautiful* (Frazer 1906–15). Balder, Odin's radiant son, was killed by a shaft of mistletoe thrown by his blind brother at Loki's prompting, and his body was burned on a pyre aboard his ship, where his wife, Nanna, dead of grief, was laid beside him. Frazer gathered the evidence for midsummer bonfires from Ireland to Russia—fires around which villagers danced, through which couples leaped, into which, in some places, effigies were cast—and found in Sweden what he took to be the decisive clue. There, he reported, the great bonfires of Saint John's Eve, kindled at dusk on the hills of Bohuslän and Skåne, had formerly been called Balder's balefires, and the name persuaded him that in earlier times "either a living representative or an effigy of Balder was annually burned" in them. Frazer proposed that the myth of Balder's death had once been the text of a sacred drama performed year by year as a magical rite, in which a human Balder, the living embodiment of a spirit of vegetation, died in the fire so that the sun would shine, the crops thrive, and people and cattle be guarded from harm. He noted that Esaias Tegnér, the poet of the Gothic Society, had placed Balder's burning at midsummer.

The Golden Bough thus imagined, as the buried truth of the Swedish midsummer, precisely the rite that *Midsommar* stages. Frazer read the bonfires of his own day as survivals: the harmless relics of a sacrifice whose meaning had been forgotten. The Hårga reverse survival into revival. What Frazer reconstructed as a ghost behind the folk custom, they perform in

the flesh. Frazer's interpretation of the fires was itself double. He weighed the theory that they were solar charms, meant to reinforce the sun at the turning points of its course, against the theory that they were purifications, meant to burn away witches, disease, and evil, and the drama he imagined for Balder served both ends. The Hårga's temple fire is likewise solar and purgative at once. It is lit at the summit of the sun's year, and it consumes the bodies of the foreign and the polluted.

Frazer's account of the Scottish Beltane fires supplies the instrument of selection. In parts of the Highlands, he reported from an eighteenth-century parish account, a cake was divided among those gathered at the fire, and whoever drew the blackened portion was called the devoted person and made to leap three times through the flames, a custom Frazer read as the relic of a victim once chosen by lot. Ludwig Wittgenstein, reading Frazer in the early 1930s, objected to the whole method. Rites, he argued, are not mistaken science, and what makes the Beltane custom sinister to us is not historical evidence that it once involved human sacrifice but something in ourselves: the thought of a man thrown, even in play, into the fire (Wittgenstein [1967] 1979). Wittgenstein's remark is the best gloss on the archival effect analyzed in Chapter Two. The Hårga do not need to be ancient to be sinister. They need only to awaken in the spectator the sinister depth that, for Wittgenstein, history merely clothes.

The scapegoat completes Frazer's catalogue. In Leviticus, the high priest lays his hands upon a live goat, confesses over it the iniquities of the people, and sends it into the wilderness to carry them to a land not inhabited, while its companion is slain as an offering (Leviticus 16). Frazer devoted a volume of *The Golden Bough* to the scapegoat, and René Girard would make it the key to the origin of culture. The Hårga, however, keep no wilderness. No one is sent away bearing the community's sins; those who try to leave are killed, and the bodies of the foreign are burned at the commune's center. The Hårga's scapegoats are not expelled but incorporated and consumed, and that passage from expulsion to incorporation leads from the archaic scapegoat to the immunitary logic examined later in this chapter.

4.3

The Machinery of Consecration

Hubert and Mauss, Robertson Smith, and the Primal Meal

Henri Hubert and Marcel Mauss gave the comparative study of sacrifice its first rigorous grammar (Hubert and Mauss [1899] 1964). Sacrifice, they argued, is a procedure that establishes communication between the sacred and profane worlds through the mediation of a victim, which is consecrated and destroyed in the course of the ceremony. Its agents are distinct: the *sacrifier*, the person or group on whose behalf the sacrifice is made and to whom its benefits accrue; the *sacrificer*, the officiant who performs it; and the victim, which passes from the profane into the sacred and is destroyed there. Rites of entry sanctify the participants and the victim, and rites of exit return them to ordinary life. The whole is pervaded by what Hubert and Mauss called a mixture of disinterestedness and self-interest: the sacrifier gives up something of himself, and expects something in return.

The Hårga's finale observes this grammar exactly. The community is the sacrifier, and its benefit is the renewal of the cycle. The elders are the sacrificers, presiding over the preparation of the victims and the lighting of the fire. But the decisive act of selection is delegated to Dani, who has been consecrated for the purpose by rites of entry: the dance, the crowning, the procession through the fields, the gown of flowers. The victims too are consecrated. The two volunteers enter the temple as celebrants; Christian, paralyzed, is sewn into the hide of a bear. The film shows no rite of exit for the community. It shows only the smile, which may be read as the exit rite of a single participant, who returns not to the profane world from which she came but to a new world in which she herself is sacred.

The bear deserves notice as a sacrificial device. The history of sacrifice, as Hubert and Mauss and later Girard told it, is a history of substitution, in which animals replace human victims and effigies replace animals; its canonical scene is the ram caught in the thicket that Abraham offers in place of his son (Genesis 22). The Hårga collapse the chain of substitution. They do not put an animal in place of a man; they put a man inside an animal. Victim and substitute are fused into one body, as though the

long history of sacrificial mitigation had been run backward to its source. Chapter Six returns to the bear as a figure of dethroned sovereignty; here it is a figure of substitution annulled.

William Robertson Smith, whose *Lectures on the Religion of the Semites* shaped both Durkheim and Freud, argued that the oldest sacrifice was not a gift to a deity but a communion: a meal at which the kin group consumed together the flesh of a sacred animal and thereby renewed the bond of common life among its members and with its god (Robertson Smith 1889). Freud built on Robertson Smith the most audacious myth of origins in modern thought. In *Totem and Taboo* he imagined a primal horde ruled by a father who kept all the women for himself, until the sons he had driven out joined together, killed and devoured him, and then, overcome by remorse, forbade the killing of the totem animal that stood in his place and renounced the women for whom they had killed him. The totem meal, in which the community periodically kills and eats the sacred animal, commemorates the deed, and guilt, the incest prohibition, and the social bond are born together (Freud [1913] 1955).

Read through Freud, the Hårga are a society that has dismantled both foundations of the social order. The incest prohibition, the first renunciation, is ritually suspended in the breeding of the oracle. The murder of the father, the founding crime, is forestalled: the elders leap from the cliff at seventy-two before any son must raise a hand against them. The ättestupa is the primal murder converted into a voluntary death, and the conversion abolishes the guilt that, for Freud, founded morality. One moment in the film betrays the conversion. The second elder survives his fall and lies on the rocks, moaning, while the assembled commune moans with him, until members of the community descend and end his life with a heavy mallet. The rite has failed, and the sons strike after all. For an instant the primal murder breaks through the surface of the voluntary death, and the chorus that accompanies it turns the killing back into shared feeling. The Hårga are a community without remorse. Their violence produces no guilt, because the old consent to their deaths and the strangers are not kin. That absence of guilt is the condition of the commune's serenity, and the film renders the serenity as horror.

4.4

Unanimity Minus One

Girard and the Name of the Victim

René Girard's theory begins not with sacrifice but with desire. Human beings, he argued, do not desire objects directly; they desire what others desire, imitating one another's wants, and this mimetic desire breeds rivalry, which spreads by imitation until a community dissolves into a war of doubles, a sacrificial crisis in which all differences collapse (Girard [1972] 1977). The crisis is resolved by the same mimesis that produced it. Violence, propagated by imitation, converges on a single victim, chosen arbitrarily but credited after the fact with responsibility for the disorder, and the community, united against that one, recovers its peace in the unanimity of all minus one. The victim, held responsible both for the disorder and for the peace that follows, is sacralized. Ritual sacrifice repeats this founding murder under controlled conditions, discharging the community's accumulated violence upon a substitute so that the crisis need not return.

The Hårga's culture can be read as a Girardian machine of unusual precision. Its central technology, the mirroring chorus, is mimesis institutionalized: the whole community imitates the affect of whichever member suffers, and Proposition II named this organized mimesis the foundation of sympathocracy. Girard's theory predicts the price. A community that produces its affect through imitation must periodically discharge the violence that imitation breeds, and the Hårga's calendar does so on schedule. Their victims bear Girard's marks of victimage. They are marginal, inside and outside at once: guests admitted to the community's intimacy who remain strangers to its kin. Girard also catalogued the stereotypes by which persecutors justify their violence: a crisis in which differences collapse, crimes attributed to the victim (especially crimes that erase difference), marks that single the victim out, and the violence itself (Girard [1982] 1986). The film supplies its victims with crimes. Mark urinates on the ancestral tree; Josh photographs the forbidden scripture; Christian appropriates his friend's thesis and, drugged, betrays Dani. The spectator, prompted to feel that each of them invites his fate, adopts the persecutors' logic. Yet the film is clear that the crimes are pretexts. The visitors were

brought to be offered before any of them transgressed, and their guilt is assigned to deaths already decided.

Girard's later work turned this anthropology into a theology. The myths of every culture, he argued, are told from the persecutors' point of view, concealing the victim's innocence behind the community's unanimity; the Gospel narratives of the Passion are the first to tell the story from the victim's side, exposing the scapegoat mechanism and thereby, in principle, disabling it (Girard [1978] 1987). The victim of *Midsommar* is named Christian. The name, which Chapter One read as the residue of a faith that has left nothing else in its bearer, acquires in Girard's frame a sharper edge. The film stages the return of the sacrificial order that, on Girard's account, the Christian revelation had exposed, and it burns a man called Christian in a rite that restores the persecutors' unanimity. It tells this story from both sides at once. Its finale is a myth in Girard's sense, narrated from the side of a community and a heroine for whom the death is a joy; its horror is a gospel in Girard's sense, narrated from the side of a victim who cannot speak. The spectator must decide which narrative to believe, and the film's form, as Chapter Three showed, is weighted toward the myth.

The Wicker Man had already staged this confrontation, and resolved it the other way. Sergeant Howie dies a Christian martyr, singing a psalm, assured of resurrection, his death a testimony against the islanders' faith. *Midsommar*'s Christian dies without a psalm, without a creed, and without a witness. The gospel perspective survives in the film only as the spectator's residual discomfort: the revelation has lost its martyr, and if it is to be supplied at all, the audience must supply it.

4.5

The Accursed Share in the Sunlit Field

Bataille's Solar Economy

Georges Bataille's general economy begins with the sun. The earth, he observed, receives from the sun a superabundance of energy for which it returns nothing, and living systems, nourished by that excess, produce more than they need to sustain themselves (Bataille [1949] 1988). The surplus

must be spent. It can be spent gloriously and without return, in festivals, monuments, luxury, art, eroticism, and sacrifice; or, if it is hoarded and accumulated, it will be spent catastrophically, in war. Bataille called the excess the accursed share, and he held that a society is defined less by how it produces than by how it squanders. Modern bourgeois civilization, organized around accumulation, had lost its institutions of glorious expenditure and was condemned to discharge its surplus in catastrophe.

The Hårga's festival is Bataillean expenditure at its purest. It falls at the summit of the sun's year, the season of maximal solar gift, and it squanders everything a restricted economy would conserve: days of labor turned to dance and feasting, the elders' remaining years, the guests, whose lives are spent rather than used, and the temple itself, which is built to be burned. In his theory of religion, Bataille argued that sacrifice withdraws its victim from the world of things, the profane order of utility in which beings serve as means to ends, and restores it to the intimate order of the sacred, in which nothing is for anything (Bataille [1973] 1989). The victim is not used but consumed. The Hårga's fire returns to the sun, in Bataille's sense, what the sun gave.

Bataille's paradigm of sacrificial expenditure was the Aztec festival of Toxcatl, as recorded in Bernardino de Sahagún's sixteenth-century account (Sahagún [c. 1577] 1981). A young man of flawless body was chosen to live for a year as the god Tezcatlipoca, honored, adorned, and worshipped. In his final days he was given four young women as wives, each bearing the name of a goddess, and at the festival he climbed the temple steps, breaking his flutes as he ascended, and was sacrificed at the summit. Christian's last days follow the same course. He is welcomed as an honored guest, given the community's attention, paired with a young woman of the commune chosen for him, and then consumed. Bataille saw in the Toxcatl victim a supreme luxury, a human being lavished and destroyed, and the Hårga treat Christian as the same luxury, spent at the climax of their festival.

Erotism adds the inner experience. Human beings, Bataille argued, are discontinuous: each is a separate being, born and dying alone, and each longs for the lost continuity of being that eroticism and death momentarily restore. Eroticism is assent to life up to the point of death, and sacrifice is the spectacle in which a community, watching a death, glimpses continuity (Bataille [1957] 1986). Christian passes through both of Bataille's experiences of continuity within a single day, the coupling rite and the fire,

but he passes through them as an object rather than a subject, drugged into the first and paralyzed for the second. The continuity is enjoyed by the chorus. Christian supplies the discontinuity that the community overcomes.

The appeal of this economy to the unheld subject of late modernity is the deepest secret of the film's seduction. Dani's American world is a restricted economy of feeling. Her grief is a cost to be minimized, a burden her partner's friends tally against his time, an emotional labor she rations, a condition referred to a therapist billed by the hour. The Hårga offer a general economy in which grief is not managed but spent, gloriously and collectively, without measure. Bataille warned that surplus left unspent returns as catastrophe; the Hårga's festival is the alternative he imagined, glorious expenditure in place of war. Its horror is that the expenditure is of persons, and that an economy of grief without measure finds its measure, in the end, in bodies.

◉

4.6

The Gift That Must Be Returned

Mauss and the Price of Belonging

Mauss's essay on the gift described archaic exchange as a system of *total prestations* governed by three obligations: to give, to receive, and to reciprocate (Mauss [1925] 1990). A gift refused is a declaration of hostility; a gift accepted binds; a gift unreciprocated subordinates the receiver to the giver. Mauss found the force of the obligation expressed in the Maori concept of the *hau*, the spirit of the thing given, which according to his source seeks to return to its origin and brings misfortune on whoever keeps it without return. He found its agonistic extreme in the potlatch of the Pacific Northwest, where chiefs competed in the destruction of wealth to establish their rank. Gifts to the gods and to the dead, he added, are the most binding of all, and sacrifice is their form.

Read through Mauss, the Hårga's courtship of Dani is a sequence of gifts that cannot be refused and must be returned. The first is Pelle's: the portrait he draws for the birthday Christian forgot. The commune's gifts follow: its welcome, its food, its flowers, its draughts, the embraces of the

women who call her sister, the chorus that answers her wail, the crown she wins, the family she is offered. Each binds her more closely, and each enlarges a debt. The finale presents the account. As May Queen, Dani is asked to choose the ninth offering, and in choosing Christian she makes her counter-gift. She gives the community the one thing she brought with her that it does not already possess, her former life in the person of the man who embodied it, and by that gift she discharges her obligation and becomes, in the full Maussian sense, a member: no longer a recipient of the community's generosity but a giver among givers. Her sovereignty is purchased by the counter-gift. The holding she received is returned as a fall.

The film thus discloses the gift economy concealed within the language of unconditional love. Derrida argued that the pure gift is impossible: the moment a gift appears as a gift, to giver or receiver, it enters the circle of exchange and is annulled, since recognition is already a return (Derrida [1991] 1992). The Hårga's holding presents itself as the pure gift that Dani's world never gave her—love without measure, mirroring without condition—and its condition is revealed only at the end. Marcel Hénaff, revising Mauss, argued that the ceremonial gift is not an economic exchange at all but a public act of recognition through which the parties affirm one another's standing (Hénaff [2002] 2010). That is what Dani receives: recognition, the experience of being seen and answered that her former life withheld. The price of the recognition is a life.

In *The Gift of Death*, Derrida went further, arguing that every act of responsibility is sacrificial. To respond to one other is to fail all the others: in caring for this one, here and now, I abandon the countless others whom I might have cared for, and I can never justify the preference (Derrida [1992] 1995). If Derrida is right, the Hårga are not the opposite of ordinary care but its ritual revelation. Every holding lets fall; every embrace of one is a turning from others. What distinguishes the Hårga is not that they sacrifice but that they choose their victims, celebrate their deaths, and abolish the guilt with which ordinary care regards the others it abandons. Proposition III can now be stated in its strongest form. All holding has a sacrificial structure. The good-enough environment acknowledges that structure as loss, disillusionment, and regret; the sacrificial environment transforms it into festival.

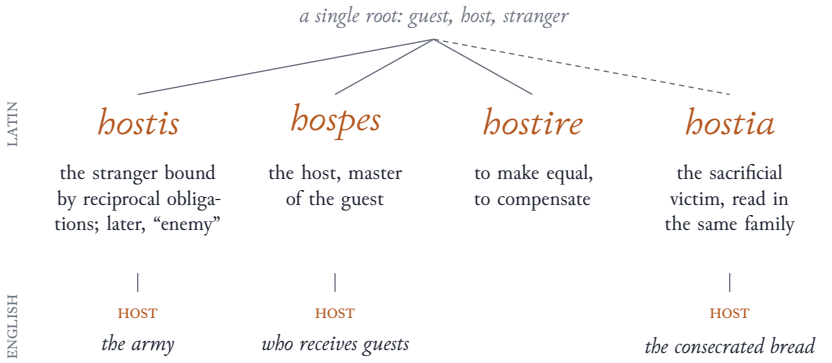
4·7

Hostipitality

The Guest as Hostage

Émile Benveniste traced the Indo-European vocabulary of hospitality to a single root that names the guest, the host, and the stranger at once. Latin *hostis*, which would come to mean "enemy," first designated the stranger bound to the community by reciprocal obligations; *hospes*, the host, joins the same root to a word for mastery, so that the host is the master of the guest; and the verb *hostire*, to make equal or to compensate, preserves the reciprocity at the institution's core (Benveniste [1969] 1973). The Latin word for a sacrificial victim, *hostia*, has been read in the same family, as the offering that compensates the gods. English inherited three hosts from these words: the army, from *hostis*; the one who receives guests, from *hospes*; and the consecrated bread of the Eucharist, from *hostia*. In the deep vocabulary of Europe, guest, host, enemy, and victim belong to a single family.

Derrida coined the word *hostipitality* for the contamination of hospitality by hostility that this vocabulary records (Derrida 2000). Hospitality, he argued, is torn between an unconditional law that would welcome any stranger without question, condition, or demand and the conditional laws by which actual hosts admit guests on their own terms; and conditional



HOSTIPITALITY In the deep vocabulary of Europe, guest, host, enemy, and victim belong to a single family.

hospitality presupposes the host's sovereignty over the home, a mastery that can always turn the guest into a hostage (Derrida [1997] 2000). The Hårga's hospitality is total and their sovereignty absolute. The guests are welcomed without reservation and permitted everything except departure. When Simon and Connie, horrified by the cliff, insist on leaving, Connie is told that Simon has been driven ahead to the station, and neither is seen alive again. Kant had limited the cosmopolitan right of strangers to a right of visit, which entitles them not to be treated with hostility on arrival but not to remain, and which presupposes their freedom to go (Kant [1795] 1991). The Hårga invert Kant's minimum, granting every guest the right to stay forever and denying each the right to leave. In Albert Hirschman's terms, they abolish both exit and voice and admit only loyalty (Hirschman 1970). Those who attempt exit die. Those who exercise voice—Mark's mockery, Josh's methodological dissent, Connie's protest—die. The one who chooses loyalty is crowned.

The oldest literature of Europe already knew this house. In the *Odyssey* the laws of guest-friendship, protected by Zeus Xenios, structure the hero's wanderings, and their violations define its monsters: the Cyclops, who eats his guests; the Lotus-Eaters, whose gift of food makes men forget their homecoming; and Circe, who welcomes Odysseus's men into her house, sets food and wine before them, mixes into the food the drugs that make them forget their homeland, and turns them with her wand into swine (Homer 1995, bk. 10). The Hårga are Circe's house. A matriarchal hospitality offers its guests food and drink laced with *pharmaka*; the guests forget home; and the last of them is turned into a beast. Odysseus survives Circe because Hermes gives him moly, the herb that protects him from her drugs. Christian has no moly.

The film plays a double game with the Homeric ethic. From the Hårga's point of view the visitors are bad guests, as Penelope's suitors were: they mock their hosts' rites, desecrate their sacred tree, steal images of their scripture, and abuse their table, and the *Odyssey* ends with the host slaughtering the suitors in his own hall. The film invites the spectator to adopt this view and to feel that the visitors' deaths are just. But Girard's analysis of persecutory stereotypes, together with the film's own evidence that the victims were destined before they transgressed, exposes the suitors' guilt as the persecutors' alibi. The guests do not die because they abused hospitality. They were invited in order to die.

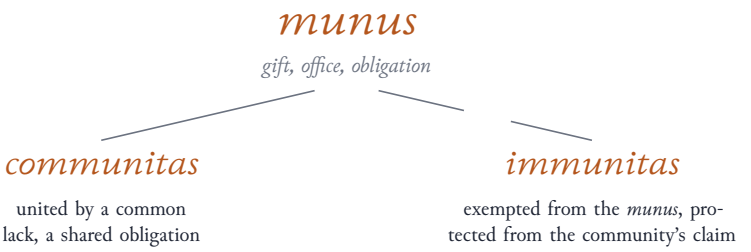
4.8

Communitas and Immunitas

The Vaccinated Community

Roberto Esposito's philosophy of community begins from etymology. Latin *communitas* derives from *munus*, a word meaning at once gift, office, and obligation: not a possession but a debt, a gift that must be given (Esposito [1998] 2010). A community so understood is united not by a common property but by a common lack, a shared obligation that expropriates its members from themselves. *Immunitas* is its opposite. The immune person is the one exempted from the *munus*, released from the obligation to give and protected from the community's claim. Modernity, Esposito argued, is the history of immunization, the progressive protection of individual life from the obligations of the common, culminating in the biopolitics of the twentieth century and, at its extreme, in a politics of death in which the protection of a people's body required the destruction of those defined as its pathogens (Esposito [2002] 2011).

The Hårga are communitas in the strict etymological sense. Every life is a *munus*, a gift received from the community and owed back to it, and the debt falls due at seventy-two, when the elder returns, with life itself, the name that passes to the unborn. No one is immune. Toward the outside, however, the Hårga constitute an immune system of exceptional rigor, operating by the logic Esposito traced to vaccination: a body protects itself by introducing a controlled dose of the foreign, provoking a response that neutralizes it. The commune imports outsiders on purpose. Its young people travel abroad on their summer pilgrimages and return with guests;



Munus Community as a shared obligation; immunity as release from it.

the elders praise the recruiters for bringing new blood; Christian's seed is taken for the community's renewal. Then the foreign bodies are destroyed. The festival is an inoculation. Lord Summerisle's islanders turn to human sacrifice because their apple harvest has failed; the Hårga sacrifice on a calendar, in the absence of any crisis. Their violence is not curative but preventive, an immune response scheduled ninety years in advance. Derrida extended the biological figure to describe the tendency of communities to turn their defenses against themselves, and he called it autoimmunity (Derrida [2003] 2005). The festival has its autoimmune moment as well: among the nine are two of the commune's own, who volunteer to enter the temple and whose fear-numbing draught fails in the fire.

Giorgio Agamben's figure of *homo sacer* marks the limit of this analysis. In archaic Roman law, the *homo sacer* was a man who could be killed with impunity but not sacrificed; excluded from human and divine law alike, he embodied what Agamben called bare life, life exposed to death without meaning (Agamben [1995] 1998). Agamben argued that modern sovereignty is founded on the production of bare life and that the camp, where human beings were killed as bare life, is its paradigm; accordingly, he rejected every sacrificial interpretation of modern mass death, which would lend meaning to killing that had none (Agamben [1998] 1999). The Hårga are bare life's antithesis. In their world no one dies meaninglessly; every death, the elder's and the stranger's alike, is consecrated, named, sung, and returned to the circle. This is their deepest appeal to a culture whose deaths, as Chapter One argued, have become private, medicalized, and silent, a culture in which a woman like Terri can die with her parents in a sealed house and leave behind nothing but its silence. The Hårga offer meaning where the modern world offers bare life. Their horror is that the meaning consecrates murder: a community that gives every death significance has also given itself the right to decide whose death will be significant.

4·9

Omelas in Midsummer

Jackson, Le Guin, and the One Who Walks Toward

Two American fictions of the twentieth century are the Hårga's closest literary kin, and both are summer stories. Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery," published in the *New Yorker* in June 1948, takes place on the morning of the twenty-seventh of June, a clear and sunny day in a small village where the flowers are blossoming and the grass is green (Jackson 1948). The villagers gather in the square, draw slips of paper from a battered black box, and stone to death the woman who draws the marked one. The ritual's origins are forgotten and its box is falling apart; an old man recites a proverb tying the June lottery to the coming harvest; and the victim, Tessie Hutchinson, protests to the last that it is not fair while her own family takes up stones. Jackson later recalled that the story provoked a flood of letters, many of whose writers wanted to know where such lotteries were held and whether they could go and watch (Jackson 1968).

The Hårga invert Jackson's village. Her horror is the persistence of a ritual emptied of meaning, a form that has outlived its reasons; theirs is a ritual overloaded with meaning, inscribed in murals and scripture and patiently explained to every guest. Her lottery is democratic, since anyone may draw the mark. The Hårga's selection is sovereign: the ninth victim is not left to the lot but given to the choice of the May Queen, between a man she knows and a member of the commune who has drawn the lot. The film thus personalizes Jackson's impersonal violence. Its decisive death is not an accident of chance but an act of will, and its executioner is a grieving woman whose choice the spectator has been prepared, over two and a half hours, to understand.

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), subtitled as variations on a theme by William James, opens with the Festival of Summer in a city of perfect happiness: bells, processions, music, dancing in the streets, horses racing in a meadow beneath the mountains (Le Guin 1973). The narrator, conceding how hard it is to describe joy without seeming naive, invites the reader to furnish the city with whatever pleasures, drugs and orgies included, are needed to believe in it. Then

the narrator discloses the condition of the city's happiness. In a basement beneath one of its buildings, a single child is kept in filth and misery; every citizen knows it; and the happiness of all depends on the child's remaining there. Most citizens, after their first horror, accept the bargain. A few walk away, alone, toward a place the narrator cannot describe. Le Guin drew the theme from William James, who imagined millions kept permanently happy on condition that one "lost soul on the far-off edge of things" should suffer lonely torture, and who held that we would recoil from the bargain (James 1891). Behind both stands Ivan Karamazov's refusal of any harmony built on the unavenged tears of a single tortured child (Dostoevsky [1880] 1990).

The Hårga are Omelas without the basement. Their bargain is the same, the happiness of all purchased by the suffering of a few, but nothing is hidden. The victims are not confined beneath the city but displayed at its center; their suffering is not tolerated in shame but celebrated in song; and the citizens do not merely accept the bargain but love it. Le Guin's story ends with the ones who walk away, and *Midsommar* contains such figures: Simon and Connie, who try to walk away and are killed. Its heroine moves in the opposite direction. Dani is the one who walks toward Omelas. She learns the condition of the city's happiness, sees the victims, hears the screams, and chooses to stay, and the film's final smile is the face of a citizen of Omelas on the day she understands, and accepts, what her happiness is made of.

The bargain's popular descendants confirm the reach of the fantasy. Plutarch reports that, by most accounts, Athens sent seven youths and seven maidens every nine years as tribute to the Minotaur in Crete (Plutarch 1914, *Theseus* 15). Suzanne Collins's *The Hunger Games* (2008) reimagined that tribute as a televised lottery in which children are chosen to kill one another for a capital's entertainment, and the series became one of the most widely read fictions of its decade (Collins 2008). The sacrificial lottery has outlived the gods it once served and become entertainment, and *Midsommar*, the most beautiful of its recent forms, asks its audience to notice the pleasure it takes in it.

4.10

Conclusion

The Price of Holding

The economy of the Hårga can now be described as a whole. Its currency is the gift, and its gifts are *pharmaka*: remedies for those it holds, poisons for those it lets fall. Its gifts bind, and the obligation they create is discharged in sacrifice, the counter-gift by which a member pays for her membership. Its sacrifices follow the grammar that Hubert and Mauss described and the mimetic logic that Girard exposed; they spend the community's surplus as Bataille's sun spends its light; and they function as the immune response of a community to foreign bodies admitted for the purpose. Its hospitality admits everyone and releases no one. In all of this the Hårga do not contradict the structure that Derrida found in every responsibility, that to hold one is to let others fall; they perfect it. What they add is festival, by which the letting-fall is chosen, scheduled, celebrated, and stripped of guilt.

The formula of this dissertation can therefore be restated in the language of the economy. In the sacrificial holding environment, to be held is to incur a debt, and the debt is paid in someone else's body. The next chapter turns to the affect that drives this economy and makes it feel, from within, not like a transaction but like love: the mirroring chorus, and the organized mimesis of grief.




5

CHAPTER FIVE

The Organized Mimesis of Grief

Lament, Fellow-Feeling, and the Mirroring Chorus

ὣς ἔφατο κλαίουσ', ἐπὶ δὲ στενάχοντο γυναῖκες,
Πάτροκλον πρόφασιν, σφῶν δ' αὐτῶν κήδε' ἑκάστη.

— Homer, *Iliad* 19.301–2

the minds of men are mirrors to one another

— David Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature* (1739–40), 2.2.5

5.1

The Chorus at the Center

Toward a Definition of Sympathocracy

Four times in *Midsommar* the community of the Hårga answers a cry with its own. At the cliff, when the second elder survives his fall and lies moaning on the rocks, the assembled commune moans with him. When Dani collapses after witnessing Christian's betrayal, the women of the commune kneel around her and wail as she wails, matching her pitch and her breath until her solitary cry has become the leading voice of a chorus. At the coupling rite, a ring of older women echoes the cries of the ceremony. And at the temple, as the fire takes hold and the two volunteers, their fear-numbing draught failing, begin to scream, the community outside screams with them, writhing as though the flames were in their own bodies. No scenes in the film are more distinctive than these choral answerings, and none has been more widely discussed. They

are the Hårga's signature and, as this dissertation has argued since its first chapter, their fundamental technology.

Proposition II called the regime this technology founds a *sympathocracy*: government by compulsory fellow-feeling, in which affect is not privately undergone and publicly expressed but collectively produced, distributed, and administered. The term requires a theory, and this chapter supplies one in three movements. It first sets the mirroring chorus against the long human history of ritual lament, from the women of Homer's Troy to the mourners of the Greek Mani, and finds that the Hårga's chorus lacks what that tradition held essential: the mourners' own sorrows, their words, and their capacity to accuse. It then sets the chorus against the philosophy of fellow-feeling, from Hume and Adam Smith to Max Scheler and Edith Stein, and finds that the Hårga substitute unison for concord and contagion for sympathy, abolishing the distance on which sympathy depends. Finally it sets the chorus against the twentieth century's analyses of crowds, mimesis, and fascist aesthetics, and against the defenses of distance that Helmuth Plessner and Hannah Arendt mounted against the dream of total community. The theory that results explains both the chorus's power and its price. It holds, absolutely, every voice it can mirror, and it lets fall every voice it cannot.

The Greek word from which sympathocracy takes its name, *sympatheia*, meant for the Stoics a cosmic interconnection: the doctrine that the universe is a single living body whose parts affect one another, so that what happens anywhere resonates everywhere. The breathing world analyzed in §3.6, in which grass grows through Dani's hand and her gown respires around her, is a Stoic cosmos of this kind, a nature that feels with the subject. The Hårga extend cosmic sympathy into a political order. Their community is a body whose members are made to feel one another's feelings, and the chorus is the organ through which that body feels.

5.2

"Each for Her Own Sorrows"

Ritual Lament from Homer to the Mani

The oldest literature of Europe ends in lament. The *Iliad* closes with the mourning of Hector, and after the dirge of the professional singers and the laments of Andromache and Hecuba, Homer repeats a formula: the women groaned in answer; after Helen's, the whole numberless people groaned (Homer 1999, 24.722, 746, 776). In the nineteenth book, when the captive Briseis laments over the body of Patroclus, the same formula is followed by a line of extraordinary psychological precision, the line that stands at the head of this chapter: the women wailed in answer, Patroclus their pretext, but each for her own sorrows (Homer 1999, 19.301–2). Homer saw what the chorus of lament is for. The women's wailing answers Briseis, but it does not merely repeat her. Each woman brings to the public occasion the private griefs that have no other occasion, and the lament is therefore antiphonal and polyphonic, a shared form in which many sorrows sound at once.

Margaret Alexiou traced this antiphonal structure across three millennia of Greek tradition, from the professional dirge and the kinswomen's improvised response in Homer, through the Byzantine laments of the Virgin, to the *moirológia* still sung in Greek villages in the twentieth century (Alexiou 1974). Nadia Seremetakis's ethnography of the Inner Mani showed what the antiphony accomplishes. In Maniat lament, the soloist's sung improvisation is answered by a chorus of women whose responses witness, confirm, and amplify it; antiphony is a jural structure, a means by which women's testimony about the dead, and about those responsible for the death, acquires the force of collective truth (Seremetakis 1991). The lament remembers, narrates, and accuses. Ernesto de Martino, studying the funeral laments of Lucania in southern Italy, gave the practice its existential rationale. Bereavement, he argued, threatens a crisis of presence, the danger that the mourner's very self will be swallowed by the loss, and ritual lament is a cultural technique that gives grief a traditional form, so that the mourner can pass through the crisis without being dissolved by it (de Martino 1958). The tradition's surviving masterpieces bear him out.

The Irish keen that Eibhlín Dubh Ní Chonaill composed in 1773 for her murdered husband, Art Ó Laoghaire, is at once a cry of grief, a memorial of a life, and a curse upon the man responsible for his death.

The prophets knew the technique as a trade. "Call for the mourning women, that they may come," Jeremiah commands, "and let them make haste, and take up a wailing for us, that our eyes may run down with tears" (Jeremiah 9:17–18). The professional mourner—the Roman *praefica*, the hired keener—existed because grief often cannot release itself and must be induced by voices that have learned the art of weeping. The Eddic lay examined in §2.7 records the same knowledge: the noblewomen gathered around the dry-eyed Guðrún each recount their own griefs in order to open hers. In every tradition, collective lament is a technology for releasing grief that cannot release itself.

The tradition also knew lament's danger. Nicole Loraux showed that the Greek city feared women's mourning as a force of unforgetting anger, capable of keeping alive grievances that the polis needed to bury; the laws ascribed to Solon restricted the laments, lacerations, and wailing for strangers that funerals had licensed, and the classical city replaced the women's dirge with the funeral oration, a civic and masculine genre that turned the dead into exemplars of the city's glory (Loraux [1990] 1998). Renato Rosaldo encountered grief's most extreme danger among the Ilongot of the northern Philippines. Older Ilongot men told him that the rage born of bereavement drove them to take heads, and that by severing and casting away a victim's head they hoped to cast away the anger of their mourning. Rosaldo found the explanation unintelligible until his wife, the anthropologist Michelle Rosaldo, died in a fall from a mountain path during fieldwork in 1981, and he discovered in his own grief the rage the Ilongot had described (Rosaldo 1989). His conclusion, that the ethnographer is a positioned subject who understands some experiences only after undergoing them, returns in Chapter Seven, where the film's anthropologists prove incapable of understanding a rite that only the bereaved Dani comprehends.

Measured against this tradition, the Hårga's chorus is both a revival and an impoverishment. It revives what modernity abandoned, the public form of grief and the technique of its release, and it gives Dani what Gorer's Britain and her own America withheld (§1.8). But it lacks what the tradition held essential. Its women do not weep for their own sorrows under cover of hers; they reproduce hers exactly. They sing no words, remember

no life, and accuse no one. And their mourning does not resist the community's order, as the Greek city feared women's mourning would; it is the community's order. The Hårga answer Dani's wail as Homer's women answered Briseis, but without the clause that makes Homer's line great. Their wailing needs no pretext, because it has no sorrows of its own. It is not antiphony but echo.

◉

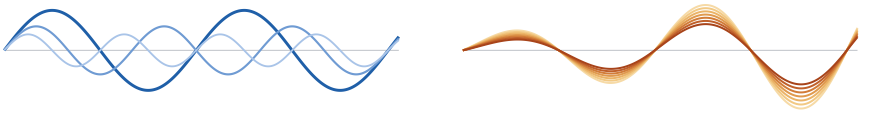
5.3

Unison and Concord

Hume, Smith, Scheler, and Stein

David Hume gave the philosophy of fellow-feeling its founding image. The minds of men, he wrote, are mirrors to one another, not only because they reflect one another's emotions but because the rays of passion may be reverberated back and forth among them and decay away by insensible degrees (Hume [1739–40] 2000, 2.2.5). Hume's mirrors are the Hårga's, with one decisive difference. In Hume's sympathy, passion reflected between persons gradually decays; it loses intensity with each reflection, and that decay is what allows feeling to circulate through a society without overwhelming it. In the Hårga's chorus, passion reflected among the women grows. Each reflection amplifies, and the mirroring tends not toward equilibrium but toward crescendo.

Adam Smith, Hume's friend, made the difference explicit, and his account of sympathy furnishes the most exact contrast with the Hårga's practice. For Smith, sympathy is an act of imagination by which the spectator changes places in fancy with the sufferer; but the spectator's imagined emotion is always weaker than the sufferer's real one, and so the sufferer, wishing to be sympathized with, learns to lower the pitch of his passion to a level the spectators can go along with. The two feelings, Smith concluded, "will never be unisons," but "they may be concords, and this is all that is wanted or required" (Smith [1759] 1976, I.i.4.7). Smithian sympathy is concord: a harmony of different pitches, purchased by the sufferer's restraint and the spectator's effort. The musical metaphor fits the film with uncanny precision. Dani's American world demanded the Smithian adjustment of her. She was to lower the pitch of her grief to what Christian and his



CONCORD
different pitches, held at a distance

UNISON
one pitch, the interval abolished

UNISON AND CONCORD Smith's sufferer lowers her pitch to what the spectators can go along with; the Hårga raise theirs to meet it, and each reflection amplifies.

friends could bear, and her failure to do so made her a burden. The Hårga reverse the adjustment. They do not ask Dani to lower her pitch; they raise theirs to meet it. They achieve what Smith thought both impossible and unnecessary, unison, and their chorus is the sound of a community that has abolished the interval between sufferer and spectator.

The phenomenological tradition supplied the distinctions needed to name what is lost when the interval goes. Max Scheler separated four phenomena commonly confused under the name of sympathy (Scheler [1923] 1954). In *emotional contagion* a feeling spreads from person to person without being referred to anyone, as merriment spreads through a tavern or panic through a crowd. In *emotional identification* the boundary between selves dissolves altogether, as in hypnosis, ecstatic union, or the infant's fusion with its mother. In the *community of feeling*, two persons feel one and the same sorrow together, as two parents standing beside the body of their dead child. And in genuine *fellow-feeling*, I feel with the other's sorrow as the other's, apprehending it in its difference from my own. Genuine fellow-feeling, for Scheler, presupposes distance: the other's suffering is given to me as belonging to another. Edith Stein, Husserl's assistant, sharpened the point in her dissertation on empathy (Stein [1917] 1989). She rejected Theodor Lipps's theory that empathy is a form of inner imitation, a projection of one's own mimicked feelings into another (Lipps 1903), and argued instead that empathy is an act of its own kind, in which another's experience is given to me non-primordially: I grasp the other's grief as truly present and truly the other's, precisely because I do not live it as my own.

The Hårga's chorus belongs to Scheler's first two categories and to Lipps's theory, not to Scheler's last or to Stein's. It is contagion: the women do not know, and do not ask, what Dani's grief is about; they

take up its sound. It tends toward identification: the boundary between Dani and the women dissolves into a single cry. And it enacts empathy as Lipps conceived it, as mimicry, the outward imitation of an expression. What it lacks is the distance in which another's grief is recognized as another's. Contemporary psychology has described the technique precisely. Elaine Hatfield, John Cacioppo, and Richard Rapson defined emotional contagion as the tendency to mimic and synchronize automatically the expressions, vocalizations, postures, and movements of another person and thereby to converge with that person emotionally (Hatfield, Cacioppo, and Rapson 1994). The definition describes the chorus exactly: a social institution designed to produce emotional convergence on demand.

The point is not that the chorus is false but that its truth is of a particular kind. What Dani receives among the women is real: a resonance she had never known, an end to the solitude of her grief. What she does not receive, because the chorus cannot give it, is the recognition of her grief as hers, the grief of a particular woman for a particular family lost in a particular way. The chorus holds the cry and drops the person. Proposition II stated that the Hårga abolish the distance on which sympathy depends; the philosophical tradition shows that this abolition is not an excess of sympathy but its replacement.

5.4

The Lamenting Pack

Canetti, Synchrony, and the Body in Time

Elias Canetti's *Crowds and Power* opens with the fear of being touched. Nothing, Canetti wrote, does a human being fear more than the touch of the unknown, and all the distances people create around themselves are dictated by that fear; only in the dense crowd is it reversed, as bodies press so closely that no one any longer cares who touches whom (Canetti [1960] 1962). The prologue of *Midsommar* is a study in the fear of touch. Christian holds Dani's body but cannot hold her cry, and his face turns away even as his arms enclose her. The Hårga reverse the fear. The women who surround Dani press against her, touch her face and hair, and breathe into her breath; the community lifts her, carries her, crowns her, and dresses

her in flowers. Canetti's crowd, in which the individual is freed from the terror of contact, is the Hårga's daily life.

Among the forms of collective life Canetti analyzed, the small, intense group he called the pack bears most directly on the chorus, and among his four kinds of pack, the lamenting pack above all. Drawing on the ethnography of the Warramunga of central Australia, the same material from which Durkheim had derived his account of obligatory mourning, Canetti described how the kin of a dying man threw themselves upon him in a heap, wailing and wounding themselves, as though to hold him among the living by sheer bodily insistence, and how, once death had come, the pack turned to driving the dangerous dead away (Spencer and Gillen 1904). The Hårga's chorus at the cliff is a lamenting pack of the same kind, with one decisive inversion. Canetti's pack laments the dying in order to hold them back from death; the Hårga lament the dying while consigning them to it. Their moans accompany the elder's agony, and the mallet ends it. Canetti identified a further form, the increase pack, which gathers in rites of fertility to multiply the group's numbers and its crops, and the Hårga deploy it too, in the procession through the fields and in the coupling rite. The commune is organized as a succession of packs, each assembling for a single purpose and dissolving when the purpose has been accomplished.

The historian William McNeill proposed that moving together in time, in dance, drill, and communal labor, produces a visceral fellow-feeling he called muscular bonding, a euphoric loosening of the boundary between self and group that armies and congregations have exploited throughout history (McNeill 1995). Experimental psychology has since confirmed the thesis and darkened it. Scott Wiltermuth and Chip Heath found that people who had sung or moved in synchrony subsequently cooperated more with one another (Wiltermuth and Heath 2009). Wiltermuth then found that synchrony also increased compliance with requests to do harm. Participants who had acted in synchrony with a confederate were more willing to subject others to unpleasant blasts of noise at that person's request, and participants who had walked in step with an experimenter were more willing, in a staged procedure in which no creature was in fact harmed, to feed insects into what they believed to be a killing machine when he asked them to (Wiltermuth 2012a; 2012b). The Hårga's dances, their synchronized breathing, and their choral wailing are techniques of this kind. They

produce cohesion and, with cohesion, compliance. The community that breathes together kills together.

Barbara Ehrenreich's history of collective joy gives the argument its historical frame. Ehrenreich traced the suppression of festive ecstasy in early modern Europe by churches, states, and the disciplines of labor, and she argued that the decline of collective joy coincided with an epidemic of melancholy, the depressive disorder that early modern Europe began to describe in unprecedented numbers (Ehrenreich 2006). Dani is the heir of that epidemic: a depressed and bereaved young woman in a society that has forgotten how to rejoice together. The Hårga are its imagined cure, a people that has never stopped dancing. Chapter Eight returns to the melancholy the festival promises to dispel.

◉

5.5

Organized Mimesis

Adorno, Horkheimer, Freud, and the Mass Ornament

Adorno and Horkheimer made mimesis the hidden protagonist of Western civilization (Adorno and Horkheimer [1947] 2002). In their account, the most archaic human response to a threatening nature was imitation: the magician mimicked the forces he sought to sway, as a frightened creature freezes into the semblance of its surroundings. Civilization replaced mimesis with rational control, with labor, concept, and law, and it punished the mimetic impulse wherever it survived. But the repressed impulse does not vanish. In the "Elements of Anti-Semitism" they argued that fascism's formulas, ritual discipline, uniforms, and rallies, the whole apparently irrational apparatus of the movement, existed to permit mimetic behavior once more, under organized control and in the service of domination. Fascism is the organization of mimesis. It licenses the forbidden pleasure of imitation, of chanting and marching and moving as one, and it directs that pleasure against those whom the movement has designated its enemies.

The phrase describes the Hårga with uncomfortable exactness. Their chorus is mimesis organized: the archaic impulse to imitate another's cry, cultivated, disciplined, and directed. Its ecstasies are administered (§3.1),

and its mimicry serves a plan. Adorno's essay on fascist propaganda, written a few years later, added a further insight. The identification of the masses with their leader and with one another, he argued, is in some measure phony: participants half-know that their collective enthusiasm is a performance, and it is probably the suspicion of this fictitiousness that makes such crowds so merciless and unapproachable (Adorno [1951] 1991). The film poses the same question about its chorus and declines to answer it. Do the Hårga women feel what they cry, or perform it? The refusal to decide is exact, because Adorno's point is that the distinction ceases to matter. A community that has made feeling into a performance can no longer tell the two apart, and the doubt it cannot admit is discharged as cruelty toward those who will not join the performance.

Freud's analysis of group psychology explains the chorus's object. Building on Gustave Le Bon's account of the crowd's contagion, suggestibility, and loss of individual judgment (Le Bon [1895] 1896), Freud defined a primary group as a number of individuals who have put one and the same object in the place of their ego ideal and have consequently identified themselves with one another in their ego (Freud [1921] 1955). The members love the leader, and through that common love they become alike. In the Hårga's finale the object installed in the community's ego ideal is not a man but a woman: the May Queen, crowned, robed, enthroned, the center of every composition. The chorus mirrors Dani because she has been placed in the position that binds the group together, and its love for her is the medium of its identification with itself.

Siegfried Kracauer, writing in the Weimar years, saw in the precision dance troupes of his day what he called the mass ornament: a pattern made of human bodies, in which individuals disappear into a geometry that has no meaning beyond itself, the aesthetic reflex of the rationality governing the economic system of the age (Kracauer [1927] 1995). Seen from above, the Hårga's maypole dance is a mass ornament, a whirling figure of white-clad bodies in which the dancers count only as elements of the design. But Kracauer's ornament was empty, an end in itself. The Hårga's ornament has an end. It selects, by exhaustion, the one who will reign, and it prepares the bodies that will burn.

5.6

Fascinating Community

Sontag, Riefenstahl, and the Thing Theater

In 1975 Susan Sontag published an essay that named the danger in the aesthetic the Hårga embody (Sontag 1975). Reviewing Leni Riefenstahl's photographs of the Nuba of the southern Sudan alongside a book of SS regalia, Sontag argued that the fascist aesthetic had outlived fascism. It flows, she wrote, from a preoccupation with control, submissive behavior, and the endurance of pain; it turns people into things and multiplies them into patterns; it groups them around an all-powerful figure or force; it alternates between frenzied motion and congealed, statuesque posing; and it glorifies surrender, exalts mindlessness, and glamorizes death. Her most unsettling claim concerned the Nuba photographs (Riefenstahl [1973] 1974). Riefenstahl presented the Nuba as an exalted community, a people of physical beauty, ritual combat, and collective ceremony living outside history, and Sontag argued that this primitivist ideal, the dream of a pure, beautiful, ritual people for whom death is a festival, was continuous with the aesthetic of *Triumph of the Will*.

The Hårga are, among other things, a Nordic counterpart to Riefenstahl's Nuba: a beautiful people dressed in white, living by ritual outside history, celebrating their dead, and photographed with a care that makes every frame an image of communal grace. Every element of Sontag's inventory appears in the film—control and submission, bodies arranged in patterns, a community gathered around a figure of power, motion alternating with tableau, a glamorized death. What distinguishes the film is that it shows the inventory as an inventory. It invites the fascination Sontag described and exposes its mechanism, as Chapter Three argued of its form generally. Yet Sontag's warning holds even for films that know what they are doing. The spectator who leaves *Midsommar* longing for the white dresses, the flower crowns, and the long tables, as the film's afterlife in costume and fashion suggests many did, has been fascinated in Sontag's sense, whatever the film intended.

The history of the twentieth century supplies a precedent that brings the Hårga's open-air rites close to a political program. In the first years

of the Third Reich, the Thingspiel movement sought to create a national theater of mass participation, named after the *thing*, the assembly of the ancient Germanic peoples. Its plays combined speaking choruses, massed movement, and quasi-religious ceremony, and they were staged in open-air amphitheaters built into hillsides on the model of the ancient Greek theater. The most celebrated of these, on the Heiligenberg above Heidelberg, was built by the Reich Labor Service and local students and dedicated by Joseph Goebbels on 22 June 1935 before a crowd of some twenty thousand; he called the site a holy mountain, and the opening festivities closed with a celebration of the summer solstice. The movement had petered out by 1937, when Goebbels withdrew his support, but it remains the modern era's most explicit attempt to found a political community on a choral liturgy, performed outdoors at midsummer in an invented Germanic idiom. Adam of Bremen's scholiast placed the temple at Uppsala on a plain ringed by hills like a theater (§2.3); the Thing theaters were built to a similar plan, and the Hårga's cliff-top rite, its assembled community facing the stone, belongs to the same architecture of communal witness.

To set the Hårga beside Riefenstahl and the Thing theater is not to call the film fascist or to read its commune as a political allegory. It is to recognize that the choral community—beautiful, ritual, ecstatic, and gathered against outsiders—is an image the twentieth century learned to use, and that its fascination has not been exhausted by history. *Midsommar*'s achievement is to make that fascination felt and to make its price visible in the same image.

◉

5·7

The Ethics of Distance

Plessner, Arendt, and Sennett

In 1924, as the German youth movement and the parties of right and left competed in their longing for a total community, the philosopher Helmuth Plessner published a book against the longing (Plessner [1924] 1999). The radicalism of community, he argued, whether founded on blood or on reason, demands that persons be wholly transparent to one another,

sincere without reserve and united without remainder. Because the human being never wholly coincides with any of its expressions—a condition Plessner would later call eccentric positionality—the demand for total transparency is a demand for exposure, and exposure is a violation. Human dignity requires the artificial forms of society: roles, ceremony, diplomacy, masks, and above all tact, the cultivated capacity to perceive and respect the imponderable differences in another's situation without forcing them into the open. The soul, in Plessner's account, needs its veils, and a community that tears them away in the name of authenticity does not liberate the person but consumes her.

Plessner's book is the most precise philosophical diagnosis of sympathocracy ever written, composed a century before such a regime could be imagined on a screen. The Hårga have no tact. They do not respect Dani's grief; they amplify it. They leave her no reticence, no privacy, no hour alone, and no mask. The film adds a grotesque gloss to Plessner's thesis: the community that has abolished masks wears one after all, for the man who kills Josh wears Mark's flayed face. In a world without veils, the only mask left is the stranger's skin.

Hannah Arendt reached a related conclusion by a different road. In *On Revolution* she distinguished compassion, the capacity to be stricken by another's suffering, from pity, its sentimental generalization (Arendt 1963). Compassion, she argued, abolishes the distance, the worldly space between persons in which political matters arise and are settled. It is directed at the particular sufferer and cannot generalize, and it is curiously mute, expressing itself in gestures and in the expressions of the face rather than in words, which are the medium of persuasion and of law. Pity, by contrast, keeps its distance and generalizes its object into the suffering multitude; and when the French Revolution made pity for the unfortunate the source of political virtue, it licensed a cruelty beyond anything cruelty alone had achieved. The Hårga's chorus combines the defects of both. It has the muteness of compassion: its women do not speak but wail, and its holding is made of touch, breath, and gesture rather than words. And it has the generality of pity: it mirrors whoever suffers without knowing her, and it extends its feeling to an abstraction, the circle of the community's life, in whose name the strangers die. A polity founded on feeling-with, Arendt's analysis suggests, tends toward terror, because it has dissolved the space in which persons might disagree.

Richard Sennett, studying the decline of public life in the modern West, named the pathology that results when community is defined by shared feeling. He called it destructive *Gemeinschaft*: the belief that people become a community by disclosing their feelings to one another, which makes the boundaries of the community the boundaries of a shared emotion and turns those who do not share it into enemies (Sennett 1977). The Hårga are destructive *Gemeinschaft* in its purest form. Their community is the feeling they share, and those who cannot share it—the skeptical, the mocking, the scholarly, the mute—are not merely outside the community but against it.

Plessner, Arendt, and Sennett converge on the claim that this dissertation has called the missing middle (Proposition I). Between the cold society that cannot hold the bereaved and the hot community that holds them to death lies a third possibility: a sociality of distance, tact, words, and plural griefs, in which one may be accompanied without being absorbed. Dani's American world lacked it, and the Hårga abolish it. Seen from this vantage, the film's horror is not that it shows a community but that it shows no society: no form of common life in which a grieving woman could be held at the right distance.

◉

5.8

Grievability

Balder's Mourners and the Voice That Cannot Be Mirrored

Snorri Sturluson tells how the gods tried to bring Balder back from the dead (Snorri Sturluson 1987). Hel, the guardian of the underworld, agreed to release him on one condition: that everything in the world, living and dead, should weep for him. The gods sent messengers throughout the world, and all things wept—people and beasts, the earth and the stones, the trees and every metal—as, Snorri explains, such things weep when they are brought out of frost into warmth. Only one refused. In a cave the messengers found a giantess called Þökk, who answered that she would weep for Balder's burning with dry tears; and because a single voice withheld its weeping, Balder remained among the dead. The giantess, Snorri adds, was thought to have been Loki in disguise.

The myth is the archetype of the mirroring chorus and of its limit. Its ideal is a universal lament, a world in which every being answers a death with tears, and Snorri's account of how stones and metals weep, sweating as they come out of the cold, makes the lament a midsummer image: everything weeps when winter ends. The Hårga's chorus aspires to that universality. But the myth also discloses that the universal lament can be defeated by a single refusal, and the Hårga's economy runs the myth in reverse. In Snorri, the one who will not weep keeps the beloved among the dead. In *Midsommar*, the one who cannot weep is put to death. Christian, paralyzed and mute inside the bear, cannot answer the community's cry, and the community, which answers every cry it hears, does not answer his silence.

Judith Butler's account of grievability gives the observation its political sense. Lives, Butler argued, are differentially exposed to loss and differentially recognized as lost; some deaths are publicly mourned while others are never registered as deaths at all, because the lives in question were never framed as fully livable, and the frames that allocate grief are instruments of power (Butler 2004; 2009). The Hårga's chorus is such a frame, and its criterion of grievability is the voice. The elders' moans are mirrored. Dani's wail is mirrored. The volunteers' screams in the fire are mirrored. Christian's silence is not. The other outsiders are not mourned at all. Their deaths take place offscreen, and their bodies return as decor: Josh's leg planted in a flowerbed, Simon displayed in a barn as a blood eagle, Mark's skin worn as a mask, Connie absent until her body is laid in the temple. These are not grieved deaths but materials, the ungrievable converted into ornament.

The film's form participates in the allocation, as Chapter Three showed: the comedy anesthetizes sympathy for Christian, and the score swells for Dani while ignoring the fire. The frame that decides whose grief counts operates both within the fiction and upon its audience, and the spectator who mourns with the elders and rejoices with Dani has been made, for the duration of the film, a member of the chorus. The formula with which this dissertation began can now be restated in the terms of grief: what cannot be mirrored cannot be grieved, and what cannot be grieved can be burned.

5.9

Sympathocracy

A Political Theory of the Chorus

The elements assembled in this chapter allow sympathocracy to be defined as a political form. A sympathocracy is a regime whose sovereign is collective feeling. Its legitimacy derives from the experience of feeling together. Its central institution is the chorus, which produces affect, distributes it among members, and administers its intensities; its calendar fixes the occasions of feeling; its sacrifices discharge the feeling that accumulates; and its theology, as Chapter Two observed, needs no gods, because the community's feeling is itself the sacred. Its operating principles can be stated in the vocabulary the preceding sections supplied. It prefers unison to concord, raising every voice to the pitch of the sufferer instead of asking the sufferer to lower hers. It replaces fellow-feeling with contagion and identification, abolishing the distance in which another's grief is recognized as another's. It substitutes echo for antiphony, so that its mourners bring no sorrows of their own, no words, and no accusations. It amplifies where Hume's mirrors let passion decay. It organizes mimesis, in Adorno and Horkheimer's sense, and converts the cohesion that synchrony produces into compliance. It has no tact, no masks, and no veils. And it allocates grievability by voice, holding every cry it can mirror and letting fall every silence it cannot.

Such a regime answers real needs, and its appeal should not be underestimated. It restores the public form of grief that modernity abandoned; it ends the solitude of the bereaved; and it offers the experience, rarer than any other in late-modern life, of being answered completely. Its danger lies in the same features. A community that answers completely leaves no room for the answer it does not wish to give, and it cannot see the others whom its answering excludes.

Sympathocracy is not only a fantasy of the archaic; it names a tendency of the present. The platforms through which much of contemporary social life is conducted are, among other things, machines for mirroring. They reward the reproduction of others' expressions, amplify affect instead of letting it decay, and sort their users into communities defined by shared

feeling. In 2014 researchers at Facebook and Cornell published an experiment, conducted on several hundred thousand users without their specific knowledge, showing that reducing the emotional content of what users saw in their news feeds measurably altered the emotional content of what they themselves posted: emotional contagion, at scale, through a network (Kramer, Guillory, and Hancock 2014). More than a decade earlier, Cass Sunstein had warned that such networks tend to produce echo chambers, in which like-minded groups amplify their members' views and grow more extreme (Sunstein 2001). The echo chamber is the digital form of the mirroring chorus, and *Midsommar*, released in 2019, gave its logic an archaic body. The Hårga are what a community of pure resonance would look like if it could be built in a meadow.

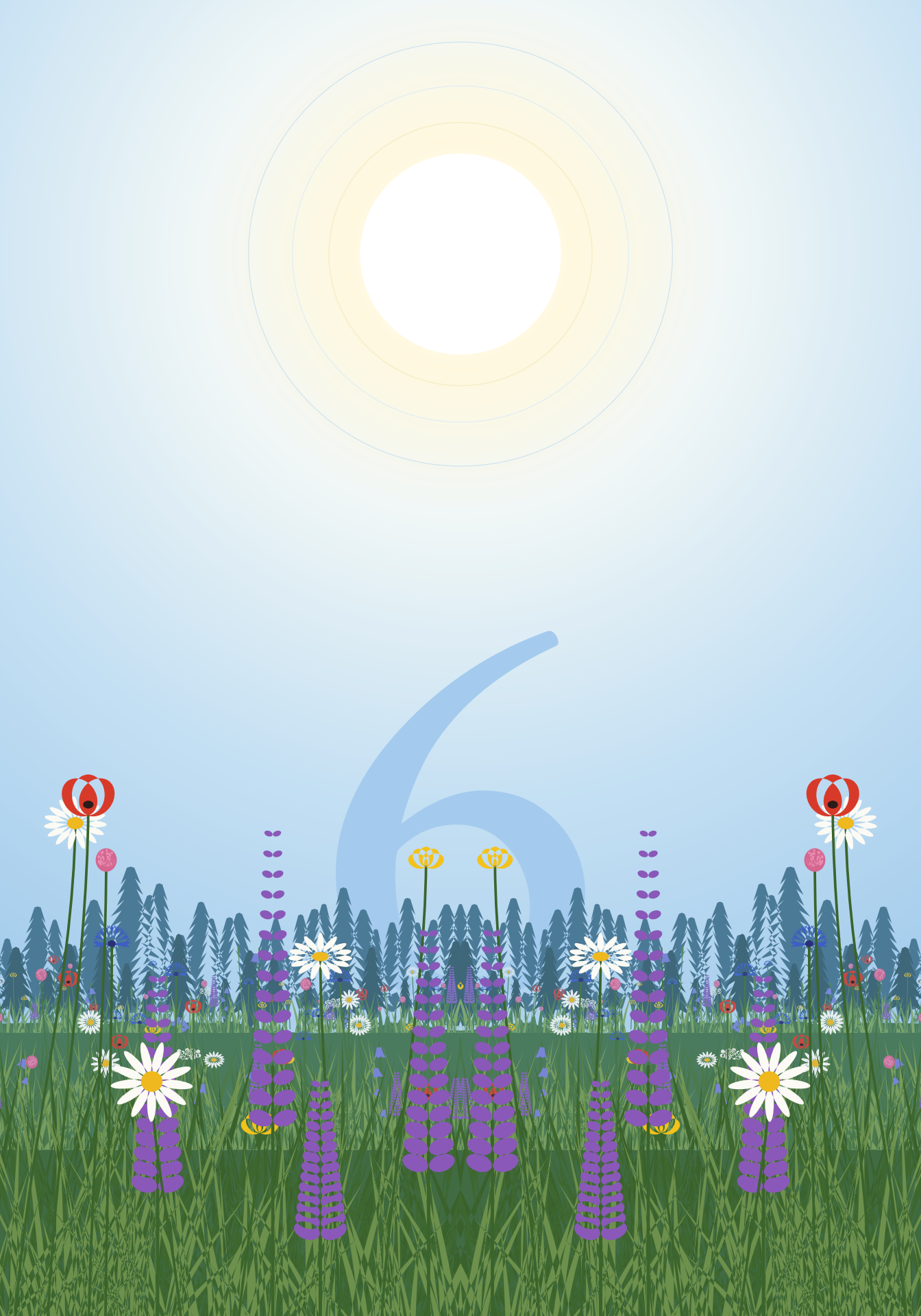
5.10

Conclusion

Against Unison

The chorus is the heart of the film's seduction and the engine of its horror, and the two cannot be separated. What the Hårga give Dani in the women's wailing is real, and the captivity reading of the film, which dismisses it as manipulation, misunderstands both the film and the need it addresses. But what the chorus gives is resonance without recognition, unison without concord, echo without antiphony. It answers Dani's cry by abolishing the interval in which her grief could be known as hers, and it sustains its answer by excluding every voice that cannot join it. Proposition II is thereby established: the Hårga's fundamental technology is organized mimesis, and their violence is the price of their resonance.

Adam Smith thought concord was all that a society needed or required, and the history of lament suggests that he was right. The women who wept over Patroclus, each for her own sorrows, held the bereaved without consuming her. The next chapter turns from the chorus to the figure at its center: the May Queen, the bear she chooses for the fire, and the gendered sovereignty that the film builds out of their exchange.



CHAPTER SIX

The Bear, the Queen, and the Fool

Gender, Desire, and the Inversion of Sacral Kingship

They'll turn me to a bear sae grim,
And then a lion bold;
But hold me fast, and fear me not,
As ye shall love your child.

— "Tam Lin" (Child 39A)

My Oberon! what visions have I seen!
Methought I was enamour'd of an ass.

— Shakespeare, *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, act 4, scene 1

6.1

Hold Me Fast

Tam Lin and the Woman Who Lets Fall

The epigraph of this dissertation comes from a Scottish ballad, and the ballad is the film's secret twin. In "Tam Lin," as Francis James Child printed it from the text that Robert Burns supplied to James Johnson's *Scots Musical Museum* in 1792, Janet goes to Carterhaugh, meets the elfin knight Tam Lin among the roses, and conceives his child (Child 1882–98, no. 39A). Tam Lin was once a mortal, taken by the Queen of the Fairies, and he tells Janet of the danger that awaits him. Fairyland is pleasant, he says, but every seven years its people pay a tithe, a *teind*, to hell, and he fears that, being so fair and full of flesh, he will be

the payment. Janet can save him on Halloween night, when the fairy host rides, if she pulls him from his milk-white horse and holds him fast while the fairies transform him in her arms: into an adder, a bear, a lion, a red-hot rod of iron, a burning coal. Through each transformation the refrain repeats its plea, to hold him fast and not to fear him, for he is the father of her child. Janet holds him, throws the burning coal into well water, and covers the naked man who emerges with her green mantle. The Queen of the Fairies, cheated of her tithe, cries out from a bush of broom against the woman who has taken the finest knight in all her company.

Every element of the ballad's climax recurs in *Midsommar*, and every one is inverted. A matriarchal power owes a periodic tithe of human flesh. The man destined for the tithe is desired by those who choose him, and he is the father of a child. In the crucial hour he is turned into a bear and given to the fire. And a woman stands before him with the power to hold him or to let him go. Janet holds; Dani lets fall. Janet saves her child's father from the tithe; Dani gives to it the father of another woman's child. Janet covers her lover with her green mantle; in *Midsommar* the mantle of flowers covers the woman, and the man is wrapped in the bear. The Queen of the Fairies is defeated by a woman's loyalty; the Hårga's matriarchal order is completed by a woman's choice. The ballad is the oldest northern statement of the ethic of holding that this dissertation has traced, the conviction that love consists in keeping hold of the beloved through every monstrous transformation, and *Midsommar* is that ethic's negative. Its heroine is held by the community at the precise moment, and by the precise means, that she lets go of the man.

This chapter reads the film's sexual politics through that inversion. The tradition of sacral kingship described by Frazer, Graves, and the mythographers of the dying god placed a male body at the center of the community's fate, and beside it a goddess who survived when the king or consort died. *Midsommar* raises a woman to sovereignty and sends her consort to the fire; it crowns a queen, turns her partner into a fool and a beast, and grants her the choice of his death. The inversion is at once a fantasy of female power, deeply satisfying to an audience that has watched Dani's grief dismissed, and a mechanism by which a collective's violence is laundered through a woman's will. The film, this chapter argues, indulges the fantasy and indicts it at the same time.

6.2

The Goddess and Her Consort

Inanna, Freyr, and the Dying God

The Golden Bough begins with a priest-king, the King of the Wood at Nemi, who held his office until a successor killed him, and from that figure Frazer built a theory of sacral kingship: the king's vigor is bound to the fertility of the land, and when it wanes he must die and be replaced (Frazer 1906–15). Around the king Frazer assembled the dying gods of the eastern Mediterranean—Tammuz, Adonis, Attis, Osiris—each the youthful consort of a great goddess who survives his death, mourns him, and presides over his return. The pattern is constant. The goddess endures, the consort dies, and the community lives by the cycle.

The oldest version of the pattern supplies the most exact precedent for Dani's choice. In the Sumerian poem known as Inanna's Descent to the Underworld, the goddess passes through the seven gates of the realm of her sister Ereshkigal, is stripped, killed, and hung upon a hook, and is revived only on condition that she provide a substitute to take her place among the dead (Wolkstein and Kramer 1983). The demons who escort her back to the upper world move to seize, in turn, her faithful servant and her sons, and each time Inanna refuses them, because each has put on mourning, torn their garments, and wept for her. At last they come upon her husband, Dumuzi, who has not mourned at all: he sits on his throne in splendid garments. Inanna fixes upon him the eye of death, speaks the word of anger against him, and gives him to the demons as her substitute. The mourners are spared; the one who did not mourn is sent to the dead.

Midsommar's finale follows the Sumerian logic precisely. The Hårga mourned with Dani. They wept her grief and answered her cry, and the community is spared, but for the volunteers who offer themselves. Christian did not mourn with her. Through the long winter of her bereavement he held her body and withheld his voice, and at the festival he was found, in the eyes of the woman he had failed, in the splendor of another woman's bed. The May Queen fixes on him the eye of death. Read through Inanna, Dani's choice is not merely revenge for infidelity. It is the archaic judgment of the goddess against the consort who failed to mourn.

The northern archive has its own consort. Adam of Bremen's Fricco, the Freyr of the Norse sources, presided at Uppsala over peace, pleasure, and marriage (§2.3), and a comic tale preserved in the Icelandic *Flateyjarbók*, which Frazer retold as the story of the god Frey and his human wife, shows how the cult might use an outsider (Frazer 1906–15). A Norwegian fugitive named Gunnarr helmingr, sheltering in Sweden, falls in with the young priestess who travels the country with Freyr's image in a wagon and is reputed to be the god's wife. He destroys the image and takes the god's place, and the Swedes receive him with delight: their god now eats and drinks, the weather is fair, and the priestess is soon with child. The stranger serves as the god's stand-in in the sacred marriage, and the community rejoices in the fertility he brings. Christian's function among the Hårga is Gunnarr's without Gunnarr's luck. He is brought in from outside and joined to a daughter of the commune for the renewal of its blood, and then, his service rendered, he is consigned to the fire.

Robert Graves gave the dying consort his most influential modern form. In *The White Goddess* he imagined a primordial religion of the Triple Goddess—maiden, mother, and crone—whose sacred king reigned for a season and was sacrificed, and he divided the year between twin kings, the Oak King of the waxing year, slain at midsummer, and the Holly King of the waning year (Graves 1948). Graves's mythography was poetry presented as scholarship. It descends from Johann Jakob Bachofen's nineteenth-century theory of a primordial mother-right that preceded patriarchy (Bachofen [1861] 1967); by way of Marija Gimbutas's archaeology of a goddess-centered Old Europe (Gimbutas 1974), it passed into the feminist spirituality of the late twentieth century; and Cynthia Eller has shown how little evidence supports the myth of a matriarchal prehistory (Eller 2000). The Hårga are that myth made flesh: a community governed by a matriarch, in which a consort is taken for his seed and killed at midsummer. Like the archive examined in Chapter Two, their gender theology is a modern fabrication disguised as an ancient truth, and its power lies in the disguise.

6.3

The Furies Unappeased

Bachofen's Oresteia in Reverse

Bachofen found the decisive episode of his history of mother-right in Aeschylus. In the *Oresteia*, Orestes kills his mother, Clytemnestra, to avenge his father, Agamemnon, whom she murdered on his return from Troy, and he is pursued by the Furies, the Erinyes, ancient avengers of blood shed within the family and above all of a mother's blood. In the *Eumenides*, the trilogy's final play, he stands trial at Athens. Apollo, his defender, argues that the mother is not truly the parent of the child but only the nurse of the seed the father has sown, and he offers as proof Athena herself, born from the head of Zeus without a mother. The jurors' votes fall equally, Athena's vote decides for Orestes, and the Furies, enraged at the overthrow of their ancient right, are persuaded at last to accept a home beneath the city as its kindly guardians, the Eumenides (Aeschylus 1926). Bachofen read the trilogy as the mythic record of a world-historical transition: the victory of an Apollonian father-right over a chthonic mother-right (Bachofen [1861] 1967).

Midsommar stages the *Oresteia* in reverse. Its Furies are not appeased. The women of the Hårga, avengers of the injuries done within the circle of feeling, pursue the man who failed his bereaved partner, and they win. There is no Athena to cast her vote in his favor, no Apollo to plead the priority of the father, and no court but the community's own rite. Christian's paternity, which Apollo made the ground of the father's right, is precisely what the Hårga take from him and turn against him: his seed is collected for the commune, and his life is given to the fire. And the Apollonian form that Bachofen identified with the father's triumph, the form of light, order, measure, and law, is placed by the film, as Chapter Three argued, in the service of the mother's order. The film's daylight is Apollo's, but its justice is the Furies'.

The Furies' transformation into the Eumenides, the Kindly Ones, finds its own echo. The Hårga women are kindness itself to Dani: they hold her, wail with her, dress her, call her sister. Their kindness and their vengeance are not two aspects of their nature waiting to be reconciled by a goddess's

persuasion; they are one force, directed inward as holding and outward as fire. In Aeschylus the city domesticates the avengers by giving them a home. In *Midsommar* the avengers give a home to the bereaved, and the price of the home is the avenged man's death.

◉

6.4

The Midsummer Bride and the Queen's Two Bodies

Frazer also recorded the Swedish custom from which the May Queen of *Midsommar* most directly descends. In Sweden, he observed, the ceremonies held elsewhere on May Day or at Whitsuntide commonly take place at Midsummer, and in parts of the province of Blekinge the young people still chose a Midsummer's Bride, to whom the church's bridal crown was sometimes lent; the girl chose a bridegroom for herself, a collection was made for the pair, and for the time being the two were regarded as man and wife (Frazer 1906–15). The Midsummer Bride is a figure of sovereign choice: she is crowned, and she chooses. *Midsommar* preserves both functions and inverts the second. Its crowned girl does not choose a bridegroom; she chooses a victim, and the man who might have been her consort becomes her offering. The choice of a bridegroom passes to another girl, Maja, who selects Christian with the help of love magic and is joined to him in the coupling rite.

The English May Queen, whose crown Dani wins in the dance, carried her own premonition of death. Tennyson's "The May Queen," among the most popular poems of the Victorian age, opens with a girl begging her mother to wake her early, because tomorrow she is to be Queen of the May; its sequels find her dying through the following winter and waiting for death as the next spring comes in (Tennyson 1842). The May Queen of Victorian sentiment was crowned to die. *Midsommar*'s May Queen survives her coronation, and the death the tradition assigned her is transferred to her consort.

What kind of sovereignty does the crown confer? Ernst Kantorowicz showed that medieval political theology distinguished the king's two bodies: the natural body, mortal and fallible, and the body politic, which never dies and in which the community's continuity is lodged (Kantorowicz

1957). The May Queen has two bodies in exactly this sense. Beneath the crown is a grieving young woman from an American city; over her is laid the immense gown of flowers that the film shows breathing (§3.6), the Hårga's body politic made into a garment. Giorgio Agamben, extending Kantorowicz, distinguished reign from government, the sovereignty that is acclaimed from the administration that decides, and found the secret of Western power in their separation: the king reigns but does not govern, and his reign consists in glory, the liturgical acclamation that surrounds the throne (Agamben [2007] 2011). The Hårga's political structure follows Agamben's diagram. The May Queen reigns; the elders govern. Her coronation is surrounded by acclamation, the chorus whose cries form the liturgy of her glory. But the decisions that matter—the recruitment of the outsiders, the love magic, the coupling, the preparation of the temple—were made before she was crowned, and the one decision left to her, the choice of the ninth offering, is framed so that only one answer is likely. Dani's sovereignty is real as glory and nominal as power.

◉

6.5

The Bear

Pastoureau's Fallen King

Michel Pastoureau's history of the bear in Western culture bears a subtitle that could gloss Christian's fate: the history of a fallen king (Pastoureau [2007] 2011). For much of pagan Europe, Pastoureau argued, the bear was the king of beasts: the strongest animal of the northern forests, the one most like a human being in its upright stance and its appetites, venerated in cults, invoked by warriors, and imagined in folklore as the lover and abductor of women and the father of half-human sons. The Norse berserkers took their name from the bear's shirt in which they fought, and the Germanic word for the animal itself, on a widely accepted etymology, began as a euphemism meaning "the brown one," a substitute for a true name too dangerous to pronounce. From the eighth century onward, Pastoureau showed, the Church waged a long campaign against the bear: mass killings in the forests of Saxony under the Carolingians, the bear's recasting as a creature of the devil, its humiliation as a muzzled dancer led from fair to

fair, and finally, by the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, its replacement as king of beasts by the lion, an exotic animal of Scripture and heraldry. The bear fell from king to fool.

Christian falls the same way. He enters the film as Dani's consort, the man around whom her life is organized; he becomes, in the course of the festival, a fool, drugged, used, laughed at, and chased naked across the commune; and he ends inside the bear, the fallen king's skin enclosing the fallen consort. But the film runs Pastoureau's history backward. In Christian Europe the Church dethroned the pagan king of beasts. In the Hårga's world a pagan community places a man named Christian inside that king's carcass and burns him. If the bear can be said to have its revenge, it is to become the shroud of the faith that dethroned it.

The Hårga keep their bear in a cage in the commune from the visitors' first days, a detail with a precise ethnographic analogue. The bear ceremonialism of the circumpolar north, whose distribution A. Irving Hallowell mapped in 1926, honored the slain bear as a guest and kinsman, with ritual speeches, feasts, and the careful disposal of its bones (Hallowell 1926). In its most elaborate form, the bear-sending festival of the Ainu of Hokkaido and Sakhalin, the *iyomante*, a cub was captured and raised in a wooden cage within the village, fed and tended, and after a year or more ritually killed amid songs and offerings, so that its spirit might be sent home to the gods laden with gifts. The Hårga's bear is an iyomante bear, a creature kept within the community in order to be killed by it, honored and caged at once. Christian becomes its double. He too is a guest kept within the community, fed and tended and given a place in its rites, and killed so that his life may be returned to the circle.

The northern sagas also know a man turned into a bear by a queen. In *Hrólfs saga kraka*, the young Björn rejects the advances of his stepmother, Queen Hvít, who strikes him with a wolfskin glove and curses him to become a beast of the forest. He lives as a bear by day and a man by night, meets his beloved, Bera, in his cave, and is at last hunted down and killed, whereupon the queen forces the pregnant Bera to eat of his flesh. One of the sons she bears, Böðvarr Bjarki, later fights in the shape of a great bear while his human body sits motionless in the king's hall, and the battle turns only when a companion rouses him (Byock 1998). Christian's fate condenses both episodes. A queen's community turns him into a beast; the woman who loved him consumes him, not by eating his flesh but by

choosing his death; and his body lies motionless inside the bear while others decide the outcome. In the saga the bear-shape is the warrior's power. In the film it is the consort's paralysis.

The ballad that opened this chapter supplies the final turn. Among the shapes into which the fairies transform Tam Lin is a bear "sae grim"; Janet holds the bear, and the bear becomes a man again. Dani does not hold the bear. In *Midsommar* the man's transformation into a beast is not a trial for love to endure but the community's last word on him: he who could not hold her grief becomes a creature that cannot be held, and what cannot be held is burned.

6.6

The Fool in the May Games

Howie, Christian, and Bottom

The fool has an old place in the festivals of spring and summer. The morris dance had its fool, the May games their mock kings and buffoons, and the medieval Feast of Fools turned the hierarchy of the Church upside down for a day. Robin Hardy's *The Wicker Man* makes the fool its sacrifice. As the wicker figure awaits him, Lord Summerisle explains to Sergeant Howie that the victim the island required had to come of his own free will, with the power of a king, as a virgin, and as a fool. Howie came voluntarily, as the representative of the law. He is a virgin, a devout Christian saving himself for marriage, who resisted the naked song and dance with which Willow, the landlord's daughter, tried the previous night to seduce him through the wall of his room. And he is a fool, having played the part in the May Day procession in the costume of Punch. Willow was played by Britt Ekland, a Swede, so that the canonical scene of pagan seduction in English folk horror already belongs to a Swedish body.

Christian meets three of Summerisle's criteria and fails the fourth in the opposite direction. He came of his own free will; he is a fool, in the sense that the film's comedy makes of him; and as Dani's partner he occupies the place of the queen's consort. But he is not chaste, and his unchastity, unlike Howie's virtue, is engineered by his hosts. Where Willow's seduction failed against Howie's faith, Maja's succeeds against Christian's

emptiness, assisted by love magic and a hallucinogenic tea. *The Wicker Man* needed a virgin; the Hårga need a father. Summerisle's islanders sacrifice a man for his purity; the Hårga use a man for his seed and then sacrifice him for a betrayal they themselves arranged.

Shakespeare's comedy of midsummer supplies the film's other fool. In *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, Oberon, quarreling with his queen, squeezes into her sleeping eyes the juice of a flower that makes the sleeper dote on the first creature she sees, and Titania wakes to love Bottom the weaver, on whom Puck has fixed the head of an ass (Shakespeare 2017). The queen of the fairies dotes on a man with a beast's head until the enchantment is lifted, and she wakes to marvel at what she has loved. The film rearranges the comedy's elements with grim precision. The flower juice called love-in-idleness becomes the bodily love magic of the Hårga, administered not to the queen but to the man; the man with a beast's head becomes the man inside a beast's body; and Titania's awakening becomes Dani's. Titania, released from the enchantment, recoils from the ass she embraced and is reconciled with her king. Dani, released from her four years with Christian, wakes to find him already a beast, and she gives the beast to the fire. The midsummer night's dream ends in weddings; *Midsommar* ends in a burning, and its wedding is between the queen and the community.

6.7

Agave, Electra, Medea

Tragedy's Women and the Burning House

Euripides' *Bacchae* is the classical tragedy of a community of ecstatic women and the man who intrudes upon their rite (Dodds 1960). Dionysus, a stranger from Asia, arrives in Thebes in human form and drives its women, among them the king's own mother, Agave, into the mountains as maenads. Pentheus, the young king, forbids the cult, imprisons the stranger, and resolves to see the women's rites for himself. The god, working on his curiosity and his suppressed desire, persuades him to dress as a woman and leads him to Mount Cithaeron to watch from the top of a pine. The maenads discover him, uproot the tree, and tear him apart, his mother first among them. Agave returns to Thebes exultant, carrying

her son's head, which she believes to be the head of a young lion she has hunted, and calls on the city to share her triumph. Only when her father, Cadmus, leads her step by step to look first at the sky and then at what she holds does she recognize what she has done.

The Bacchae and *Midsommar* share their materials and invert their forms. Both stage a women's rite of ecstatic communion. Both punish a man who intrudes upon it with the desire to see. Both transform the victim into an animal in the eyes of his killers, Pentheus into a lion and Christian into a bear. Pentheus is the archetypal anthropologist of the forbidden rite, the voyeur who must look upon the women's mysteries, and his fate anticipates Josh's, who dies for photographing the Hårga's scripture, as well as Christian's, who presses toward the commune's secrets in the name of a thesis. The stranger in Euripides is the god who destroys the city's king; the strangers in Aster are the victims whom the community destroys.

The tragic structure, above all, runs in opposite directions. Agave's joy precedes her recognition: she exults in the hunt until Cadmus brings her to see the truth, and the recognition is catastrophe. Dani's recognition precedes her joy: she sees what the fire is, who is in it, and what her choice has done, and then she smiles. Euripides gives the classical form of tragic anagnorisis, the passage from euphoria to horror. Aster gives its inversion, the passage from horror to euphoria, which this dissertation calls euphoric anagnorisis. Agave's joy is the madness from which recognition rescues her; Dani's joy is what recognition produces.

Girard read *The Bacchae* as the paradigm of the sacrificial crisis, a drama in which the differences between god and man, man and woman, and human and beast collapse until the community discharges its violence on a single victim (Girard [1972] 1977). The Hårga, who have institutionalized the undifferentiation that Euripides depicts as crisis, can stage the maenads' dismemberment of the intruder as festival. What the tragedian showed as the catastrophe of a city, the film shows as the routine of a commune, and the spectator, carried by the score, is invited to share Agave's triumph without Agave's awakening.

Sophocles' *Electra* supplies the image that the film's final scene most closely recalls. Electra is the mourner who will not stop mourning. For years she has lamented her murdered father in the unforgetting grief that Nicole Loraux identified as the most dangerous form of women's mourning, a lament that refuses to end because it is waiting for vengeance (Loraux

[1990] 1998). When her brother Orestes returns and enters the palace to kill their mother, Electra remains outside the doors. She hears Clytemnestra's cries from within and calls through the doors for her brother to strike again, if he has the strength (Sophocles 1994, *Electra* 1415). A woman outside the house, listening to the death cries of the one she hates, her grief turned in an instant into exultation: the scene is the classical prototype of Dani before the burning temple. Electra's unending lament ends in a killing, and Dani's unanswered wail ends in the fire. In both, mourning proves to have been the long preparation of a joy that arrives with a death.

Euripides' *Medea* completes the series and gives the film its most precise classical analogue. Medea is a foreign woman, a princess of distant Colchis whom Jason has brought to Greece and now abandons in order to marry the daughter of the king of Corinth. Feigning reconciliation, she sends the bride gifts, a fine robe and a crown of beaten gold. When the bride puts them on, the crown pours out a stream of devouring fire and the robe eats into her flesh, and her father dies embracing her (Euripides 1994). Medea's gifts are the Germanic *Gift* of Chapter Four in Greek dress, presents that are poison, and their instruments are a crown and a gown. *Midsommar* rearranges the elements with its characteristic exactness. Its foreign woman is abandoned for a local girl; she, not the rival, is given the crown and the gown; and the fire consumes neither the rival, who will bear the betrayer's child, nor the woman, but the betrayer himself, where Euripides' Jason survives to lament. The play's ending, finally, supplies the image toward which this dissertation has been moving. Having killed the bride, the king, and her own children, Medea escapes in a chariot drawn by dragons, sent to her by her grandfather, the Sun. The betrayed foreign woman, after the burning, is carried off by the sun. Chapter Eight takes up that solar apotheosis, and the white light in which Dani's smile is set.

6.8

Midsummer Night in Strindberg's Kitchen

Miss Julie and The Father

Swedish literature's most famous Midsummer Eve ends in death at sunrise. August Strindberg's *Miss Julie* (1888) takes place in a count's kitchen on

Midsummer Night, while the servants of the estate dance and sing outside (Strindberg 1998). Julie, the count's daughter, lately freed from a broken engagement, dances with the valet, Jean, seduces him and is seduced by him, and finds herself, as night turns to morning, trapped between disgrace and flight. Jean kills her pet bird with a cleaver. At sunrise he puts a razor in her hand, and she walks out of the kitchen to her death. Strindberg's preface presents the play as a naturalist study of heredity, environment, and the struggle of the sexes, and the play's misogyny is inseparable from its power: Julie is, in Strindberg's own term, a "half-woman," and her destruction is offered as a natural outcome.

Midsommar inverts *Miss Julie* with almost diagrammatic exactness. Both stage the Swedish midsummer as a night of sexual license and of transgression across a boundary, of class in Strindberg and of culture in Aster, and both end in a death at the turning of the light. But in Strindberg the woman dies and the man survives; in Aster the man dies and the woman survives. The battle of the sexes that Strindberg narrated as the woman's destruction, Aster narrates as the man's.

Strindberg's *The Father* (1887) adds the theme on which the Hårga's treatment of Christian turns. In that play a cavalry captain is destroyed by his wife, who drives him to madness by planting in him the doubt that he is truly the father of their daughter; paternity, the play insists, is the man's unprovable claim, the point at which his authority depends wholly on a woman's word (Strindberg 1998). The Hårga realize the Captain's nightmare. Christian's paternity is taken from him: he fathers a child for the commune, under the supervision of its women, and the child will belong to the community that kills him. The man is reduced to his seed and then removed, and the community receives his child as the Fairy Queen would have received her tithe.

The Scandinavian drama of the couple, from Strindberg's stage to Ingmar Bergman's *Scenes from a Marriage* (1973), made the dissolution of a marriage one of the central subjects of modern art, and Aster's breakup film belongs to that lineage. What distinguishes it is that the dissolution is not negotiated between two people but decided by a third party, a community, which offers the woman a way out that consists in the man's death. The war of two that the Scandinavian theater of the couple always staged becomes, in *Midsommar*, the victory of the many over the one.

6.9

The Final Girl Crowned

Neumann, Creed, Clover, and the Politics of Revenge

The Hårga's matriarchal order invites interpretation through the archetypal psychology of the feminine. Erich Neumann's *The Great Mother* described the archetypal Feminine, in its elementary character, as a vessel: the body that contains, shelters, nourishes, and holds, in an image that equates woman with body, vessel, and world (Neumann 1955). The same archetype has a negative pole, the Terrible Mother, who devours what she has held, so that the womb that shelters is also the tomb that receives. Neumann's Great Mother is the mythological correlate of Winnicott's holding environment, and her two faces are the two faces of the Hårga's embrace. The community that holds Dani as a vessel holds Christian as a tomb.

Barbara Creed's psychoanalytic study of horror, *The Monstrous-Feminine*, read the genre's female monsters—the archaic mother, the monstrous womb, the witch, the castrating woman—as figures of male anxiety about the generative and destructive powers attributed to women (Creed 1993). Creed drew on Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection, which distinguished two classes of polluting substance: excrement, which threatens identity from outside, and menstrual blood, which threatens it from within, as the mark of sexual difference (Kristeva [1980] 1982). The Hårga's love magic works with the substances of abjection. A pubic hair is baked into Christian's pie and menstrual blood colors his drink: the man is made to ingest the abject feminine, and the ingestion binds him to the community that will consume him. In Creed's terms the commune is the archaic mother, the generative and devouring origin to which the male intruder is returned.

Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* read the slasher film's Final Girl, the resourceful young woman who alone survives the killer and often destroys him, as the figure through which a largely male audience identified with female suffering and triumph, and she read the rape-revenge film as a genre in which a violated woman exacts vengeance on the men who wronged her (Clover 1992). Dani is a Final Girl of a new kind. She is the only one of the visitors to survive, but she survives not by defeating

the killers but by joining them, and her final confrontation is not with the monster but with the man she loved. The film borrows the structure of rape-revenge and turns it inside out. The sexual violation at its center is inflicted not on the woman but on the man, who is drugged into the coupling rite by his hosts, and the revenge punishes him for an infidelity that the violation itself produced. Christian is at once the betrayer whom Dani punishes and the victim of a betrayal the community arranged.

Here the film both indulges and indicts. It indulges the fantasy of revenge. The long humiliation of Dani's grief by a partner who resented it, the friends who wished her gone, the dismissal of her feelings as a burden: all find their answer in the fire, and the score, the composition, and the final smile invite the audience to share her release. Aster's own description of the film as a perverse wish-fulfillment acknowledges the invitation. But the film also documents the engineering of the wish. The infidelity was manufactured with love magic and drugs; the choice was framed so that it could have only one likely outcome; the queen's sovereignty is glory without government. The revenge that feels like Dani's is the community's, and the woman's will is the instrument through which a collective's violence acquires the appearance of personal justice. The gendered fantasy of the breakup film, a woman's liberation from the man who failed her, is thereby exposed as the mask of a sacrificial machine that needs her choice in order to disavow its own.

Aster's films approach this structure from opposite sides. In *Hereditary*, a cult led by the protagonist's mother, who appears in a photograph crowned as its queen, destroys a family in order to install a male demon in the body of a son, and the film ends with the boy crowned king before a kneeling congregation (§1.2). *Midsommar* inverts the gender of the coronation. Its collective destroys men in order to crown a woman, and the woman, unlike *Hereditary*'s possessed son, appears to rejoice. In both films, however, the coronation is the culmination of a design that the crowned figure did not author.

6.10

Conclusion

Sovereignty as Instrument

The inversion of sacral kingship that *Midsommar* performs can now be summarized. In the tradition that runs from Frazer's King of the Wood to Graves's Oak King, sovereignty was lodged in a male body whose death renewed the land, and the goddess who outlived him presided over his return. *Midsommar* crowns the goddess and burns the consort. Inanna's judgment against the husband who did not mourn, the Furies' victory over the father's right, the Midsummer Bride's choice, Brynhildr's vengeance (§2.7), and the Fairy Queen's tithe converge on a single scene. The bear dethroned by Christendom becomes the shroud of a man named Christian; the fool of the May games becomes the offering; Titania wakes and burns her ass; Agave rejoices and does not awaken; Julie lives and Jean dies.

Yet the queen's sovereignty is the community's instrument. She reigns in glory while the elders govern; her choice is real and framed; her revenge is hers and theirs. The film's gender politics therefore cannot be reduced to either of the readings with which this dissertation began. Dani is not simply liberated, because her liberation is the community's design; she is not simply captured, because the design answers needs that her old world refused. She is held, at last, by a power that requires her to let fall the man who could not hold her. Janet held Tam Lin through the bear and the burning, and Dani does not; the ballad's refrain, hold me fast and fear me not, sounds in the film only as an absence, in the silence of the bear.

The next chapter turns from the queen to those who came to study her people: the ethnographers devoured by their object, and the oracle whose scripture they tried to read.





CHAPTER SEVEN

Ethnographers Devoured

Anthropology, Aura, and the Hermeneutics of the Oracle

ὁ ἄναξ, οὗ τὸ μαντεῖόν ἐστι τὸ ἐν Δελφοῖς, οὔτε λέγει οὔτε κρύπτει ἀλλὰ σημαίνει.

— Heraclitus, fragment 93 (Diels-Kranz)

The most merciful thing in the world, I think, is the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents.

— H. P. Lovecraft, "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928)

7.1

The Thesis and the Fire

Anthropologists in the Field

Midsommar is a film about anthropologists. Christian and Josh are graduate students in anthropology, and Mark is their friend; Josh is writing his dissertation on European midsummer festivals and has come to the Hårga to study one; Pelle, the Hårga-born friend who invites them, is a fellow student at their American university. The journey to Hälsingland is, among other things, fieldwork, and the film follows its academic logic with satirical precision. Josh brings the apparatus of his discipline: notes, questions, formal requests to the elders. Christian, who has no topic of his own, decides on the spot to write about the Hårga too, appropriating Josh's subject and provoking a quarrel over intellectual property in the middle of a pagan festival. The elders consent

to the research on one condition, which is also the discipline's own ethical rule: the theses must omit the names and location of the community. The people who will kill the researchers insist, with perfect professional propriety, on their anonymity. And when the two elders leap from the cliff and the visitors' horror breaks out, the students respond in the vocabulary of their training. They urge respect for a custom they do not share, and they stay, because the custom has become material for theses.

None of the anthropologists survives. Josh, who tries to photograph the Hårga's scripture after being told that it may not be photographed, is killed in the temple. Christian, who presses toward the commune's secrets in the name of his thesis, is burned in the bear. The only visitor who survives is the one who came with no research question and no professional distance, the one who came, in a sense, to be studied rather than to study: Dani, whose grief the commune reads, assesses, and answers. The film is thus a parable of ethnographic knowledge in which the observers are observed, the readers are read, and the writers are written. This chapter examines the parable through the critical history of anthropology itself: Johannes Fabian's account of the discipline's denial of shared time; the interpretive ideals of Bronislaw Malinowski and Clifford Geertz, and the crisis of ethnographic authority that followed them; Walter Benjamin's theory of the aura; the ancient hermeneutics of the oracle; and Max Weber's account of the sacrifice of the intellect. Its claim is that the film literalizes Weber's metaphor. In the Hårga, the intellect is sacrificed not as a figure of speech but as a body count, and the only knowledge the commune permits is the knowledge that comes from belonging.



7.2

Allochronism

Fabian and the Denial of Coevalness

Johannes Fabian's *Time and the Other* diagnosed anthropology's founding contradiction (Fabian 1983). In the field, the ethnographer shares time with the people he studies: he talks, eats, and lives with them in a common present. In writing, he removes them from that present. The discourse of the discipline places its objects in another time—the primitive, the archaic,

the traditional, the "ethnographic present" that freezes a living people into a timeless description—and so performs what Fabian called the denial of coevalness, the refusal to recognize that the observed are the observer's contemporaries. Frazer's doctrine of survivals, which read the folk customs of modern Europe as relics of a forgotten past (§4.2), is the paradigm of this allochronic discourse, and it is the discourse the film's anthropologists bring to Hälsingland. They see the Hårga as a survival, an archaic people preserving rites the modern world has lost, and they treat the festival as a window onto the past. Dean MacCannell observed that the modern tourist travels in search of an authenticity that his own society has lost and that he believes others still possess (MacCannell 1976). The anthropologists are tourists of time, and the Hårga's lure is precisely the pastness they hope to find.

The error is fatal, because the Hårga are entirely coeval. Their recruiter studies at an American university. Their summer pilgrimages send young people into the modern world to bring back guests. They understand the visitors' ambitions, careers, relationships, and vulnerabilities as precisely as any contemporary could. And as Chapter Two argued, their antiquity is itself a modern construction, an archive manufactured to produce the very effect of pastness that the anthropologists accept at face value. The students' allochronism blinds them to the strategic present in which they are caught. They believe they are visiting the past; they are being processed by the present.

The film completes Fabian's critique by reversing the gaze. Roy Wagner used the phrase reverse anthropology for the ways in which peoples studied by anthropologists produced their own interpretations of the anthropologists and of the civilization that sent them (Wagner [1975] 1981). Pelle is a reverse anthropologist. He has lived among the Americans as they will live among his people. He has observed them, assessed them, and recorded them; he draws Dani's portrait, and he diagnoses her condition with a single question about whether she feels held (§1.7). His fieldwork is complete before theirs begins. The anthropologists arrive to study a people that has already studied them, and their research question has already been answered by the community's plan.

Paul Rabinow's account of his fieldwork in Morocco had already dismantled the image of the informant as a passive source of data (Rabinow 1977). His informants, he found, interpreted him, managed his access, pur-

sued their own purposes through him, and constructed the anthropologist even as he constructed them; fieldwork was a negotiation between parties each of whom was using the other. Pelle is the informant as manager carried to its limit. He selects the anthropologists, delivers them to the field, translates the community's customs into terms they can accept, and supervises their progress toward the fire. The informant has become the principal investigator, and the investigators have become his subjects.

◉

7·3

Reading over the Shoulder

Malinowski, Geertz, and the Forbidden Text

Bronislaw Malinowski defined the goal of ethnography as grasping the native's point of view, his relation to life, and his vision of his world, and he promised that the fieldworker's long immersion would yield it (Malinowski 1922). Clifford Geertz, half a century later, recast the ambition in semiotic terms. Culture, he argued, is an ensemble of texts, and the ethnographer's task is thick description, the interpretation of symbolic action in its full context; the anthropologist reads those texts, in a phrase that became famous, over the shoulders of those to whom they properly belong (Geertz 1973). Geertz's best-known essay opens with an account of how he and his wife came to be accepted by a Balinese village. During a police raid on an illegal cockfight, they fled with the villagers instead of standing on their status as foreign guests, and their complicity in the flight earned them a trust that months of polite presence had not.

Midsommar literalizes both images. Josh's attempt to photograph the *Rubi Radr* is reading over the shoulder made physical: he enters the temple at night, alone, to copy a text that its owners have explicitly withheld from him, and he is killed for it. Geertz's complicity, the shared flight that turns an observer into a participant, finds its extreme form in Dani's choice. Her acceptance by the commune is completed not by polite presence, nor even by her victory in the dance, but by her participation in its violence, the choice of the ninth offering. The film takes the ethnographic doctrine that understanding requires participation to its terminal conclusion: full understanding requires full complicity.

The crisis of ethnographic authority that James Clifford and others diagnosed in the 1980s turned on the question of who has the right to represent whom (Clifford 1983; Clifford and Marcus 1986). Ethnography, they argued, is a form of writing, and its authority rests on rhetorical conventions that efface the voices of the people described. *Midsommar* stages the crisis and resolves it against the ethnographers. The Hårga possess their own scripture; they control its reproduction; they set the conditions on which the visitors may write about them; and they have already painted the visitors' story in the panorama with which the film begins (§3.3). The writers are written. The anthropologists' theses are never composed, while the community's account of the anthropologists is completed in fire.

The posthumous publication of Malinowski's field diary in 1967 had already exposed what the discipline's public writing concealed: the loneliness, irritation, desire, and contempt that accompanied the patient observation celebrated in *Argonauts* (Malinowski 1967). The diary revealed an ethnographer whose private motives bore little resemblance to his published method. *Midsommar*'s anthropologists wear their private motives openly. Christian wants a topic, Josh wants a dissertation, Mark wants sex and drugs, and none of them, until it is too late, wants to understand what the Hårga intend to do with them. The film reads the discipline through its diary rather than its monographs, and it lets the community read the diary as well.

The discipline's colonial history, which Talal Asad and his collaborators examined in *Anthropology and the Colonial Encounter* (Asad 1973), gives the reversal a further edge. Classical anthropology typically sent scholars from imperial centers to study colonized peoples. *Midsommar* sends a Black American scholar to study a white Scandinavian people, and then reverses the reversal of the discipline's habitual geometry: Josh, who came to make the commune an object of knowledge, ends as an object in its garden, his leg planted in a flowerbed with a rune cut into its sole. The tradition of Black American anthropology that runs from Zora Neale Hurston's fieldwork in the American South (Hurston 1935) has always known the doubleness of an observer who is also observed. The film turns that doubleness into a fatal trap.

7.4

The Aura and the Camera

Benjamin's Rubi Radr

Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility defined the aura of a work as the unique appearance of a distance, however near the object may be, and grounded it in the work's original place in ritual (Benjamin [1936] 1968). The earliest artworks served cults, and their cult value required concealment more than display: certain statues of the gods were accessible only to the priest in the inner sanctuary, Benjamin observed, and certain images of the Madonna remained veiled for most of the year. Technological reproduction, above all photography, replaces cult value with exhibition value. It detaches the work from its place in tradition, multiplies it, brings it close to the viewer, and destroys its aura. Benjamin also credited the camera with a power of exposure: it reveals an optical unconscious, details the naked eye passes over, and makes them available to analysis.

The *Rubi Radr* is an object of pure cult value. It is kept in the temple, read only by the elders, extended continually by the oracle, and protected by an explicit prohibition on photography. Josh's phone is the instrument of exhibition value and of the optical unconscious: the device that would detach the scripture from its cult, reproduce it, expose its details to scholarly analysis, and carry it into the archive of a dissertation, where it would become data. The conflict between them is Benjamin's conflict between cult and exhibition, staged as a killing. The Hårga kill to preserve the aura of their text, to keep it at the distance that makes it sacred, however near the ethnographer comes.

The irony is that the film is itself a technologically reproduced work, distributed in thousands of copies, streamed, and endlessly captured in still frames by the culture of decoding described in §3.3. *Midsommar* manufactures aura in the medium that, for Benjamin, destroyed it. It presents its invented scripture, its murals, and its rites with the solemnity of cult objects, and it offers them to an audience that consumes them as exhibition. At the level of its own circulation, the film restages the conflict that

kills Josh: its images invite at once the reverent reading of the elder and the reproductive gaze of the camera.

Benjamin's earlier "Critique of Violence" supplies a name for the force that guards the aura (Benjamin [1921] 1978). He distinguished mythic violence, which founds and preserves law and demands sacrifice, from divine violence, which annihilates law and which he described, in a notoriously difficult formulation, as bloodless and expiatory. His example of mythic violence was the punishment of Niobe, whose children Apollo and Artemis killed because she had boasted of them, and who was turned into a stone that weeps forever. The Hårga's violence is mythic in Benjamin's sense. It founds and preserves the law of the circle and demands sacrifice, and like the arrows of Apollo it falls on those who have offended the community's sacred order: the man who urinated on the ancestral tree, the scholar who photographed the scripture. The aura of the *Rubi Radr* is protected by the same violence that sustains the commune's law.

◉

7.5

The Oracle

Delphi, Plato, and the Interpreters of Unreason

The Hårga's scripture is oracular, and the ancient world's most famous oracle supplies its model. Heraclitus, in the fragment that stands at the head of this chapter, wrote that the lord whose oracle is at Delphi neither speaks nor conceals but gives a sign (Diels and Kranz 1951–52, fr. 93). The Delphic oracle was a collaboration between inspiration and interpretation. The Pythia, the priestess on the tripod, spoke in a state of divine possession, and her utterances were rendered into intelligible responses by the sanctuary's officials. Some geologists have argued that her trance may have been induced by hydrocarbon gases rising through faults beneath the temple (de Boer, Hale, and Chanton 2001); if so, the oracle of Apollo was, like the Hårga's rites, an intoxication administered by an institution. Plato held in the *Phaedrus* that some of the greatest blessings come to human beings through madness, when it is sent as a gift of the gods, and that the prophetesses of Delphi and Dodona had done much good to Greece when mad and little or none when in their right minds. In the *Timaeus*

he drew the consequence. The inspired diviner, possessed and out of his mind, cannot judge his own visions; that task belongs to interpreters, who are properly called not prophets but expounders of riddling utterance and vision (Plato 1997, *Phaedrus* 244a–b; *Timaeus* 71e–72b).

The *Rubi Radr* institutionalizes Plato's division of labor. Ruben, bred, on the community's account, to be unclouded by ordinary cognition, is the inspired diviner; the elders are the interpreters, and the power is theirs. Ruben's marks, like the Pythia's cries, mean nothing until the elders say what they mean, and what they say determines what the community does. Benjamin, in his essay on the mimetic faculty, recalled a line of Hofmannsthal's describing the oldest form of reading: to read what was never written, as the ancients read entrails, stars, and dances before there were letters (Benjamin [1933] 1978). The elders read what was never written. Their hermeneutics is not the decoding of a message but the production of one, and the scripture they read is, in the sense of Chapter Two, an archive that produces the events it records.

The oracle's characteristic structure is the self-fulfilling prophecy, and its characteristic victims are those who misread it. Herodotus tells how Croesus, king of Lydia, asked Delphi whether he should make war on Persia and was told that if he did he would destroy a great empire; he attacked, and the empire he destroyed was his own (Herodotus 1920, 1.53, 1.91). Robert Merton gave the structure its sociological name: a self-fulfilling prophecy is a false definition of a situation that evokes behavior which makes it come true (Merton 1948). The *Rubi Radr*'s prophecies are self-fulfilling in a stricter sense than Merton's. They are not false definitions that come true by accident but plans written as prophecies, which the community fulfills by carrying them out. The visitors, like Croesus, misread the signs. They take the murals for folklore and the scripture for literature, and they discover too late that what they took for representation was instruction.

7.6

The Seer's Wound

Incest, Disability, and the Sacred

The ancient seer pays for vision with the body. Teiresias, the blind prophet of Thebes, received his gift of prophecy as compensation for his blindness; Odin, as Chapter Two recalled, pledged an eye at Mímir's well for wisdom. The seer's wound is the visible sign of his access to what others cannot see. The Hårga's oracle is wounded in a different way. Ruben is the deliberate product of incest, bred so that his mind will be, in the commune's account, unclouded, and his disability is treated by the community as the condition of his sanctity.

Sophocles' *Oedipus Tyrannus*, the founding drama of investigative knowledge, joins the two figures that the film merges. Oedipus, the solver of riddles, conducts an inquiry into the pollution of Thebes and discovers that he is himself its cause, the man who killed his father and married his mother; Teiresias, the blind seer, knew the truth all along (Sophocles 1994). In Sophocles the incestuous union produces the curse, and the blind seer reveals it. In the Hårga the incestuous union produces the seer. The commune has made Oedipus's crime into a method and Teiresias's affliction into a product, and what tragedy treated as the deepest pollution it treats as the source of sacred knowledge.

Claude Lévi-Strauss argued that the prohibition of incest is the threshold at which nature passes into culture: by forbidding marriage within the group, it obliges the group to exchange with others, and from that exchange the alliances that constitute society are born (Lévi-Strauss [1949] 1969). The Hårga occupy both sides of the threshold at once. Toward the outside they practice an exogamy of their own kind, importing strangers for their new blood, as when Christian is joined to Maja. Toward the sacred center they suspend the prohibition and breed the oracle within the group, placing their source of revelation beyond the line on which culture is founded. The commune's knowledge comes from the place where culture has not yet begun, and its social renewal depends on alliances with strangers whom it then destroys.

The figure of Ruben raises an ethical question about the film itself. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson traced how American culture has used extraordinary bodies as screens for its own anxieties and fantasies, from the freak show to the sentimental novel (Garland-Thomson 1997), and David Mitchell and Sharon Snyder named narrative prosthesis the pervasive literary practice of using disability as a metaphor or device that props up a story's meaning while the disabled character remains a sign rather than a subject (Mitchell and Snyder 2000). The Hårga's use of Ruben is narrative prosthesis practiced as religion: they turn a disabled person into the source of their scripture, and they speak for him. The film's own use of Ruben is harder to judge. It presents him almost entirely through the commune's interpretation, as an object of reverence and dread, and gives him no perspective of his own. In doing so it reproduces, perhaps deliberately, the instrumentalization it depicts. The oracle has no voice in the film except the one the elders lend him, and the spectator learns about him only what they say.

7·7

The Old Gods Rise

Weber and the Sacrifice of the Intellect

Max Weber's lecture "Science as a Vocation," delivered in Munich in 1917 and published two years later, is the classic statement of the scholar's ethic in a disenchanted world, and it reads in retrospect like a commentary on the fate of *Midsommar*'s visitors (Weber [1919] 1946). The progress of science, Weber told his audience, had disenchanted the world: there are, in principle, no mysterious incalculable forces at work, and all things can be mastered by calculation. The scholar's vocation in such a world is specialized, provisional, and austere. It demands intellectual integrity, the refusal to pass off personal values as scientific findings, and the renunciation of the prophet's role at the lectern. Weber knew that many of his listeners longed for more than science could give: for meaning, for community, for a faith that would tell them how to live. To those who could not bear the fate of the age, he said, the arms of the old churches stand open; but the

price of entering them is the sacrifice of the intellect, which the religious virtuoso makes and the scholar may not.

Weber also offered an image of what the disenchanted world would become. The many gods of old, he said, rise from their graves, but disenchanted, in the form of impersonal powers, and resume their eternal struggle for power over our lives. The Hårga are those gods. Their religion, as Chapter Two observed, names no deity; its object is the impersonal power of the circle, the community's own continuity. They are the old gods risen in exactly the form Weber predicted, as forces without faces, and they offer the comfort of the old churches at the price he named.

The film's body count literalizes the price. Every visitor who keeps the stance of the disenchanted mind dies. Josh, the specialist, who maintains his professional distance and seeks to document what he studies, dies for his documentation. Christian, the careerist, who treats the commune as an opportunity, dies in the commune's rite. Simon and Connie, who judge what they have seen and try to leave, die for their judgment. Mark, who mocks, dies for his mockery. The only visitor who survives is the one who makes the sacrifice of the intellect: Dani, who suspends her judgment, enters the community's meanings, and accepts its account of what she sees. Weber's metaphor names the believer's renunciation of critical reason; the Hårga perform it on bodies. The intellect is sacrificed not in the mind of the convert but in the persons of the skeptics.

Weber closed his lecture with a gendered injunction that the film quietly overturns. Those who cannot bear the fate of the times, he said, should return to the old churches silently, without the self-advertisement of the convert; those who can should bear it like men and do the work of the day. Dani does not bear the fate of the times. She returns to an old church that is in fact an invented one, and she does not return silently. She returns crowned, at the center of a chorus, smiling. The film does not tell us whether this is the defeat of the intellect or its transcendence. It shows what the intellect costs, and who pays.

7.8

The Positioned Subject

Grief and the Only Ethnographer Who Understood

Chapter Five recalled how Renato Rosaldo came to understand the Ilongot account of grief's rage only after his wife's death, and how he concluded that the ethnographer is a positioned subject, able to grasp certain human experiences only from within the position of having lived them (Rosaldo 1989). *Midsommar* turns Rosaldo's insight into plot. The anthropologists, unpositioned, approach the Hårga's rites as data. They watch the cliff, note the custom, defend it as culture, and plan their theses. They cannot understand what the rites are for, because they have no need of what the rites provide. Dani, the one visitor without an academic purpose, understands at once, because she is bereaved. The chorus that answers her wail is unintelligible to a scholar and self-evident to a mourner.

Dani is therefore the film's true ethnographer. She achieves Malinowski's goal of grasping the native's point of view more completely than any professional could, and she achieves it by the means the discipline has always feared: she goes native. Her understanding is total because it is not knowledge but belonging. Here the film's critique of ethnography turns back upon its heroine. The understanding Dani attains is not empathy in Edith Stein's sense, the apprehension of another's experience as another's (§5.3); it is identification, the dissolution of the distance in which another's experience could be known as other. She comprehends the Hårga by becoming one of them, and from inside the community she can no longer see what it does to those outside.

Geertz offered a more modest model of ethnographic understanding in his essay on the native's point of view (Geertz 1983). The ethnographer, he argued, does not and cannot perceive what informants perceive, and need not try; understanding comes instead from tacking continually between experience-near concepts, the terms in which people describe their own lives, and experience-distant concepts, the terms in which an observer places those lives in a wider frame, a distinction he borrowed from the psychoanalyst Heinz Kohut. The visitors fail at both ends of Geertz's movement. The anthropologists possess only experience-distant

concepts—custom, ritual, culture, thesis—and never reach the experience the rites organize. Dani acquires the experience-near completely and loses the experience-distant altogether: she lives the Hårga's meanings from within and can no longer describe them from without.

The film thus poses the oldest dilemma of anthropological knowledge in its most extreme form. Distance is the condition of seeing the other as other, and therefore of seeing the costs of the other's practices; but distance also prevents understanding, and in the Hårga's world it is punished by death. Participation is the condition of understanding; but complete participation abolishes the standpoint from which judgment is possible. Plessner's tact (§5.7), the capacity to approach without fusing, names the virtue that would hold the two in balance. None of the visitors possesses it. The anthropologists have distance without understanding, and Dani has understanding without distance.

◉

7.9

Ethnographic Horror

Cannibal Holocaust, The Ritual, and the Forbidden Book

Midsommar belongs to a genre that might be called ethnographic horror, in which outsiders who come to observe a people become its victims, and the genre has always turned on the question of who the savages are. Ruggero Deodato's *Cannibal Holocaust* (1980) follows an anthropologist into the Amazon to recover the footage left by a documentary crew that disappeared there; the footage reveals that the filmmakers had terrorized, raped, and killed the people they came to film before they were killed in turn, and the anthropologist, leaving the screening, wonders aloud who the real cannibals are. David Bruckner's *The Ritual* (2017), released two years before *Midsommar*, sent a group of British friends hiking through the forests of northern Sweden, where they fall into the power of a pagan cult that worships a monstrous offspring of Loki. *Midsommar*'s visitors are neither the atrocious filmmakers of Deodato's film nor the hapless hikers of Bruckner's. They are scholars, guests, and partners, and the film's satire falls on their curiosity rather than their cruelty.

The Wicker Man supplies the genre's purest model of investigation as bait. Sergeant Howie comes to Summerisle in answer to an anonymous letter reporting a missing girl, and he conducts his inquiry with the diligence of the law, interviewing, searching, consulting records. Only at the end does he learn that the letter was sent by the islanders themselves, that the missing girl was never missing, and that his investigation was the means by which the island drew to itself the victim it needed. His inquiry was staged by its object. The Hårga do the same to their anthropologists. The invitation that brings them is addressed to their scholarly interest; the festival they come to study has been arranged with their arrival in view; and their research, like Howie's investigation, is the route by which they are delivered to the fire.

The genre's deepest root is the literature of the forbidden book. H. P. Lovecraft built a mythology on scholars who read what they should not: professors of Miskatonic University, antiquarians, and heirs who piece together documents until the pattern they reveal destroys them. "The Call of Cthulhu" opens with the reflection that stands at the head of this chapter, that the most merciful thing in the world is the human mind's inability to correlate all its contents, and it warns that the piecing together of dissociated knowledge will one day open such vistas that humanity will either go mad or "flee from the deadly light into the peace and safety of a new dark age" (Lovecraft 1928). Lovecraft's light is deadly, as the Hårga's is (§3.2). His grimoire, the *Necronomicon*, destroys those who read it; the *Rubi Radr* kills the one who tries to copy it. Josh is a Lovecraftian scholar in an Apollonian world, trying to correlate the contents of a scripture in the full light of day.

Midsommar adds a twist that Lovecraft's fiction anticipated only in "The Shadow over Innsmouth," to which Chapter Eight returns. In the conventional plot of the forbidden book, knowledge destroys the knower. In *Midsommar* it destroys the knower who keeps his distance and rewards the knower who surrenders it. The scholar who tries to read the community's book dies; the mourner who lets the community read her lives, and is crowned.

7.10

The Scholar's Capital

Bourdieu and the Economy of the Thesis

The quarrel between Josh and Christian over the right to write about the Hårga is the film's sharpest satire, and Pierre Bourdieu's sociology of the university explains why it belongs in a horror film. In *Homo Academicus*, Bourdieu described the academic world as a field: a space of competition in which agents struggle for specific forms of capital—intellectual reputation, institutional power, the recognition of peers—and in which the choice of an object of research is itself a strategic move, an investment whose return is measured in the currency of the field (Bourdieu [1984] 1988). The dissertation topic is capital. Josh has invested years in his, and Christian, who has accumulated none, appropriates it in a single conversation, converting another man's labor into his own prospective credit. The appropriation is the academic form of the betrayal for which Christian will be burned. He takes what is not his because it is available and he is drifting, as he will himself be taken by the commune because he is available and drifting.

The Hårga understand this economy perfectly and exploit it. Their invitation is addressed to the visitors' scholarly interest; a festival held once in ninety years is an object of irresistible value in an economy of academic distinction; and the elders' permission to study it, granted on condition of anonymity, binds the students into the community's control of its own representation. The visitors' ambition is the bait. Bataille's distinction between restricted and general economies (§4.5) applies here too. The academy is a restricted economy of knowledge, in which observations are accumulated, converted into publications, and capitalized as careers. The Hårga's economy of knowledge is general: their scripture is not accumulated but continually produced and consumed in ritual, and the knowledge that counts in their world is spent in the rite rather than banked in an archive. Josh dies trying to transfer the community's sacred knowledge from the general economy into the restricted one, to turn the *Rubi Radr* into data. Christian dies having tried to turn the community itself into his thesis.

The satire of the academic field also reaches the profession of interpretation to which this dissertation belongs. A doctoral thesis on *Midsommar* is a thesis on the Hårga, and the film's verdict on theses about the Hårga is unambiguous. The parallel is instructive rather than merely amusing. Bourdieu insisted that the sociologist of the academic field must turn his instruments upon himself, objectifying the position from which he objectifies others, and the same reflexivity is owed to the film. Every interpretation of *Midsommar*, this one included, is a move in a field of readings, an investment in a particular account of the smile, and every such account converts the film's ambiguity into its interpreter's capital. The elders' condition of anonymity, the injunction to omit the names and the place, may be read as the film's warning to its interpreters: the meaning of the Hårga cannot be extracted from them without loss, and any reading that claims to possess it entire has already begun to imitate the anthropologists. The most this dissertation can do is to declare its position, as Rosaldo urged, and to count the costs of its readings, as §1.4 promised.

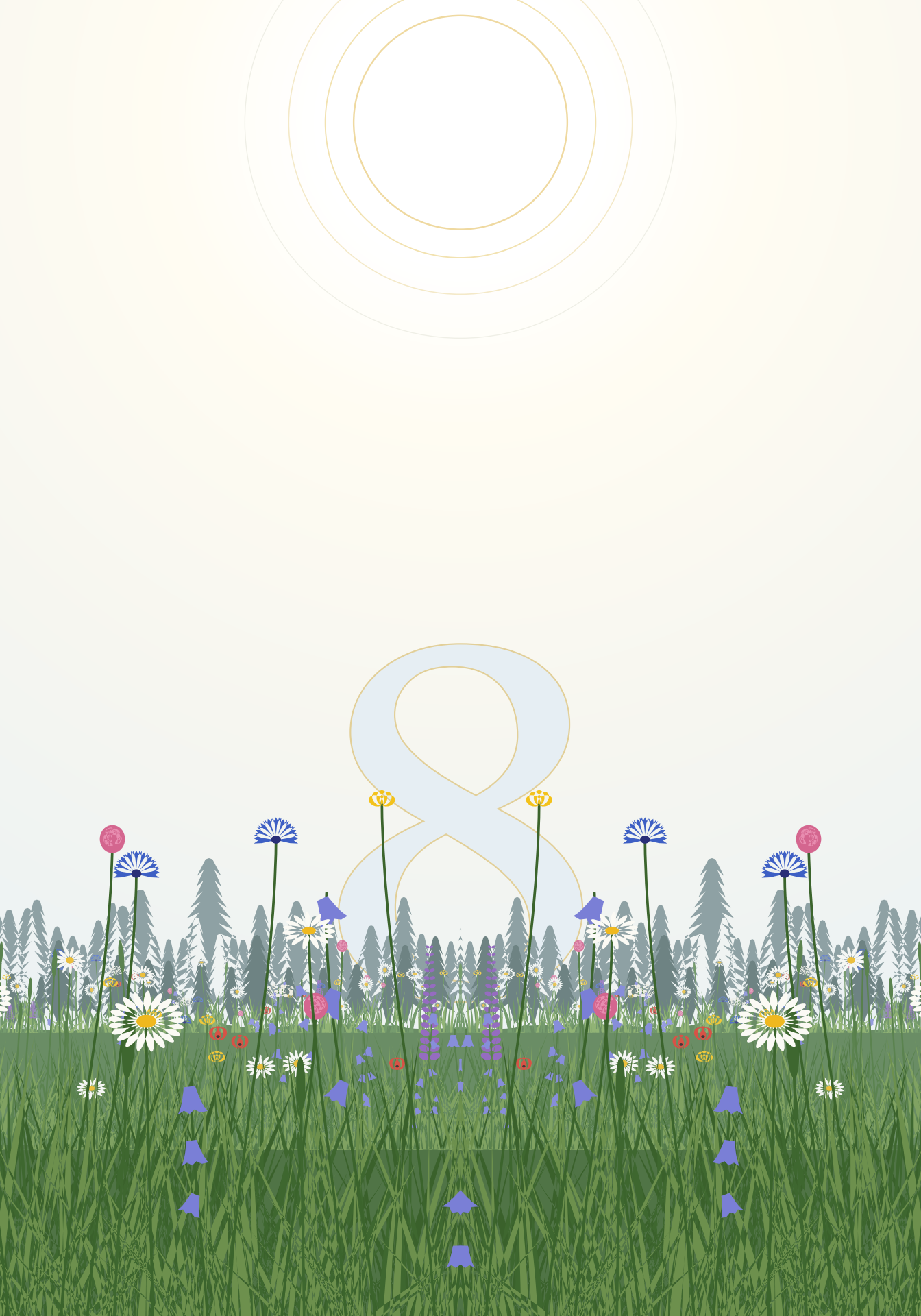
7.11

Conclusion

The Spectator as Elder

The fate of the film's ethnographers leaves its spectators in an uncomfortable position, because the spectators are interpreters too. The culture of decoding that grew up around *Midsommar*, with its inventories of runes, murals, and numbers (§3.3), is a culture of reading like an elder: of treating the film as an oracular text whose every sign was placed by a designing intelligence and whose meaning can be extracted by patient interpretation. The film rewards this reading. Its signs are real, its prophecies come true, and its patterns hold. But to read the film entirely as the elders read the *Rubi Radr*—to accept that everything signifies and that the signs foretell what must happen—is to adopt the community's hermeneutics, and so to make, in the act of interpretation, a small version of the sacrifice of the intellect that Dani makes in the act of belonging. The opposite stance, the skeptic's refusal to read the signs, is Josh's error in another form: the refusal to see what the film plainly shows.

This dissertation has tried, since §1.4, to practice a third hermeneutics, which it called sacrificial: to read the film's patterns as real while asking at every turn what each pattern costs and who is made to bear the cost. It is the reading the anthropologists never attempted and Dani could no longer perform. It holds the elder's attention to signs together with the scholar's attention to persons, and it refuses both the oracle's plenitude and the skeptic's blindness. The final chapter applies it to the film's last and most oracular sign, the smile, and to the melancholy the smile appears to cure.



CHAPTER EIGHT

The White Sun

Toward a Theory of the Sacrificial Holding Environment

Bei der Trauer ist die Welt arm und leer geworden, bei der Melancholie ist es das Ich selbst.

— Sigmund Freud, "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917)

τοιόνδ' ὄχημα πατρὸς Ἥλιος πατὴρ
δίδωσιν ἡμῖν, ἕρυμα πολεμίας χερός.

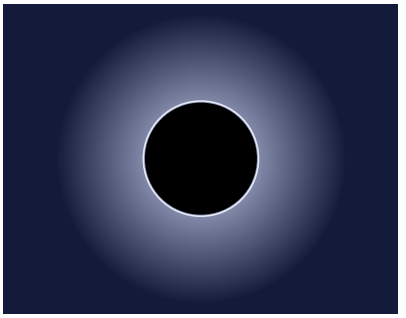
— Euripides, *Medea* 1321–22

8.1

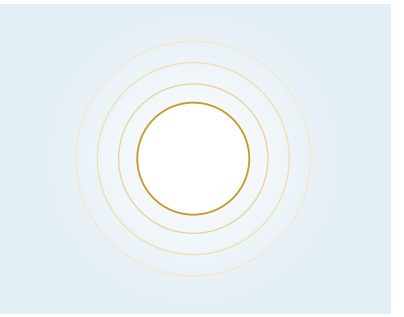
The Black Sun and the White

Nerval, Dürer, Kristeva

The second epigraph of this dissertation comes from Gérard de Nerval's sonnet "El Desdichado" (1854), in which the disinherited poet, his only star dead, bears on his constellated lute the black sun of melancholy (Nerval 1854). The image descends from a long iconography of melancholy, whose most famous instance is Albrecht Dürer's engraving *Melencolia I* (1514): a winged figure sits brooding among abandoned instruments of measurement and craft, while over a distant sea a comet or dark star radiates beneath a rainbow and a bat-winged creature bears the title. The black sun is a light that does not illuminate, a radiance of darkness, the shining of a loss that will not let itself be mourned. Julia Kristeva took Nerval's line for the title of her study of depression and melancholia (Kristeva [1987] 1989). The depressed, she argued, are bound



THE BLACK SUN
a light that does not illuminate



THE WHITE SUN
mourning deprived of its night

BLACK SUN, WHITE SUN Melancholy not as darkness but as unbearable light.

to a loss they cannot name, an archaic Thing anterior to any object of desire, and their grief is an impossible mourning: a sorrow that has failed to pass into language and so remains a dark sun at the center of the self, around which speech slows, empties, and falls silent.

Midsommar begins under the black sun. Its prologue is set in winter darkness, and its heroine is a depressed young woman who has lost her family to her sister's illness and can find no words for the loss, only a wail. The film's journey carries her from the black sun to its opposite. In Hälsingland the sun scarcely sets and the night never comes, and the melancholy of the prologue is not cured but inverted. The white sun of this dissertation's title names that inversion: melancholy not as darkness but as unbearable light, mourning deprived of its night. The festival offers the bereaved woman not the slow work of grief, which needs darkness, solitude, and time, but a perpetual noon in which grief is instantly expressed, collectively amplified, and converted within days into exultation.

The literature of the north had long known the white night as a season of melancholy rather than its cure. In Dostoevsky's *White Nights* (1848), a lonely dreamer wandering the luminous summer nights of Saint Petersburg meets a young woman who confides in him for four nights and loses her when her absent lover returns, left with the memory of a single moment of happiness (Dostoevsky [1848] 1918). In Knut Hamsun's *Pan* (1894), a solitary lieutenant living in a hut at the edge of the Nordland forest passes a summer of sleepless light in an ecstasy of nature that tips into erotic obsession and cruelty, and his story ends in death (Hamsun [1894] 1998). In

both, the light that never fails exposes the solitary rather than consoling him. The Hårga reverse the tradition. Their white night is not the setting of a lonely man's brief happiness but the instrument of a community's total embrace, and its light does not expose the bereaved woman. It holds her.

The argument of this concluding chapter is that the conversion of grief into exultation is not the completion of mourning but its manic reversal. Psychoanalytic theory from Freud to Klein, and from Karl Abraham to Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok, distinguished the mourning that slowly accepts the loss of an object from the melancholia that refuses it, and it recognized that melancholia can turn, in mania, into triumph. The final smile of *Midsommar* is such a triumph. It is the white sun of melancholy: a mourning spared its night, which therefore never takes place, and is replaced by a joy whose radiance is the light of a fire. The chapter reads the smile through this theory, places it in the lineage of horror's euphoric recognitions, measures it against Nietzsche's affirmation of the circle, and returns at last to the spectator, whose smile the film solicits, and to the middle term the film withholds.



8.2

Mourning and Melancholia

The Shadow of the Object

Freud's essay of 1917 drew the distinction on which the analysis turns (Freud [1917] 1957). Mourning and melancholia share most of their features: profound dejection, withdrawal of interest from the world, loss of the capacity to love, inhibition of activity. Melancholia adds one more, a lowering of self-regard that expresses itself in self-reproach and the expectation of punishment. In mourning, Freud wrote in the sentence that heads this chapter, it is the world that has become poor and empty; in melancholia it is the ego itself. Mourning is work. Reality shows the bereaved that the loved object no longer exists, and the libido must be withdrawn from it piece by piece, each memory and expectation recalled and detached, in a labor carried out slowly, at great expense of time and energy, during which the object's existence is psychically prolonged. Melancholia

refuses the work. The libido withdrawn from the lost object is not displaced onto a new one but drawn back into the ego, where it sets up an identification with what was lost. "Der Schatten des Objekts fiel so auf das Ich": the shadow of the object fell upon the ego, and the melancholic's self-reproaches are reproaches against the lost object turned back upon the self.

Melancholia arises above all, Freud added, where the relation to the lost object was ambivalent, a mixture of love and hate. Dani's grief is ambivalent to the core. Her sister, whom she loved and worried over, is also the killer of her parents; the message that announced Terri's intention was at once a farewell and a threat; and the film's prologue shows Dani's exhaustion with her sister's crises alongside her love. The object she mourns is also an object she has reason to hate, and her grief accordingly takes melancholic form. Throughout the American half of the film she reproaches herself: she apologizes for her needs, fears that she is too much, and treats her own suffering as a burden on others. The shadow of the object has fallen upon her ego. Her relation to Christian repeats the structure. He is loved and resented, depended upon and disappointing, and by the time of the festival he has become a second ambivalent object, whose loss she both fears and desires.

The American world's response to Dani's grief, so far as the film shows it, is pharmacological and diagnostic: she takes medication, the people around her speak of therapy, and her suffering is treated as a condition to be managed. Contemporary psychiatry has since given grief a diagnosis of its own. In 2022 the American Psychiatric Association added prolonged grief disorder to the revised fifth edition of its diagnostic manual, classifying as a mental disorder a grief that remains intense and impairing long after a loss (American Psychiatric Association 2022). Whatever its clinical merits, the diagnosis completes the privatization of mourning described in Chapter One: grief that will not end becomes an illness of the individual rather than an occasion for the community. The Hårga offer the opposite, a grief that is never the individual's alone and that is ended, collectively, within days. Between the diagnosis and the festival, the film shows no place in which mourning could simply take its time.

Freud also observed that melancholia tends to turn into its opposite. In mania, the ego, having mastered the loss or thrust it aside, celebrates its liberation from the object that caused its suffering. The energy bound up in

the melancholic struggle is suddenly released, and the manic subject seeks new objects on which to spend it, in Freud's image, like a ravenously hungry man. The Hårga's festival is mania institutionalized: feasting, dancing, ecstatic license, collective exultation. And Dani's finale is the turn of melancholia into manic triumph. Freed at a stroke from both ambivalent objects, since the sister's crime is answered by a family that kills in daylight and the partner is given to the fire, she seizes the new objects the community offers, its sisters, its crown, its circle, with the hunger Freud described. Her smile is not the end of mourning, which never took place, but the manic reversal of the melancholia that had replaced it.

◉

8.3

The Manic Defense

Klein, Segal, and the Counterfeit of Reparation

Melanie Klein rewrote Freud's distinction in the terms of her developmental theory (Klein 1940). Every loss in adult life, she argued, reactivates the infant's depressive position, the early anxiety that one's own hatred has damaged or destroyed the loved object on which one depends. Normal mourning therefore involves rebuilding the inner world: reinstating the lost person within, together with the good objects of early life, and tolerating the guilt and sorrow that come with the recognition of one's own ambivalence. Against the pain of this work the mind deploys manic defenses, which deny dependence on the object and the reality of its loss. Hanna Segal summarized them as a triad of control, triumph, and contempt (Segal 1964). The manic subject controls the object so as not to need it, triumphs over it so as not to mourn it, and despises it so as not to miss it. Klein observed, too, that even normal mourning contains moments of triumph over the dead, and that the guilt such triumph provokes is among the obstacles mourning must overcome.

Klein distinguished genuine reparation, the effort to restore a damaged object, which is born of love and guilt and accepts both the object's separateness and the reality of the harm done, from its manic counterfeit, which repairs omnipotently, without guilt, and with a secret contempt for what it repairs. Chapter One promised that this distinction would decide

the meaning of the smile, and it can now be applied. The finale of *Midsommar* enacts Segal's triad with almost clinical exactness. Control: Dani chooses the ninth offering, deciding the fate of the man on whom she had depended. Triumph: crowned and enthroned, she presides over his death amid acclamation. Contempt: the man is sewn into the carcass of an animal and burned, his body made into a thing. The repair that follows is manic in Klein's precise sense. Dani's inner world is restored, a family recovered, a home found, a self held, but the restoration is achieved by destroying an external object, without guilt, and with so complete a denial of the damage that the burning can be experienced as joy.

The Hårga make this counterfeit possible because, as Chapter Four argued, they are a community without remorse. Klein's depressive position requires guilt: the capacity to recognize that one has harmed what one loves, and to grieve the harm. The Hårga have abolished guilt by abolishing its occasions. Their elders consent to their own deaths, their victims are strangers, and their violence is scheduled, sanctified, and shared. In such a community the depressive position cannot be reached, because its threshold, the experience of guilt toward a loved and damaged object, has been ritually removed. What remains is the manic position held permanently open: triumph without guilt, reparation without mourning.

The film shows the moment at which Dani crosses into it. Her face in the final shot passes first through horror and grief, the beginnings of the depressive pain that genuine mourning would require, and only then does the smile arrive. Klein would read the sequence exactly: the depressive position glimpsed and abandoned, the manic defense installed in its place. The order matters. The film does not show a woman incapable of grief. It shows a woman who begins to grieve, for the man in the bear and perhaps for everything the bear contains, and who is offered, at that instant, a way not to. The smile is the acceptance of the offer.

8.4

Mouths Without Words

Abraham, Torok, and the Crypt of the Chorus

Karl Abraham, Freud's closest collaborator on the theory of melancholia, found in his melancholic patients fantasies of devouring the lost object, an oral incorporation that preserves what it destroys by taking it bodily inside (Abraham [1924] 1927). Half a century later Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok refined the insight into a distinction between introjection and incorporation (Abraham and Torok [1987] 1994). Introjection is the process by which the self grows by taking in what it has lost, and its model is language. The infant learns to fill the emptiness of its mouth, once filled by the mother's breast, with words, and the work of mourning repeats that achievement: a loss is gradually put into words and thereby assimilated. Incorporation is introjection's failure. When a loss cannot be spoken, the self swallows the lost object whole, in fantasy, and preserves it intact in a psychic crypt, where it is neither mourned nor forgotten. Incorporation fills the mouth not with words but with the object itself.

The Hårga's chorus is a technology of incorporation. Its mourning is wordless (§5.2): the women's mouths are filled not with the language of lament, its memories, accusations, and narratives, but with the cry itself, repeated and amplified. The community's mouths are full in a second sense as well. Its rites are feasts, its love magic works through food and drink, and its festival consumes, in every sense of the word. Dani's loss is never put into words among the Hårga. It is swallowed into the communal body, and Dani is swallowed with it.

The crypt that Abraham and Torok located inside the melancholic self is thereby turned inside out. The bereaved woman is entombed alive within the community's body, and her grief, never spoken and so never introjected, is sealed in a radiant tomb of flowers. The flower gown, which the film shows breathing (§3.6), is the crypt made visible: a living enclosure in which the loss is preserved by being buried together with the self that suffered it. The question that introjection would have required, what exactly was lost, and what can be said about it, is never asked. The film's American half, in which Dani could not speak her grief to a partner who would not

listen, and its Swedish half, in which she need not speak it because the chorus answers without words, lead to the same result. In neither world is the loss put into language, and in neither, therefore, can it be mourned.

8.5

Euphoric Anagnorisis

Innsmouth, Rosemary, Thomasin, and the Crowned

Chapter One defined euphoric anagnorisis as the inversion of tragic recognition: a passage from ignorance to knowledge that issues not in pity and fear but in joy, as the protagonist recognizes what the community is and embraces it. The structure has a lineage in modern horror, and the lineage clarifies what *Midsommar* adds to it.

Its founding text is H. P. Lovecraft's "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1936). Lovecraft's narrator, a young antiquarian touring New England, visits the decaying seaport of Innsmouth, discovers that its people have interbred with amphibious beings from the sea, and flees in terror. Then, tracing his own genealogy, he learns that he descends from an Innsmouth family, and as the signs of the change appear in his body his horror turns to longing. The story ends with his resolve to return to the sea and to dwell in glory in the undersea city of his ancestors (Lovecraft 1936). The investigation ends in a homecoming. Lovecraft's tale is also, as critics have long observed, a fantasy of racial contamination, and its euphoric ending is haunted by the fear it inverts. *Midsommar*'s commune is Innsmouth's mirror image: a community of uniform whiteness that imports outsiders for their blood and then kills them, whose new member is not a descendant discovering her lineage but a stranger adopted into it.

Roman Polanski's *Rosemary's Baby* (1968), adapted from Ira Levin's novel (Levin 1967), supplies the domestic form of the structure. Rosemary Woodhouse, betrayed by a husband who has traded her body to a coven of neighbors in exchange for his career, gives birth to the son of Satan. She enters the coven's apartment armed with a knife, finds the cradle, and is urged to be a mother to her child; in the final scene she begins, slowly, to rock it. Horror turns to acceptance through a bond the community has engineered. Robert Eggers's *The Witch* (2015) gives the structure its most

ecstatic image before *Midsommar*. Thomasin, whose Puritan family has been destroyed by the forest's power and by its own suspicion of her, signs the book offered by the goat Black Phillip, walks naked into the woods, and finds a coven dancing around a fire. As the witches rise into the air, Thomasin rises with them, laughing. A young woman whose family has died, a fire, a female collective, an ascent, a face transfigured by joy: the last scene of *The Witch* is the nearest precedent for the last minutes of *Midsommar*.

Aster's own *Hereditary* (2018) and Ben Wheatley's *Kill List* (2011) supply the coronations. In *Hereditary*, a son whose family has been destroyed by a cult is crowned as the vessel of a demon king before a kneeling congregation (§6.9). In *Kill List*, a hitman who has unknowingly killed his own wife and child in a ritual combat is crowned by the cult that arranged it, amid applause. In both, the crowned figure is the instrument of a design, and the crown follows the destruction of a family. *Midsommar* combines these strands—the investigator's homecoming, the betrayed woman's acceptance, the orphan's ecstatic ascent, the coronation that follows a family's ruin—and adds the one element that none of its predecessors supplies in full: the protagonist's own choice of the death that completes her belonging.

William James's study of religious experience gives the structure its most general name. Conversion, James wrote, is the process, gradual or sudden, "by which a self hitherto divided, and consciously wrong inferior and unhappy, becomes unified and consciously right superior and happy, in consequence of its firmer hold upon religious realities" (James 1902). The definition fits Dani's arc with uncanny precision, down to its last word: the divided and unhappy self of the prologue becomes, in the finale, unified, right, and happy, in consequence of its firmer hold. James's sick soul, the melancholic who must be born twice, passes through despair into joy. But James also gave conversion a pragmatic test. Religious experiences, he argued, are to be judged not by their origins but by their fruits. The fruit of Dani's conversion is a man burned in a bear.

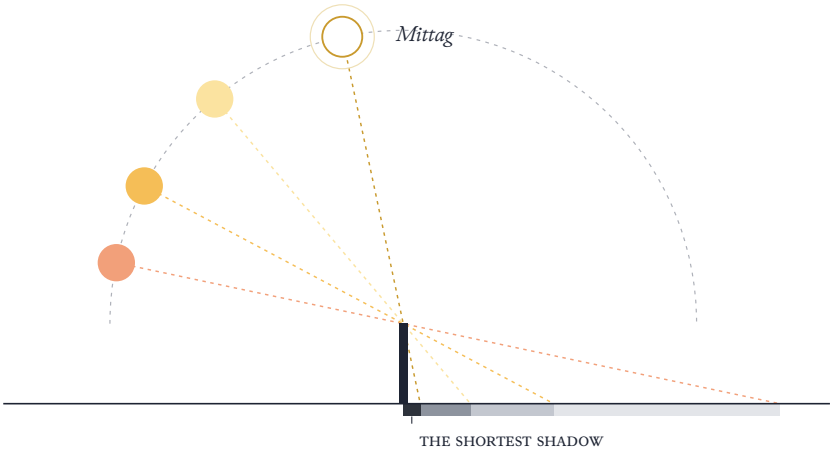
8.6

The Great Noon

Nietzsche's Circle and the Counterfeit Yes

The Hårga's metaphysics has a philosophical name. Siv explains the elders' leap by telling the guests that the community understands life as a circle, in which one thing falls so that another may rise (§2.4). Nietzsche called the thought of the circle the greatest weight. In *The Gay Science* he imagined a demon who steals into one's "einsamste Einsamkeit," one's loneliest loneliness, and announces that this life must be lived again and innumerable times more, every pain and every joy returning in the same sequence; and he asked whether one would curse the demon or answer that one had never heard anything more divine (Nietzsche [1882] 2001, §341). His formula for human greatness was *amor fati*: to want nothing to be other than it is, not forward, not backward, not in all eternity. And he placed the arrival of the thought at noon: "Mittag; Augenblick des kürzesten Schattens; Ende des längsten Irrthums," noon, the moment of the shortest shadow, the end of the longest error (Nietzsche 2005).

Midsommar's finale can be read as an answer to Nietzsche's demon. The demon comes to Dani, as Nietzsche said he would, in her loneliest loneli-



THE GREAT NOON Noon, the moment of the shortest shadow, the end of the longest error.

ness, the winter of the prologue. The Hårga's festival is held at the great noon of the northern year, the season of the shortest shadow. And the smile is a yes to the circle, an affirmation of everything that has happened, the deaths included, as the condition of what she has become. Read this way, the smile is *amor fati*: Dani wants nothing to be otherwise.

But Nietzsche would also have recognized the counterfeit. His affirmation is the act of a solitary self, earned in the loneliest loneliness against every consolation; the demon visits one person, and the yes is spoken alone. Dani's yes is choral. It is spoken within a community that has supplied its content, prepared its occasion, and surrounds it with acclamation. Nietzsche despised the herd and its morality of pity, and his critique of pity reads like a description of the mirroring chorus. Pity, he wrote in *The Antichrist*, is a depressive affect that multiplies suffering: "das Leiden selbst wird durch das Mitleiden ansteckend," suffering itself becomes contagious through pity (Nietzsche 2005, §7). The Hårga's chorus is pity organized, the contagion of suffering made into an institution (§5.3). Their circle is not the eternal recurrence of a self that wills its fate but the cycle of a herd that has abolished the self.

Dani's smile thus has the form of the overman's yes and the content of the herd's consent. It affirms the circle by surrendering to it, and so it is, in Nietzsche's own terms, *amor fati* counterfeited by belonging. The distinction is not merely Nietzschean pedantry. It marks the difference between an affirmation that a person could sustain alone, in the dark, after the festival has ended, and an affirmation that exists only so long as the chorus continues to sing. The film ends before we can learn which kind Dani's is. Its last image is a face at the great noon, and the shortest shadow is the one the smile does not cast.

◉

8.7

The Smile as Equation

Reading the Last Shot

The final sequence of *Midsommar* can now be read in full. The temple burns. Inside are nine bodies: four strangers already dead, two elders, two volunteers who begin to scream as their draught fails, and Christian, mute

and paralyzed inside the bear. Outside, the community answers the volunteers' screams with its own, writhing and wailing as though the flames were in their bodies, while the score rises toward an ecstatic climax. Dani, robed in the breathing gown of flowers, stands before the fire. Her face, held in close-up, passes through horror, grief, and bewilderment; tears run; and then, slowly, a smile forms. The screen cuts to black.

Every chapter of this dissertation has contributed a reading of that smile, and the readings do not compete; they coincide. The smile is euphoric anagnorisis, recognition issuing in joy (§1.9). It is Brynhildr's laugh at the death of the man who betrayed her, a laugh whose meaning was disputed in the saga as the smile's has been by the film's critics (§2.7). It is the third smile of the summer night, reserved for the sad, the sleepless, and the lonely (§3.8). It is the counter-gift that pays for membership (§4.6), and the face of a citizen of Omelas who has accepted the condition of her happiness (§4.9). It is the moment at which the chorus's echo becomes the heroine's own expression (§5.1). It is Inanna's eye of death fixed on the consort who did not mourn, and Janet's refusal to hold the bear (§6.1–6.2). It is the face of the only ethnographer who understood, at the moment she ceases to be an ethnographer (§7.8). And it is Freud's manic triumph, Klein's counterfeit reparation, Abraham and Torok's crypt, James's conversion, and Nietzsche's yes, counterfeited by belonging.

What unites these readings is the equation with which this dissertation began: the smile is the visible identity of being held and being burned. In Dani's face the two operations coincide. She is held at last, answered, crowned, given a family, at the precise moment that the man who failed to hold her is burned, and the holding is the burning, experienced from the side of the held. Her surname, Ardor, completes the equation. The woman who has carried a name for fire since the first scene becomes the fire's sovereign rather than its victim.

Two promises made earlier in the argument can now be kept. The suicide that Brynhildr committed and Dani does not (§2.7) returns in displaced form. What burns in the temple, besides Christian, is the self that Dani was, the bereaved and unheld young woman of the prologue, offered up, as Odin was offered, myself to myself (§2.2). The old self is the ninth offering's hidden twin, and the smile is the face of the new self over its pyre. And Medea's chariot (§6.7) arrives in the only form the film permits. The betrayed foreign woman, after the burning, is carried off by the sun:

not in a chariot drawn by dragons but in a smile, set in the white light of a sky that does not darken.

8.8

Conscription

The Spectator's Smile

Proposition V held that the film performs upon its spectators the operation it represents, and the final sequence is where the performance is completed. Everything in the film's form converges on the invitation to smile with Dani. The score swells for her and ignores the fire (§3.7). The composition centers her and surrounds her with acclamation (§3.4). The comedy has already withdrawn sympathy from the man who burns (§3.7). The chorus has already modeled the mimetic response the scene requires (§5.1). And the long humiliation of Dani's grief has prepared an audience to experience her release as its own. Many spectators accepted the invitation. The ending has had a popular afterlife as a fantasy of triumphant breakup, and Aster's own paratexts, which present the film as a fairy tale (§1.2), acknowledge the pleasure on offer.

The spectator who smiles with Dani has done, in miniature, what the Hårga do. Held by the film's form, mirrored, answered, and released, the spectator lets fall the man in the bear and the strangers in the temple. Chapter Two promised that the spectators would undergo, in reverse, the conversion that befell King Vikarr, whose mock sacrifice became real (§2.2). The promise is kept here. For the characters, a rite that seemed a performance became a death; for the audience, a death within the fiction becomes a performance, enjoyed. The spectator, like the Greek spectator in Nietzsche's account of tragedy, has joined the chorus (§3.7), and like the Hårga's chorus, the audience mirrors only the voices it can hear. Christian's silence reaches no one.

And yet the film does not leave its audience inside the chorus. Its form, which conscripts, also exposes. The spectator who has followed the film's evidence knows that Christian's infidelity was arranged by his hosts, that the visitors were brought to die, that the queen's choice was framed, and that the joy of the finale is financed by bodies. The film produces two

spectators at once: one who smiles with Dani and one who sees what the smile costs. That doubleness is the film's ethical achievement. It allows its audience to feel the pleasure of the sacrificial holding environment and to know its price in the same moment, and it leaves the decision about which of the two spectators to be, like the ninth offering, to a single person under the gaze of a crowd.

The conscription is therefore not a trap from which there is no exit but a test, and its form is the one this dissertation has called sacrificial hermeneutics (§1.4). The film asks its audience to feel the full force of being held, so that the audience may discover what it is willing to let fall in return. A spectator who never feels the pull of the ending has not understood the film; a spectator who feels nothing else has been absorbed by it. Between the two lies the position the film makes available and Dani cannot occupy: the position of one who is moved by the chorus and still hears the silence in the bear.

◉

8.9

The Missing Middle

Toward an Ethics of Holding

Proposition I held that the film's deepest horror is not that the Hårga exist but that nothing exists between them and the world Dani left. The film shows two forms of social life: a cold society in which grief is a burden, managed privately, rationed, and referred to professionals, and a hot community in which grief is answered completely and financed by sacrifice. It shows no third. But the archive this dissertation has assembled is full of the third, and its outlines can now be drawn.

The tradition of lament supplies its first feature. The women who wept over Patroclus wept with Briseis, each for her own sorrows (§5.2); the Maniat chorus answered the soloist by witnessing and confirming her truth; and de Martino's lament gave grief a traditional form that preserved the mourner's presence instead of dissolving it. A holding community, on this model, accompanies grief antiphonally, in many voices, with words, memory, and the freedom to accuse. The philosophy of fellow-feeling supplies the second. Adam Smith's concord, Scheler's fellow-feeling, and Stein's

empathy all insist on distance: another's grief is recognized as another's, and sympathy is a harmony of different voices rather than their unison (§5.3). The psychoanalytic tradition supplies the third. Winnicott's good-enough holding fails gradually, so that the held person comes to bear reality (§1.7); Klein's depressive position accepts guilt and loss instead of exporting them as triumph (§8.3); and Abraham and Torok's introjection puts loss into words (§8.4). Social theory supplies the fourth: Durkheim's intermediary groups, near enough to hold the individual and plural enough not to absorb her (§1.6); Plessner's tact, which approaches without fusing (§5.7); and Arendt's world between persons, in which disagreement remains possible. And the northern ballad supplies the fifth, in Janet's holding of Tam Lin: a love that holds the beloved through every monstrous transformation and returns him to himself, rather than consuming him (§6.1).

The middle term is not only a theoretical construction. Late modernity has produced its own attempts to restore public forms for death and grief without total community. The modern hospice movement, which Cicely Saunders inaugurated with the opening of St Christopher's Hospice in London in 1967, undertook to care for the dying person's total pain, physical, emotional, social, and spiritual, within a community of care that surrounds the dying and the bereaved without absorbing them. The death cafés that spread from London after 2011, informal gatherings at which strangers talk about mortality over tea and cake, and the movement of morticians and writers who have argued for a more open relation to death, have sought in their different ways to give mourning back a public place. None of these institutions asks anyone to let anyone fall. They are small, plural, and limited, which is to say that they are intermediary bodies in Durkheim's sense, and their modesty is their virtue.

Together these features define an ethics of holding that the film withholds: holding that keeps its distance, mourning that has its night, community that grieves in many voices, and care that acknowledges its failures as losses rather than exporting them as sacrifices. Its rule might be stated as the inversion of this dissertation's formula. In the economy of total belonging, to be held is to let fall. In the economy of good-enough holding, to be held is to be let go, gradually, into a world one can bear.

The lesson reaches beyond the film. The late-modern world described in Chapter One, lonely, therapeutic, privatized in its grief, and increas-

ingly organized by networks that mirror and amplify affect (§5.9), produces both the unheld subject and the communities that promise to hold her absolutely. *Midsommar* teaches a single question to ask of any community, religious, political, or digital, that promises never to let one grieve alone: whom does it let fall?

◉

8.10

Conclusion

The Ninth

This dissertation has argued that *Midsommar* is a philosophical fiction about the conditions under which a human being can be held, and about the price that total holding exacts. Its four claims can now be stated as established. The film stages, with sociological precision, the late-modern disappearance of any middle term between unheld isolation and devouring belonging. The Hårga's central technology is organized mimesis, a chorus that abolishes the distance on which sympathy depends. Their total holding is financed by the destruction of what cannot be mirrored: the outsider, the intellect, the voiceless victim. And the film conscripts its spectators into the community it depicts, as a mirroring chorus and as a college of interpreters, performing upon its audience the operation it represents. The claims converge on the formula with which the argument began: in the economy of total belonging, to be held is to let fall.

The argument leaves several paths open. The film's reception in Sweden, where its invented folklore meets a living midsummer tradition, deserves a study of its own, as does the relation between the Hårga and the contemporary revival of Nordic paganism. Aster's later films, which return obsessively to mothers, sons, and communities that will not let go, invite a reading of his work as a sustained inquiry into failed holding. The concept of sympathocracy may prove useful beyond the cinema, in the analysis of digital platforms and political movements organized around the amplification of shared feeling. And the film's spectators, whose smiles this dissertation has inferred from the form that solicits them, could be studied directly.

The dissertation comprises eight chapters, and §1.10 left the ninth to the reader. It can now be named. The Hårga's ninth offering was chosen by a single person between two candidates, under the gaze of a community, and the reader who has followed this argument faces a choice of the same form. One reading accepts the smile: it lets the film hold it, feels Dani's release as its own, and lets the man in the bear fall. The other keeps hold of what the smile costs: it remembers the voices the chorus could not mirror, counts the bodies in the temple, and refuses the unison. The film permits both, and this dissertation has tried to make the second possible without denying the force of the first.

The film's last gift is its last image, which is not an image at all. After the smile, the screen goes black. For two and a half hours *Midsommar* has denied its heroine and its audience the night: no darkness in which to grieve, no solitude in which to be alone with a loss, no shadow at the great noon of the Hårga's year. The cut to black restores what the white sun withheld. In that darkness, alone, the spectator can do what Dani could not. The spectator can mourn.



Works Cited

Texts

Abraham, Karl. [1924] 1927. "A Short Study of the Development of the Libido, Viewed in the Light of Mental Disorders." In *Selected Papers of Karl Abraham*, translated by Douglas Bryan and Alix Strachey. London: Hogarth Press.

Abraham, Nicolas, and Maria Torok. [1987] 1994. *The Shell and the Kernel: Renewals of Psychoanalysis*. Vol. 1. Edited and translated by Nicholas T. Rand. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Adam of Bremen. 1959. *History of the Archbishops of Hamburg-Bremen*. Translated by Francis J. Tschan. New York: Columbia University Press.

Adorno, Theodor W. [1951] 1991. "Freudian Theory and the Pattern of Fascist Propaganda." In *The Culture Industry: Selected Essays on Mass Culture*, edited by J. M. Bernstein. London: Routledge.

Adorno, Theodor W., and Max Horkheimer. [1947] 2002. *Dialectic of Enlightenment: Philosophical Fragments*. Edited by Gunzelin Schmid Noerr. Translated by Edmund Jephcott. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Aeschylus. 1926. *Agamemnon. Libation-Bearers. Eumenides. Fragments*. Translated by Herbert Weir Smyth. Loeb Classical Library 146. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Agamben, Giorgio. [1995] 1998. *Homo Sacer: Sovereign Power and Bare Life*. Translated by Daniel Heller-Roazen. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Agamben, Giorgio. [1998] 1999. *Remnants of Auschwitz: The Witness and the Archive*. Translated by Daniel Heller-Roazen. New York: Zone Books.

Agamben, Giorgio. [2007] 2011. *The Kingdom and the Glory: For a Theological Genealogy of Economy and Government*. Translated by Lorenzo Chiesa with Matteo Mandarini. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Alexiou, Margaret. 1974. *The Ritual Lament in Greek Tradition*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

American Psychiatric Association. 2022. *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders*. 5th ed., text rev. (DSM-5-TR). Washington, DC: American Psychiatric Association Publishing.

Andersen, Hans Christian. 1845. "De røde Skoe." In *Nye Eventyr*. Copenhagen: C. A. Reitzel.

Apollodorus. 1921. *The Library*. Translated by James George Frazer. 2 vols. Loeb Classical Library 121–22. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Arendt, Hannah. [1951] 1973. *The Origins of Totalitarianism*. New ed. New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich.

Arendt, Hannah. 1963. *On Revolution*. New York: Viking.

Ariès, Philippe. 1974. *Western Attitudes toward Death: From the Middle Ages to the Present*. Translated by Patricia M. Ranum. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press.

Ariès, Philippe. [1977] 1981. *The Hour of Our Death*. Translated by Helen Weaver. New York: Knopf.

Aristotle. 1995. *Poetics*. Edited and translated by Stephen Halliwell. Loeb Classical Library 199. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Asad, Talal, ed. 1973. *Anthropology and the Colonial Encounter*. London: Ithaca Press.

Aster, Ari. 2019. Interview on *Midsommar*. *HuffPost India*, October 2019. huffingtonpost.in.

Bachofen, Johann Jakob. [1861] 1967. *Myth, Religion, and Mother Right: Selected Writings of J. J. Bachofen*. Translated by Ralph Manheim. Bollingen Series 84. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Balázs, Béla. 1952. *Theory of the Film: Character and Growth of a New Art*. Translated by Edith Bone. London: Dennis Dobson.

Bartholin, Thomas. 1689. *Antiquitatum Danicarum de causis contemptae a Danis adhuc gentilibus mortis libri tres*. Copenhagen.

Bataille, Georges. [1949] 1988. *The Accursed Share: An Essay on General Economy*. Vol. 1, *Consumption*. Translated by Robert Hurley. New York: Zone Books.

Bataille, Georges. [1957] 1986. *Erotism: Death and Sensuality*. Translated by Mary Dalwood. San Francisco: City Lights.

Bataille, Georges. [1973] 1989. *Theory of Religion*. Translated by Robert Hurley. New York: Zone Books.

Bauman, Zygmunt. 2003. *Liquid Love: On the Frailty of Human Bonds*. Cambridge: Polity.

Benjamin, Walter. [1921] 1978. "Critique of Violence." In *Reflections: Essays, Aphorisms, Autobiographical Writings*, edited by Peter Demetz, translated by Edmund Jephcott. New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich.

Benjamin, Walter. [1933] 1978. "On the Mimetic Faculty." In *Reflections: Essays, Aphorisms, Autobiographical Writings*, edited by Peter Demetz, translated by Edmund Jephcott. New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich.

Benjamin, Walter. [1936] 1968. "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction." In *Illuminations*, edited by Hannah Arendt, translated by Harry Zohn, 217–51. New York: Schocken.

Benveniste, Émile. [1969] 1973. *Indo-European Language and Society*. Translated by Elizabeth Palmer. London: Faber and Faber.

Bergson, Henri. [1900] 1911. *Laughter: An Essay on the Meaning of the Comic*. Translated by Cloudesley Brereton and Fred Rothwell. London: Macmillan.

Bion, Wilfred R. 1962. *Learning from Experience*. London: Heinemann.

Bourdieu, Pierre. [1984] 1988. *Homo Academicus*. Translated by Peter Collier. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Broberg, Gunnar, and Nils Roll-Hansen, eds. 1996. *Eugenics and the Welfare State: Sterilization Policy in Denmark, Sweden, Norway, and Finland*. East Lansing: Michigan State University Press.

Burke, Edmund. 1757. *A Philosophical Enquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful*. London: R. and J. Dodsley.

Butler, Judith. 2004. *Precarious Life: The Powers of Mourning and Violence*. London: Verso.

Butler, Judith. 2009. *Frames of War: When Is Life Grievable?* London: Verso.

Byock, Jesse L., trans. 1990. *The Saga of the Volsungs: The Norse Epic of Sigurd the Dragon Slayer*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Byock, Jesse L., trans. 1998. *The Saga of King Hrolf Kraki*. London: Penguin.

Caesar, Julius. 1917. *The Gallic War*. Translated by H. J. Edwards. Loeb Classical Library 72. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Canetti, Elias. [1960] 1962. *Crowds and Power*. Translated by Carol Stewart. London: Gollancz.

Child, Francis James, ed. 1882–98. *The English and Scottish Popular Ballads*. 5 vols. Boston: Houghton, Mifflin.

Chion, Michel. [1990] 1994. *Audio-Vision: Sound on Screen*. Edited and translated by Claudia Gorbman. New York: Columbia University Press.

Clifford, James. 1983. "On Ethnographic Authority." *Representations* 2: 118–46.

Clifford, James, and George E. Marcus, eds. 1986. *Writing Culture: The Poetics and Politics of Ethnography*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Clover, Carol J. 1992. *Men, Women, and Chain Saws: Gender in the Modern Horror Film*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Collins, Suzanne. 2008. *The Hunger Games*. New York: Scholastic.

Coser, Lewis A. 1974. *Greedy Institutions: Patterns of Undivided Commitment*. New York: Free Press.

Creed, Barbara. 1993. *The Monstrous-Feminine: Film, Feminism, Psychoanalysis*. London: Routledge.

Dällenbach, Lucien. [1977] 1989. *The Mirror in the Text*. Translated by Jeremy Whiteley with Emma Hughes. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

de Boer, Jelle Zeilinga, John R. Hale, and Jeffrey Chanton. 2001. "New Evidence for the Geological Origins of the Ancient Delphic Oracle (Greece)." *Geology* 29 (8): 707–10.

Deleuze, Gilles. [1983] 1986. *Cinema 1: The Movement-Image*. Translated by Hugh Tomlinson and Barbara Habberjam. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.

de Martino, Ernesto. 1958. *Morte e pianto rituale nel mondo antico: Dal lamento pagano al pianto di Maria*. Turin: Einaudi.

De Quincey, Thomas. 1845. "Suspiria de Profundis: Being a Sequel to the Confessions of an English Opium-Eater." *Blackwood's Edinburgh Magazine*, March–July 1845.

Derrida, Jacques. [1972] 1981. "Plato's Pharmacy." In *Dissemination*, translated by Barbara Johnson. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Derrida, Jacques. [1991] 1992. *Given Time: I. Counterfeit Money*. Translated by Peggy Kamuf. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Derrida, Jacques. [1992] 1995. *The Gift of Death*. Translated by David Wills. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Derrida, Jacques. [1995] 1996. *Archive Fever: A Freudian Impression*. Translated by Eric Prenowitz. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Derrida, Jacques. [1997] 2000. *Of Hospitality: Anne Dufourmantelle Invites Jacques Derrida to Respond*. Translated by Rachel Bowlby. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Derrida, Jacques. 2000. "Hostipitality." Translated by Barry Stocker with Forbes Morlock. *Angelaki* 5 (3): 3–18.

Derrida, Jacques. [2003] 2005. *Rogues: Two Essays on Reason*. Translated by Pascale-Anne Brault and Michael Naas. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Diels, Hermann, and Walther Kranz, eds. 1951–52. *Die Fragmente der Vorsokratiker*. 6th ed. 3 vols. Berlin: Weidmann.

Dodds, E. R., ed. 1960. *Euripides: Bacchae*. 2nd ed. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Doniger, Wendy, with Brian K. Smith, trans. 1991. *The Laws of Manu*. London: Penguin.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. [1848] 1918. *White Nights and Other Stories*. Translated by Constance Garnett. London: Heinemann.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. [1880] 1990. *The Brothers Karamazov*. Translated by Richard Pevear and Larissa Volokhonsky. San Francisco: North Point Press.

Durkheim, Émile. [1893] 1984. *The Division of Labor in Society*. Translated by W. D. Halls. New York: Free Press.

Durkheim, Émile. [1897] 1951. *Suicide: A Study in Sociology*. Translated by John A. Spaulding and George Simpson. Edited by George Simpson. Glencoe, IL: Free Press.

Durkheim, Émile. [1912] 1995. *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*. Translated by Karen E. Fields. New York: Free Press.

Eco, Umberto, with Richard Rorty, Jonathan Culler, and Christine Brooke-Rose. 1992. *Interpretation and Overinterpretation*. Edited by Stefan Collini. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Ehrenreich, Barbara. 2006. *Dancing in the Streets: A History of Collective Joy*. New York: Metropolitan Books.

Eliade, Mircea. [1949] 1958. *Patterns in Comparative Religion*. Translated by Rosemary Sheed. London: Sheed and Ward.

Eliot, T. S. 1922. *The Waste Land*. New York: Boni and Liveright.

Eller, Cynthia. 2000. *The Myth of Matriarchal Prehistory: Why an Invented Past Won't Give Women a Future*. Boston: Beacon Press.

Esposito, Roberto. [1998] 2010. *Communitas: The Origin and Destiny of Community*. Translated by Timothy Campbell. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Esposito, Roberto. [2002] 2011. *Immunitas: The Protection and Negation of Life*. Translated by Zakiya Hanafi. Cambridge: Polity.

Euripides. 1994. *Cyclops. Alcestis. Medea*. Edited and translated by David Kovacs. Loeb Classical Library 12. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Fabian, Johannes. 1983. *Time and the Other: How Anthropology Makes Its Object*. New York: Columbia University Press.

Foucault, Michel. [1975] 1977. *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison*. Translated by Alan Sheridan. New York: Pantheon.

Frank, Roberta. 1984. "Viking Atrocity and Skaldic Verse: The Rite of the Blood-Eagle." *English Historical Review* 99 (391): 332–43.

Frazer, James George. 1906–15. *The Golden Bough: A Study in Magic and Religion*. 3rd ed. 12 vols. London: Macmillan.

Freud, Sigmund. [1913] 1955. *Totem and Taboo*. In *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, edited and translated by James Strachey, 13:1–161. London: Hogarth Press.

Freud, Sigmund. [1917] 1957. "Mourning and Melancholia." In *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, edited and translated by James Strachey, 14:237–58. London: Hogarth Press.

Freud, Sigmund. [1919] 1955. "The 'Uncanny.' " In *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, edited and translated by James Strachey, 17:217–56. London: Hogarth Press.

Freud, Sigmund. [1921] 1955. *Group Psychology and the Analysis of the Ego*. In *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, edited and translated by James Strachey, 18:65–143. London: Hogarth Press.

Freud, Sigmund. [1925] 1961. "A Note upon the 'Mystic Writing-Pad.' " In *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud*, edited and translated by James Strachey, 19:227–32. London: Hogarth Press.

Fukazawa Shichirō. [1956] 1961. "The Oak Mountain Song." In *The Old Woman, the Wife, and the Archer: Three Modern Japanese Short Novels*, translated by Donald Keene. New York: Viking.

Garland-Thomson, Rosemarie. 1997. *Extraordinary Bodies: Figuring Physical Disability in American Culture and Literature*. New York: Columbia University Press.

Geertz, Clifford. 1973. *The Interpretation of Cultures*. New York: Basic Books.

Geertz, Clifford. 1983. *Local Knowledge: Further Essays in Interpretive Anthropology*. New York: Basic Books.

Geijer, Erik Gustaf. 1811. "Vikingen" and "Odalbonden." *Iduna* 1. Stockholm.

Geijer, Erik Gustaf, and Arvid August Afzelius, eds. 1814–18. *Svenska folkvisor från forntiden*. 3 vols. Stockholm.

Genette, Gérard. [1972] 1980. *Narrative Discourse: An Essay in Method*. Translated by Jane E. Lewin. Ithaca: Cornell University Press.

Genette, Gérard. [1987] 1997. *Paratexts: Thresholds of Interpretation*. Translated by Jane E. Lewin. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Giddens, Anthony. 1991. *Modernity and Self-Identity: Self and Society in the Late Modern Age*. Cambridge: Polity.

Giddens, Anthony. 1992. *The Transformation of Intimacy: Sexuality, Love and Eroticism in Modern Societies*. Cambridge: Polity.

Gimbutas, Marija. 1974. *The Gods and Goddesses of Old Europe, 7000–3500 BC: Myths, Legends and Cult Images*. London: Thames and Hudson.

Ginzburg, Carlo. 1989. *Clues, Myths, and the Historical Method*. Translated by John

Tedeschi and Anne C. Tedeschi. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press.

Ginzburg, Carlo. [1989] 1991. *Ecstasies: Deciphering the Witches' Sabbath*. Translated by Raymond Rosenthal. New York: Pantheon.

Girard, René. [1972] 1977. *Violence and the Sacred*. Translated by Patrick Gregory. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press.

Girard, René. [1978] 1987. *Things Hidden since the Foundation of the World*. With Jean-Michel Oughourlian and Guy Lefort. Translated by Stephen Bann and Michael Metteer. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Girard, René. [1982] 1986. *The Scapegoat*. Translated by Yvonne Freccero. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press.

Goffman, Erving. 1961. *Asylums: Essays on the Social Situation of Mental Patients and Other Inmates*. Garden City, NY: Anchor Books.

Goodrick-Clarke, Nicholas. 1985. *The Occult Roots of Nazism: The Ariosophists of Austria and Germany, 1890–1935*. Wellingborough: Aquarian Press.

Gorer, Geoffrey. 1965. *Death, Grief, and Mourning in Contemporary Britain*. London: Cresset Press.

Graves, Robert. 1948. *The White Goddess: A Historical Grammar of Poetic Myth*. London: Faber and Faber.

Hallowell, A. Irving. 1926. "Bear Ceremonialism in the Northern Hemisphere." *American Anthropologist* 28 (1): 1–175.

Hamsun, Knut. [1894] 1998. *Pan*. Translated by Sverre Lyngstad. New York: Penguin.

Hatfield, Elaine, John T. Cacioppo, and Richard L. Rapson. 1994. *Emotional Contagion*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Hénaff, Marcel. [2002] 2010. *The Price of Truth: Gift, Money, and Philosophy*. Translated by Jean-Louis Morhange with Anne-Marie Feenberg-Dibon. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Hermann Pálsson and Paul Edwards, trans. 1968. *Gautrek's Saga and Other Medieval Tales*. London: University of London Press.

Herodotus. 1920. *The Persian Wars*. Vol. 1, *Books 1–2*. Translated by A. D. Godley. Loeb Classical Library 117. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Hirschman, Albert O. 1970. *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty: Responses to Decline in Firms, Organizations, and States*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Hobsbawm, Eric, and Terence Ranger, eds. 1983. *The Invention of Tradition*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Hochschild, Arlie Russell. 1983. *The Managed Heart: Commercialization of Human Feeling*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Homer. 1995. *Odyssey*. Translated by A. T. Murray. Revised by George E. Dimock. 2 vols. Loeb Classical Library 104–5. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Homer. 1999. *Iliad*. Translated by A. T. Murray. Revised by William F. Wyatt. 2 vols. Loeb Classical Library 170–71. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Hubert, Henri, and Marcel Mauss. [1899] 1964. *Sacrifice: Its Nature and Function*. Translated by W. D. Halls. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Hultgård, Anders. 2022. "The Sacrificial Festival at Uppsala: A Comparative Perspective." *Religionsvidenskabeligt Tidsskrift* 74: 600–621.

Hume, David. [1739–40] 2000. *A Treatise of Human Nature*. Edited by David Fate Norton and Mary J. Norton. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Hurston, Zora Neale. 1935. *Mules and Men*. Philadelphia: J. B. Lippincott.

Illouz, Eva. 2007. *Cold Intimacies: The Making of Emotional Capitalism*. Cambridge: Polity.

Illouz, Eva. 2008. *Saving the Modern Soul: Therapy, Emotions, and the Culture of Self-Help*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Jackson, Shirley. 1948. "The Lottery." *New Yorker*, June 26, 1948.

Jackson, Shirley. 1968. "Biography of a Story." In *Come Along with Me*, edited by Stanley Edgar Hyman. New York: Viking.

James, William. 1891. "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life." *International Journal of Ethics* 1 (3): 330–54.

James, William. 1902. *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study in Human Nature*. New York: Longmans, Green.

Johannes Magnus. 1554. *Historia de omnibus Gothorum Sueonumque regibus*. Rome.

Kant, Immanuel. [1790] 2000. *Critique of the Power of Judgment*. Edited by Paul Guyer. Translated by Paul Guyer and Eric Matthews. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Kant, Immanuel. [1795] 1991. "Perpetual Peace: A Philosophical Sketch." In *Political Writings*, edited by Hans Reiss, translated by H. B. Nisbet. 2nd ed. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Kanter, Rosabeth Moss. 1972. *Commitment and Community: Communes and Utopias in Sociological Perspective*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Kantorowicz, Ernst H. 1957. *The King's Two Bodies: A Study in Mediaeval Political Theology*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

King, David. 2005. *Finding Atlantis: A True Story of Genius, Madness, and an Extraordinary Quest for a Lost World*. New York: Harmony Books.

Klein, Melanie. 1940. "Mourning and Its Relation to Manic-Depressive States." *International Journal of Psycho-Analysis* 21: 125–53.

Kohut, Heinz. 1971. *The Analysis of the Self*. New York: International Universities Press.

Kracauer, Siegfried. [1927] 1995. "The Mass Ornament." In *The Mass Ornament: Weimar Essays*, translated and edited by Thomas Y. Levin. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Kramer, Adam D. I., Jamie E. Guillory, and Jeffrey T. Hancock. 2014. "Experimental Evidence of Massive-Scale Emotional Contagion through Social Networks." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 111 (24): 8788–90.

Krebs, Christopher B. 2011. *A Most Dangerous Book: Tacitus's Germania from the Roman Empire to the Third Reich*. New York: W. W. Norton.

Kristeva, Julia. [1980] 1982. *Powers of Horror: An Essay on Abjection*. Translated by Leon S. Roudiez. New York: Columbia University Press.

Kristeva, Julia. [1987] 1989. *Black Sun: Depression and Melancholia*. Translated by Leon S. Roudiez. New York: Columbia University Press.

Lacan, Jacques. [1949] 2006. "The Mirror Stage as Formative of the *I* Function as Revealed in Psychoanalytic Experience." In *Écrits: The First Complete Edition in English*, translated by Bruce Fink, 75–81. New York: Norton.

Lagerlöf, Selma. 1906–7. *Nils Holgerssons underbara resa genom Sverige*. 2 vols. Stockholm: Bonnier.

Larrington, Carolyne, trans. 2014. *The Poetic Edda*. Rev. ed. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Larsson, Carl. 1899. *Ett hem*. Stockholm: Bonnier.

Larsson, Lars. 2007. "The Iron Age Ritual Building at Uppåkra, Southern Sweden." *Antiquity* 81 (311): 11–25.

Le Bon, Gustave. [1895] 1896. *The Crowd: A Study of the Popular Mind*. London: T. Fisher Unwin.

Le Guin, Ursula K. 1973. "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas." In *New Dimensions 3*, edited by Robert Silverberg. Garden City, NY: Doubleday.

Levin, Ira. 1967. *Rosemary's Baby*. New York: Random House.

Lévi-Strauss, Claude. [1949] 1969. *The Elementary Structures of Kinship*. Rev. ed. Translated by James Harle Bell, John Richard von Sturmer, and Rodney Needham. Boston: Beacon Press.

Lévi-Strauss, Claude. 1955. "The Structural Study of Myth." *Journal of American Folklore* 68 (270): 428–44.

Linnaeus, Carl. 1758. *Systema Naturae*. 10th ed. Stockholm: Laurentius Salvius.

Lipps, Theodor. 1903. "Einfühlung, innere Nachahmung und Organempfindungen." *Archiv für die gesamte Psychologie* 1: 185–204.

List, Guido von. 1908. *Das Geheimnis der Runen*. Guido-List-Bücherei 1. Vienna.

Loraux, Nicole. [1990] 1998. *Mothers in Mourning*. Translated by Corinne Pache. Ithaca: Cornell University Press.

Lovecraft, H. P. 1928. "The Call of Cthulhu." *Weird Tales*, February 1928.

Lovecraft, H. P. 1936. *The Shadow over Innsmouth*. Everett, PA: Visionary Publishing.

Lundborg, Herman, and F. J. Linders, eds. 1926. *The Racial Characters of the Swedish Nation*. Uppsala: Almqvist & Wiksell.

MacCannell, Dean. 1973. "Staged Authenticity: Arrangements of Social Space in Tourist Settings." *American Journal of Sociology* 79 (3): 589–603.

MacCannell, Dean. 1976. *The Tourist: A New Theory of the Leisure Class*. New York: Schocken.

Malinowski, Bronislaw. 1922. *Argonauts of the Western Pacific*. London: George Routledge & Sons.

Malinowski, Bronislaw. 1967. *A Diary in the Strict Sense of the Term*. Translated by Norbert Guterman. New York: Harcourt, Brace & World.

Mauss, Marcel. 1921. "L'expression obligatoire des sentiments (rituels oraux funéraires australiens)." *Journal de psychologie normale et pathologique* 18.

Mauss, Marcel. 1924. "Gift, gift." In *Mélanges offerts à M. Charles Andler par ses amis et ses élèves*, 243–47. Strasbourg: Istra.

Mauss, Marcel. [1925] 1990. *The Gift: The Form and Reason for Exchange in Archaic Societies*. Translated by W. D. Halls. London: Routledge.

McNeill, William H. 1995. *Keeping Together in Time: Dance and Drill in Human History*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Merton, Robert K. 1948. "The Self-Fulfilling Prophecy." *Antioch Review* 8 (2): 193–210.

Mitchell, David T., and Sharon L. Snyder. 2000. *Narrative Prosthesis: Disability and the Dependencies of Discourse*. Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press.

Moynihan, Michael, and Didrik Søderlind. 1998. *Lords of Chaos: The Bloody Rise of the Satanic Metal Underground*. Venice, CA: Feral House.

Myrdal, Alva, and Gunnar Myrdal. 1934. *Kris i befolkningsfrågan*. Stockholm: Bonnier.

Nerval, Gérard de. 1854. "El Desdichado." In *Les Filles du feu*. Paris: D. Giraud.

Neumann, Erich. 1955. *The Great Mother: An Analysis of the Archetype*. Translated by Ralph Manheim. Bollingen Series 47. New York: Pantheon.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. [1872] 1999. *The Birth of Tragedy and Other Writings*. Edited by Raymond Geuss and Ronald Speirs. Translated by Ronald Speirs. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. [1882] 2001. *The Gay Science*. Edited by Bernard Williams. Translated by Josefine Nauckhoff. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. 2005. *The Anti-Christ, Ecce Homo, Twilight of the Idols, and Other Writings*. Edited by Aaron Ridley and Judith Norman. Translated by Judith Norman. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Nolan, William F., and George Clayton Johnson. 1967. *Logan's Run*. New York: Dial Press.

Olsen, Olaf. 1966. *Hørg, hov og kirke: Historiske og arkæologiske vikingetidsstudier*. Copenhagen: Gad.

Osler, William. 1906. "The Fixed Period." In *Aequanimitas, with Other Addresses to Medical Students, Nurses and Practitioners of Medicine*. 2nd ed. Philadelphia: Blakiston.

Ovid. 1984. *Metamorphoses*. Translated by Frank Justus Miller. Revised by G. P. Goold. 2 vols. Loeb Classical Library 42–43. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Panofsky, Erwin. [1927] 1991. *Perspective as Symbolic Form*. Translated by Christopher S. Wood. New York: Zone Books.

Pastoureau, Michel. [2007] 2011. *The Bear: History of a Fallen King*. Translated by George Holoch. Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press.

Plato. 1992. *Republic*. Translated by G. M. A. Grube. Revised by C. D. C. Reeve. Indianapolis: Hackett.

Plato. 1997. *Complete Works*. Edited by John M. Cooper. Indianapolis: Hackett.

Plessner, Helmuth. [1924] 1999. *The Limits of Community: A Critique of Social Radicalism*. Translated by Andrew Wallace. Amherst, NY: Humanity Books.

Plutarch. 1914. *Lives*. Vol. 1, *Theseus and Romulus; Lycurgus and Numa; Solon and Publicola*. Translated by Bernadotte Perrin. Loeb Classical Library 46. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Pringle, Heather. 2006. *The Master Plan: Himmler's Scholars and the Holocaust*. New York: Hyperion.

Procopius. 1919. *History of the Wars*. Vol. 3, *Books 5 and 6.1–15*. Translated by H. B. Dewing. Loeb Classical Library 107. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Propp, Vladimir. [1928] 1968. *Morphology of the Folktale*. Translated by Laurence Scott. 2nd ed. Revised by Louis A. Wagner. Austin: University of Texas Press.

Rabinow, Paul. 1977. *Reflections on Fieldwork in Morocco*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Ricoeur, Paul. [1960] 1967. *The Symbolism of Evil*. Translated by Emerson Buchanan. New York: Harper & Row.

Ricoeur, Paul. [1965] 1970. *Freud and Philosophy: An Essay on Interpretation*. Translated by Denis Savage. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Riefenstahl, Leni. [1973] 1974. *The Last of the Nuba*. New York: Harper & Row.

Rieff, Philip. 1966. *The Triumph of the Therapeutic: Uses of Faith after Freud*. New York: Harper & Row.

Robertson Smith, William. 1889. *Lectures on the Religion of the Semites: First Series, The Fundamental Institutions*. Edinburgh: Adam and Charles Black.

Rosaldo, Renato. 1989. *Culture and Truth: The Remaking of Social Analysis*. Boston: Beacon Press.

Rudbeck, Olof. 1679–1702. *Atland eller Manheim* [*Atlantica*]. 4 vols. Uppsala.

Sahagún, Bernardino de. [c. 1577] 1981. *Florentine Codex: General History of the Things of New Spain*. Book 2, *The Ceremonies*. Translated by Arthur J. O. Anderson and Charles E. Dibble. 2nd ed. Santa Fe: School of American Research; Salt Lake City: University of Utah.

Scheler, Max. [1923] 1954. *The Nature of Sympathy*. Translated by Peter Heath. London: Routledge & Kegan Paul.

Scovell, Adam. 2017. *Folk Horror: Hours Dreadful and Things Strange*. Leighton Buzzard: Auteur.

Sedgwick, Eve Kosofsky. 2003. *Touching Feeling: Affect, Pedagogy, Performativity*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Segal, Hanna. 1964. *Introduction to the Work of Melanie Klein*. London: Heinemann.

Sennett, Richard. 1977. *The Fall of Public Man*. New York: Knopf.

Seremetakis, C. Nadia. 1991. *The Last Word: Women, Death, and Divination in Inner Mani*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Shakespeare, William. 2010. *The Winter's Tale*. Edited by John Pitcher. Arden Shakespeare, Third Series. London: Methuen Drama.

Shakespeare, William. 2017. *A Midsummer Night's Dream*. Edited by Sukanta Chaudhuri. Arden Shakespeare, Third Series. London: Bloomsbury.

Smith, Adam. [1759] 1976. *The Theory of Moral Sentiments*. Edited by D. D. Raphael and A. L. Macfie. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Snorri Sturluson. 1964. *Heimskringla: History of the Kings of Norway*. Translated by Lee M. Hollander. Austin: University of Texas Press.

Snorri Sturluson. 1987. *Edda*. Translated by Anthony Faulkes. London: Dent.

Sontag, Susan. 1975. "Fascinating Fascism." *New York Review of Books*, February 6, 1975.

Sophocles. 1994. *Ajax. Electra. Oedipus Tyrannus*. Edited and translated by Hugh Lloyd-Jones. Loeb Classical Library 20. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Spencer, Baldwin, and F. J. Gillen. 1904. *The Northern Tribes of Central Australia*. London: Macmillan.

Stein, Edith. [1917] 1989. *On the Problem of Empathy*. Translated by Waltraut Stein. 3rd rev. ed. Washington, DC: ICS Publications.

Stern, Daniel N. 1985. *The Interpersonal World of the Infant: A View from Psychoanalysis and Developmental Psychology*. New York: Basic Books.

Strabo. 1917–32. *Geography*. Translated by Horace Leonard Jones. 8 vols. Loeb Classical Library. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Strindberg, August. 1998. *Miss Julie and Other Plays*. Translated by Michael Robinson. Oxford World's Classics. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Sunstein, Cass R. 2001. *Republic.com*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Tacitus. 1970. *Agricola. Germania. Dialogus*. Translated by M. Hutton and W. Peterson. Revised by R. M. Ogilvie, E. H. Warmington, and Michael Winterbottom. Loeb Classical Library 35. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Tarkovsky, Andrei. [1986] 1987. *Sculpting in Time: Reflections on the Cinema*. Translated by Kitty Hunter-Blair. Austin: University of Texas Press.

Tegnér, Esaias. 1825. *Frithiofs saga*. Stockholm.

Tennyson, Alfred. 1842. *Poems*. 2 vols. London: Edward Moxon.

Thietmar of Merseburg. 2001. *Ottonian Germany: The Chronicon of Thietmar of Merseburg*. Translated by David A. Warner. Manchester: Manchester University Press.

Tönnies, Ferdinand. [1887] 2001. *Community and Civil Society*. Edited by Jose Harris. Translated by Jose Harris and Margaret Hollis. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Trollope, Anthony. 1882. *The Fixed Period*. 2 vols. Edinburgh: William Blackwood and Sons.

Tronick, Edward, Heidelise Als, Lauren Adamson, Susan Wise, and T. Berry Brazelton. 1978. "The Infant's Response to Entrapment between Contradictory Messages in Face-to-Face Interaction." *Journal of the American Academy of Child Psychiatry* 17 (1): 1–13.

Truffaut, François. 1967. *Hitchcock*. With the collaboration of Helen G. Scott. New York: Simon and Schuster.

US Department of Health and Human Services, Office of the Surgeon General. 2023. *Our Epidemic of Loneliness and Isolation: The U.S. Surgeon General's Advisory on the Healing Effects of Social Connection and Community*. Washington, DC: US Department of Health and Human Services.

Verelius, Olof, ed. and trans. 1664. *Gothrici & Rolfi Westrogothiae regum historia lingua antiqua Gothica conscripta*. Uppsala: Henricus Curio.

Wagner, Richard. [1849] 1993. *The Art-Work of the Future and Other Works*. Translated by William Ashton Ellis. Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press.

Wagner, Roy. [1975] 1981. *The Invention of Culture*. Rev. ed. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Weber, Max. [1919] 1946. "Science as a Vocation." In *From Max Weber: Essays in Sociology*, translated and edited by H. H. Gerth and C. Wright Mills, 129–56. New York: Oxford University Press.

Weston, Jessie L. 1920. *From Ritual to Romance*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Williams, Linda. 1991. "Film Bodies: Gender, Genre, and Excess." *Film Quarterly* 44 (4): 2–13.

Wiltermuth, Scott S. 2012a. "Synchrony and Destructive Obedience." *Social Influence* 7 (2): 78–89.

Wiltermuth, Scott S. 2012b. "Synchronous Activity Boosts Compliance with Requests to Aggress." *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology* 48 (1): 453–56.

Wiltermuth, Scott S., and Chip Heath. 2009. "Synchrony and Cooperation." *Psychological Science* 20 (1): 1–5.

Wimsatt, W. K., Jr., and Monroe C. Beardsley. 1946. "The Intentional Fallacy." *Sewanee Review* 54 (3): 468–88.

Winnicott, D. W. 1953. "Transitional Objects and Transitional Phenomena." *International Journal of Psycho-Analysis* 34: 89–97.

Winnicott, D. W. 1960. "The Theory of the Parent-Infant Relationship." *International Journal of Psycho-Analysis* 41: 585–95.

Winnicott, D. W. [1962] 1965. "Ego Integration in Child Development." In *The Maturational Processes and the Facilitating Environment*. London: Hogarth Press.

Winnicott, D. W. [1963] 1965. "The Development of the Capacity for Concern." In *The Maturational Processes and the Facilitating Environment*. London: Hogarth Press.

Winnicott, D. W. [1967] 1971. "Mirror-Role of Mother and Family in Child Development." In *Playing and Reality*. London: Tavistock.

Winnicott, D. W. 1974. "Fear of Breakdown." *International Review of Psycho-Analysis* 1: 103–7.

Wittgenstein, Ludwig. [1967] 1979. *Remarks on Frazer's Golden Bough*. Edited by Rush Rhees. Translated by A. C. Miles. Retford: Brynmill.

Wolkstein, Diane, and Samuel Noah Kramer. 1983. *Inanna, Queen of Heaven and Earth: Her Stories and Hymns from Sumer*. New York: Harper & Row.

Zaremba, Maciej. 1999. *De rena och de andra: Om tvångssteriliseringar, rashygien och arvsynd*. Stockholm: DN.

Films, Series, and Artworks

Alfvén, Hugo. 1903. *Midsommarvaka* (Swedish Rhapsody No. 1), op. 19. Orchestral work.

Anderson, Michael, dir. 1976. *Logan's Run*. Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer.

Arbo, Peter Nicolai. 1872. *Åsgårdsreien*. Oil on canvas. Nasjonalmuseet, Oslo.

Aster, Ari, dir. 2018. *Hereditary*. A24.

Aster, Ari, dir. 2019. *Midsommar*. A24, Square Peg, and B-Reel Films. Theatrical cut and director's cut.

Aster, Ari, dir. 2023. *Beau Is Afraid*. A24.

Aster, Ari, dir. 2025. *Eddington*. A24.

Bathory. 1988. *Blood Fire Death*. Black Mark Production.

Bergman, Ingmar, dir. 1955. *Smiles of a Summer Night* [*Sommarnattens leende*]. Svensk Filmindustri.

Bergman, Ingmar, dir. 1957. *The Seventh Seal* [*Det sjunde inseglet*]. Svensk Filmindustri.

Bergman, Ingmar, dir. 1957. *Wild Strawberries* [*Smultronstället*]. Svensk Filmindustri.

Bergman, Ingmar, dir. 1960. *The Virgin Spring* [*Jungfrukällan*]. Svensk Filmindustri.

Bergman, Ingmar, dir. 1966. *Persona*. Svensk Filmindustri.

Bergman, Ingmar, dir. 1972. *Cries and Whispers* [*Viskningar och rop*]. Cinematograph.

Bergman, Ingmar, dir. 1973. *Scenes from a Marriage* [*Scener ur ett äktenskap*]. Sveriges Television.

Bruckner, David, dir. 2017. *The Ritual*. Entertainment One and Netflix.

Christensen, Benjamin, dir. 1922. *Häxan*. Svensk Filmindustri.

Deodato, Ruggero, dir. 1980. *Cannibal Holocaust*. F.D. Cinematografica.

Dreyer, Carl Theodor, dir. 1928. *The Passion of Joan of Arc* [*La Passion de Jeanne d'Arc*]. Société Générale des Films.

Dreyer, Carl Theodor, dir. 1943. *Day of Wrath* [*Vredens dag*]. Palladium.

Eggers, Robert, dir. 2015. *The Witch*. A24.

Fleischer, Richard, dir. 1973. *Soylent Green*. Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer.

Fleming, Victor, dir. 1939. *The Wizard of Oz*. Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer.

Hardy, Robin, dir. 1973. *The Wicker Man*. British Lion Films.

Hitchcock, Alfred, dir. 1959. *North by Northwest*. Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer.

Hooper, Tobe, dir. 1974. *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre*. Vortex.

Imamura Shōhei, dir. 1983. *The Ballad of Narayama* [*Narayama bushikō*]. Toei.

Kinoshita Keisuke, dir. 1958. *The Ballad of Narayama* [*Narayama bushikō*]. Shochiku.

Kubrick, Stanley, dir. 1980. *The Shining*. Warner Bros.

Kubrick, Stanley, dir. 1999. *Eyes Wide Shut*. Warner Bros.

Larsson, Carl. 1915. *Midvinterblot*. Oil on canvas. Nationalmuseum, Stockholm.

Munch, Edvard. 1893. *The Scream* [*Skrik*]. Nasjonalmuseet, Oslo.

Munch, Edvard. 1899–1900. *The Dance of Life* [*Livets dans*]. Oil on canvas. Nasjonalmuseet, Oslo.

Noujaim, Jehane, and Karim Amer, creators. 2020. *The Vow*. HBO.

Parajanov, Sergei, dir. 1965. *Shadows of Forgotten Ancestors*. Dovzhenko Film Studios.

Parajanov, Sergei, dir. 1969. *The Color of Pomegranates* [*Sayat Nova*]. Armenfilm.

Polanski, Roman, dir. 1968. *Rosemary's Baby*. Paramount Pictures.

Powell, Michael, and Emeric Pressburger, dirs. 1947. *Black Narcissus*. The Archers.

Powell, Michael, and Emeric Pressburger, dirs. 1948. *The Red Shoes*. The Archers.

Riefenstahl, Leni, dir. 1935. *Triumph of the Will* [*Triumph des Willens*]. Universum Film AG.

Stravinsky, Igor. 1913. *Le Sacre du printemps*. Ballet; scenario with Nicholas Roerich; choreography by Vaslav Nijinsky. First performed by the Ballets Russes, Théâtre des Champs-Élysées, Paris, May 29, 1913.

Tarkovsky, Andrei, dir. 1966. *Andrei Rublev*. Mosfilm.

Tarkovsky, Andrei, dir. 1986. *The Sacrifice* [*Offret*]. Swedish Film Institute and Argos Films.

Visconti, Luchino, dir. 1971. *Death in Venice* [*Morte a Venezia*]. Warner Bros.

Wagner, Richard. 1876. *Der Ring des Nibelungen*. First complete performance, Bayreuth Festspielhaus, August 1876.

Way, Chapman, and Maclain Way, dirs. 2018. *Wild Wild Country*. Netflix.

Weir, Peter, dir. 1975. *Picnic at Hanging Rock*. Picnic Productions.

Wheatley, Ben, dir. 2011. *Kill List*. Warp X and Rook Films.

Zorn, Anders. 1897. *Midsommardans*. Oil on canvas. Nationalmuseum, Stockholm.

Keywords

Midsommar; Ari Aster; folk horror; sacrificial holding environment; sympathocracy; holding environment; D. W. Winnicott; mirror-role; affect attunement; phonic holding; containment; ritual lament; Émile Durkheim; altruistic suicide; fatalistic suicide; anomie; piacular rites; obligatory expression of sentiments; ättestupa; Adam of Bremen; Uppsala; Old Norse religion; Swedish Gothicism; invented tradition; comparative mythopoetics; sacrificial hermeneutics; sacrifice; Georges Bataille; René Girard; gift; hospitality; immunity; Roberto Esposito; organized mimesis; emotional contagion; fellow-feeling; grievability; Apollonian dread; daylight horror; euphoric anagnorisis; manic reparation; melancholia; black sun; sacral kingship; May Queen; *The Wicker Man*; Omelas; high-control groups; greedy institutions; commitment therapies; disenchantment; *sacrificium intellectus*; loneliness; late modernity; pure relationship; emotional labor; palimpsest; archive; Gothicism; Hávamál; Odin; runes; Gautreks saga; Olof Verelius;

Olof Rudbeck; Hårgalåten; maypole; Le Sacre du printemps; Nerthus; valkyrie; Brynhildr; Guðrún; Völsunga saga; Gesamtkunstwerk; Skansen; staged authenticity; Carl Larsson; folkhem; racial biology; senicide; Uppsala; Apollonian; Dionysian; Friedrich Nietzsche; Marsyas; prolepsis; mise en abyme; Vladimir Propp; symmetry; chiasmus; panopticism; environment-mother; body genres; anempathetic music; laughter; close-up; Carl Theodor Dreyer; Ingmar Bergman; Andrei Tarkovsky; Sergei Parajanov; Stanley Kubrick; Edvard Munch; the uncanny; pharmakon; pharmakos; Thargelia; scapegoat; Balder; James George Frazer; Ludwig Wittgenstein; Hubert and Mauss; substitution; totem meal; Sigmund Freud; mimetic desire; unanimity minus one; René Girard; general economy; Toxcatl; potlatch; hau; counter-gift; recognition; hostipitality; xenia; Circe; communitas; immunitas; munus; autoimmunity; homo sacer; bare life; "The Lottery"; ritual lament; antiphony; Ernesto de Martino; Renato Rosaldo; Nicole Loraux; sympathy; concord; unison; David Hume; Adam Smith; Max Scheler; Edith Stein; emotional contagion; lamenting pack; Elias Canetti; muscular bonding; synchrony; mass ornament; fascinating fascism; Thingspiel; tact; Helmuth Plessner; compassion; destructive Gemeinschaft; Judith Butler; echo chamber; Tam Lin; dying god; Inanna; Dumuzi; Freyr; Oak King; Robert Graves; mother-right; Johann Jakob Bachofen; Oresteia; Erinyes; Midsummer Bride; the king's two bodies; reign and government; glory; the bear; Michel Pastoureau; iyomante; the fool; A Midsummer Night's Dream; The Bacchae; Agave; Miss Julie; August Strindberg; Great Mother; abjection; Final Girl; rape-revenge; ethnography; denial of coevalness; Johannes Fabian; reverse anthropology; Clifford Geertz; Bronislaw Malinowski; ethnographic authority; aura; cult value; exhibition value; Walter Benjamin; mythic violence; oracle; Delphi; self-fulfilling prophecy; incest prohibition; Claude Lévi-Strauss; narrative prosthesis; positioned subject; Cannibal Holocaust; The Ritual; H. P. Lovecraft; academic field; Pierre Bourdieu; Electra; Medea; mourning and melancholia; work of mourning; manic defense; Melanie Klein; Hanna Segal; introjection and incorporation; Nicolas Abraham; Maria Torok; conversion; William James; eternal recurrence; amor fati; great noon; The Shadow over Innsmouth; Rosemary's Baby; The Witch; Kill List; prolonged grief disorder; ethics of holding